

**Open Translator's Notes** is based on: Open Translator's Notes, [SIL International](#), 2024, which is licensed under a [CC BY-SA 4.0 license](#).

This PDF version is provided under the same license.

# Colossians

## Colossians 1:1

### Section 1:1–2: Paul greeted the Colossian believers

#### 1:1a

**Paul,**

- ¶ I, Paul, am writing this letter.
- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul.

**Paul:** Greek people usually began letters by just writing their name, as Paul did here. Then they would state the name of the person to whom they were writing. Today people do not usually start letters in this way, so you may need to use a greeting that is more natural in your language. For example, you could use a phrase in which Paul refers to himself in the first person. For example:

I, Paul, write this letter.

This letter is from me, Paul,

#### 1:1b

**an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God,**

- God himself chose me to represent Christ Jesus.
- I am an apostle of Christ Jesus because God chose me to be an apostle.

**apostle:** An apostle was a person whom Jesus had appointed or commissioned to represent him and to teach his message with authority. See the term “apostle” in the glossary and in KBT. If the term you choose for apostle means simply “messenger,” make sure that it does not refer to a person who only delivers a message and then has no further responsibility for the message. An apostle not only taught the message about Christ, but he also had the authority to act on behalf of Christ. He was an ambassador for Christ.

**Christ Jesus:** In this letter Paul usually referred to Jesus by the name Christ Jesus or “Christ.” He used “Jesus Christ” only once (1:3). The Greek word *christos*, which is written “Christ” in English, means “Messiah.” However, by the time Paul wrote this letter, people were already using the word “Christ” as another name for Jesus, rather than a title. Most scholars, therefore, believe that there is no difference in meaning between the terms “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ.”

Most English versions (as well as other national language translations) translate “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” using the same order as the Greek text

in each instance. Throughout the Display, the names “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ” follow the word order of the Greek text.

But if the people who read your translation would be confused by the different order of the names, you may decide to use the more familiar order “Jesus Christ” here and in the other places where the Greek text has “Christ Jesus.”

**by the will of God:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates the will of God means what God wants and desires. Paul wanted to clarify that when he called himself an apostle, it was not because he had decided that for himself. It was God who had chosen him to be an apostle of Christ Jesus.

Paul was emphasizing his authority by using the phrases “apostle of Christ Jesus” and by the will of God together. You should connect these two phrases in a way that shows this emphasis. The SSA has expressed the relationship between the two phrases as:

an apostle who represents/was-appointed-by  
Christ Jesus, because God chose me in order that  
I should be an apostle

#### 1:1c

**and Timothy our brother,**

- I, together with Timothy who is our<sup>(incl)</sup> Christian brother, greet you.
- I am here with our<sup>(incl)</sup> Christian brother, Timothy.

**Timothy:** Timothy was with Paul when he was writing this letter. One possible reason his name was mentioned here may be that Paul dictated the letter to Timothy and Timothy wrote down what he said, but we do not know that for certain. Biblical scholars generally agree that Paul alone was the author of the letter and that Timothy did not contribute to the content.

One way you could translate this part of the verse to avoid implying that Timothy was a co-author would be to say:

I, Paul, together with our<sup>(incl)</sup> brother Timothy, am  
sending this letter to you...

**brother:** Since God is the Father of all Christians, all Christians are like brothers and sisters. Therefore, people in the NT frequently use the word brother when referring to a fellow Christian. You should translate this term literally in your translation if possible. However, in some languages the word brother can only refer to a blood relative. If this is a problem in

your language, you could use a term meaning “fellow Christian.”

## Colossians 1:2

### Section 1:1–2: Paul greeted the Colossian believers

#### 1:2a

#### To the saints and faithful brothers in Christ at Colossae:

- I am writing this letter to you who are God’s people and who are our<sup>(excl)</sup> faithful Christian brothers, united to Christ, in the town of Colossae.
- I am sending this letter to you who trust in Christ and are our<sup>(excl)</sup> fellow believers in the town of Colossae. You have dedicated yourselves to God and you are faithful to Christ.

**saints and faithful brothers in Christ:** The phrase saints and faithful brothers does not refer to two different groups of people. It refers to a single group: people who have dedicated themselves to God and who are faithful to Christ.

**saints:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints refers to all God’s people, that is, all true believers. It does not just refer to Christians who have done something special or whom the church today calls saints. Possible ways to translate saints in this verse are:

- you<sup>(plur)</sup> who are devoted to God
- you<sup>(plur)</sup> who are set apart for God
- you<sup>(plur)</sup> who belong to God
- God’s people.

See “holy,” sense A3a in KBT and meaning 1 in the glossary for more information.

**faithful brothers:** This referred to all the Christians in Colossae, both male and female. If the word you use in your language for brothers refers only to men, you should consider saying “brothers and sisters,” or using a neutral term like “relatives.” See also the note in 1:1c.

**faithful:** This does not mean that these people were faithful to Paul. It means that they were faithful and loyal to Christ.

**in Christ:** This is a phrase that Paul used in all his letters. It means “united to Christ” or “trusting completely in Christ.” It refers to the close relationship which Christians have with Christ and therefore with one another. It is often a difficult phrase to translate. Here “brothers in Christ” means “Christian brothers,” or “fellow believers in Christ.”

#### 1:2b

#### Grace and peace to you from God our Father.

- I pray that God our<sup>(incl)</sup> Father will continually help you and will cause you to have peace.
- May God who is our<sup>(incl)</sup> heavenly Father always bless you and cause you to have inner peace.

**Grace and peace to you from God our Father:** In this greeting, Paul was expressing a strong desire or a prayer. In Greek, this part of the verse has no verb, but in your language you may need to supply a verb. For example:

I/We<sup>(excl)</sup> pray/hope that you will receive...

May God our Father give you...

**Grace:** In many passages in the NT the Greek word usually translated Grace describes something that God does for sinful people. It means: “God helps people because he has compassion on them even though they do not deserve his help.” However in this verse it is part of a common Greek greeting and has a more general meaning. Therefore, you do not need to try and express the specific meaning of Grace that is described above. See “grace,” sense A1 in KBT and meaning 1 in the glossary for more information.

Some ways you could express this using a verb are:

May God our<sup>(incl)</sup> Father treat you kindly

We<sup>(excl)</sup> pray that God our<sup>(incl)</sup> Father will help you in every way

We<sup>(excl)</sup> ask God our<sup>(incl)</sup> Father to bless you because of his kindness

**peace:** God causes his people to be at peace with him and with one another. The meaning of the Greek word includes not only inward peace of mind, but also good health and prosperity.

**you:** Throughout the letter the word you is always plural and refers to the Colossian believers. The only exception is in 4:17, where Paul was sending a personal message to Archippus.

## Colossians 1:3

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God's people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

#### Paragraph 1:3–8

The theme in this section is that Paul continually thanked God for the Colossian Christians, because they had trusted in Christ Jesus and because they loved their fellow Christians.

#### 1:3

**We always thank God, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, when we pray for you,**

- ¶ Every time we<sup>(excl)</sup> pray for you, we<sup>(excl)</sup> thank God, who is the Father of our<sup>(incl)</sup> Lord Jesus Christ, for you,
- ¶ Every time we<sup>(excl)</sup> pray for you, we<sup>(excl)</sup> thank God for you. God is the Father of our<sup>(incl)</sup> Lord Jesus Christ.

**We:** Paul said We here instead of “I” because he was including Timothy, and perhaps others who were with him.

**the Father:** God is not the father of Jesus in the way that a man is the biological father of a child. The use of the word Father is figurative and is used to express the unique and close relationship between God and Jesus. Calling God Father and Jesus “God’s Son” are important figures of speech throughout the NT, and you should keep these figures in your translation. If it is really impossible for you to use these figures of speech in your language, you must discuss other possibilities with your Translation Consultant to be sure you have chosen the best alternative.

## Colossians 1:4

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God's people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

#### Paragraph 1:3–8

The theme in this section is that Paul continually thanked God for the Colossian Christians, because they had trusted in Christ Jesus and because they loved their fellow Christians.

#### 1:4a

**because we have heard about your faith in Christ Jesus**

- because we<sup>(excl)</sup> have heard news about you. Epaphras told us<sup>(excl)</sup> that you believe in Christ Jesus,
- We<sup>(excl)</sup> thank God for you because we<sup>(excl)</sup> have heard that you trust in Christ Jesus,

**because:** Here Paul gave some specific reasons why he thanked God for the Colossian Christians.

**we have heard:** In 1:8 Paul wrote that it was Epaphras who had told him about the Colossian Christians. He had probably heard about the church in Colossae from other people also. In some languages it is necessary to say who had told Paul about the Colossians. If this is necessary in your language, you could say “Epaphras has told us...” based on 1:8.

**faith in Christ Jesus:** In many languages it is necessary to translate faith as a verb. One way to do this is:

you trust/believe in Christ Jesus

#### 1:4b

**and your love for all the saints—**

- and that you love all God's people.

**your love for all the saints:** There are several Greek words that can be translated “love” in English. The one in this verse is *agapē*. It was a word that the Greeks who lived when the New Testament was written did not often use. However, the early Christians began to use it to mean the sort of love about which Jesus taught. *Agapē* is more than a purely emotional feeling or attraction (which is often what people who speak English mean when they talk about “love” in a non-biblical context). It means loving people the way God does: caring for them, helping them, and encouraging them, without expecting them to respond in the same way or repay the kindness.

In many languages it is necessary to translate the noun love as a verb. One way to do this is:

that you love all the saints.

**saints:** This is the same word as in 1:2a. See the note there. One way to translate it here is “God’s people.” Many modern English versions translate it in this way (see GNT, CEV, GW, NCV, NLT, REB).

#### General Comment about 1:4

In some languages, people use direct quotes when writing about what someone else said. If this is true in your language, you may want to do this in 1:4. For example:

We<sup>(excl)</sup> thank God for you, because people have told us: “The believers in Colossae really believe in Christ Jesus, and they love all God’s people.”

#### General Comment about 1:3–4

In some languages it may be more natural to put 1:4 before 1:3. One way to do this would be:

<sup>4a</sup> We have heard that you trust in Christ Jesus <sup>4b</sup> and that you love all of God’s people. <sup>3</sup> Therefore, when we pray for you, we always thank God, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, for you.

## Colossians 1:5

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God’s people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

#### Paragraph 1:3–8

The theme in this section is that Paul continually thanked God for the Colossian Christians, because they had trusted in Christ Jesus and because they loved their fellow Christians.

#### 1:5a

**the faith and love proceeding from the hope stored up for you in heaven,**

- You trust in Christ Jesus and love God’s people like that because you confidently expect the reward that God has prepared for you in heaven.
- This is true about you because you are confidently waiting for the time that God will give you all the blessings that he has prepared for you in heaven.

#### 1:5b

**of which you have already heard**

- You already heard about the wonderful things that God has promised to do for you
- You already heard about this

#### 1:5c–6a

**in the word of truth, the gospel that has come to you.**

- when people first came to you and told you the true message about Christ, that is, the good news about Christ Jesus.
- when people came to your city and told you the gospel about Christ Jesus, which is God’s true message.

#### 1:5a–b

**the faith and love proceeding from the hope stored up for you in heaven, of which you have already heard:**

The Greek text does not include the words the faith and love in this verse, but begins “because of the hope” (see RSV). The BSB has repeated the words faith and love from 1:4 to clarify the connection between 1:4 and 1:5. Paul was saying that the Colossian believers trusted in Christ Jesus and loved other Christians because of the hope they had.

**hope:** In English the word hope is more like a “wish.” When someone says, “I hope it doesn’t rain,” he means that he is uncertain: he doesn’t want it to rain, but he doesn’t know if it will or not. But this is not the biblical meaning of hope. The Greek word *elpis*, that the BSB translates hope, means “to confidently expect something to happen.”

Full Christian hope is this:

1. Christ will descend from heaven.
2. He will raise to life the Christians who have died, and he will gather them along with those who are still alive in order to bring them all together to meet him.
3. All these believers will receive new bodies.
4. God will accept them all as his perfect people.
5. They all will live forever with God and Christ in heaven.

When Paul spoke about “the hope stored up for you in heaven,” he was referring to all these wonderful things that Christians are waiting for, the things that God has prepared for his people in heaven.

**stored up:** The Greek word *apokeimai* that the BSB translates stored up means, “to put away, store up,” like a farmer who stores grain in a barn so he can use it in the future. Paul was not saying that God had stored up literal “things” like money or food, but he was referring to the reward which God has for his people and which he is “keeping safe” for them. The UBS Handbook (page 11) suggests one way to translate this:

God is keeping safe for you in heaven the reward that you are confident that he will give you.

### 1:5c–6a

**the word of truth, the gospel:** Paul was not writing about two different things. The word of truth and the gospel refer to the same thing. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the true message, which is the good news (CEV)

**the word of truth:** This means the true message about Christ. In these verses, Paul began to emphasize that the message about Christ that the Colossians had originally been taught was the only true message about Christ. He emphasized this because some people in Colossae had begun to teach false things about Christ.

**gospel:** The Greek word *euangelion* that the BSB translates gospel means “good news.” After Jesus’

death and resurrection, the first Christians soon began to use *euangelion* to mean specifically “God’s message about Christ.” If you translate it using a general phrase like “good news,” check that the people who use your translation will understand that the term refers specifically to the message about Christ. See “gospel” in KBT and in the glossary.

**that has come to you:** Although this expression is actually part of 1:6, it is joined grammatically to 1:5.

In some languages, it is not possible to talk about news “coming” to a place or to people. If this is the case in your language, you can say something like:

the message that was first told to you

the message that was first brought to you

In this verse, Paul did not say who brought the gospel. In 1:7, Paul said that Epaphras taught them the gospel. However, Epaphras may not have been the only teacher who brought the gospel to Colossae. So if you need to say who brought the message in your translation, it is better to say something general like. For example:

people came and told you...

### General Comment about 1:5a–6a

It may be helpful in your translation to change the order of the parts of 1:5a–6a. The GNT has done that in this way:

When the true message, the good news, first came to you, you heard about the hope it offers. So your faith and love are based on what you hope for, which is kept safe for you in heaven.

Another way might be to say:

When people first came to you and told you the true message, the good news about Christ, you heard it and believed it. Now you are expectantly waiting for the blessings that God has planned to give you in heaven. Because of this, you are trusting in Christ Jesus and love all God’s people.

## Colossians 1:6

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God's people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

#### Paragraph 1:3–8

The theme in this section is that Paul continually thanked God for the Colossian Christians, because they had trusted in Christ Jesus and because they loved their fellow Christians.

#### 1:6b

**All over the world this gospel is bearing fruit and growing,**

- Everywhere more and more people are believing this gospel and changing the way they behave in order to please God.
- In many places people are hearing this message about Christ, and more and more people are becoming Christians and behaving in a way that pleases God.

**All over the world:** This is an exaggeration used to emphasize that the gospel had spread to many places in the world. Such an exaggeration is called hyperbole. If you do not use hyperbole in your language, you could translate this part of the verse:

to people in many places

**bearing fruit and growing:** This is a figure of speech. Paul said that the gospel was bearing fruit and growing like a tree or plant produces a crop and grows.

**bearing fruit:** This probably refers to the way a person changes after he becomes a Christian.

**growing:** This refers to the way the message about Jesus was spreading throughout the world and more and more people were believing it.

You need to check if these figures of speech make sense in your language. If not, you could change them to a simile, like this:

A healthy plant continues to produce good fruit and grow bigger. In the same way the message about Christ is causing many people to behave as God wants them to, and it is causing more and more people to believe the message.

In some modern English versions, the translators have removed the figure of speech completely. For example:

It is producing results and spreading all over the world. (GW)

#### 1:6c

**just as it has been doing among you since the day you heard it**

- This is exactly what has been happening among you from the time that you first heard the message

#### 1:6d

**and truly understood the grace of God.**

- and fully understood the true message about how kind/gracious God is.
- and you understood the truth that God graciously/freely forgives the sins of those who trust in Christ.

**and truly understood the grace of God:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as truly is literally “in truth.” There are two different ways to understand what this means:

1. In this verse most English versions understand it to mean “the truth about the grace of God.” Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

[you] came to know it [the grace of God] as it really is (GNT)

you came to know what God's kindness truly means (GW) (GNT, GW, )

1. In some English versions, it means

**the grace of God:** Here Paul used the word grace as a synonym for the gospel. This is the message that God graciously/freely saves those who trust in Christ.

In many languages the term the grace of God must be translated as a clause. For example:

how kind/gracious God is

See “grace” in KBT and meaning 2 in the glossary for further help.

### General Comment about 1:6b–d

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder 1:6b–d. One way to do this would be:

When you heard that God would freely forgive you if you trusted in Christ, you understood and believed God’s message as it really is. Now you are behaving in a way that pleases God. In the same way, people in many places have heard and believed this message and they are behaving in a way that pleases God. So the message is spreading to others.

## Colossians 1:7

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God’s people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

### Paragraph 1:3–8

The theme in this section is that Paul continually thanked God for the Colossian Christians, because they had trusted in Christ Jesus and because they loved their fellow Christians.

#### 1:7a

#### You learned it from Epaphras,

- It was Epaphras who taught you this message.
- This is what Epaphras taught you.

**You learned it from Epaphras:** The word it refers back to “the word of truth, the gospel” in 1:5. In some languages, it may be necessary to say “Epaphras taught this message to you” rather than You learned it from Epaphras.

**Epaphras:** Epaphras was the main person who had taught the message about Christ to the Colossians.

#### 1:7b

#### our beloved fellow servant,

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> love him. He is a Christian worker like we<sup>(excl)</sup> are.
- He serves Christ just as we<sup>(excl)</sup> do, and we<sup>(excl)</sup> love him.

**our:** The word our refers to Paul and Timothy and perhaps other Christians who were with them.

**fellow servant:** When Paul said Epaphras was his fellow servant (the Greek is literally “co-slave”), he meant that Epaphras was Christ’s slave just as Paul and Timothy were.

In 1:5–7 Paul emphasized that God had given only one true message—the message about Christ that Epaphras had originally taught to the Colossians. In 1:7 Paul emphasized that just as he and Timothy were messengers of Jesus, Epaphras was also. So Paul was saying that if the Colossian Christians rejected Epaphras, they would also be rejecting him and Timothy.

#### 1:7c

#### who is a faithful minister of Christ on our behalf,

- He has faithfully served Christ among you as our<sup>(excl)</sup> representative.
- He represented us<sup>(excl)</sup> when he served Christ by teaching you the gospel.

**faithful minister of Christ:** In 1:7b Paul called Epaphras his “fellow servant.” Here in 1:7c he called him a minister of Christ. The word minister means “worker, servant.” The words “servant” in 1:7b and minister in 1:7c translate different Greek words, but they have similar meanings.

**faithful:** This means that Epaphras was reliable. He continued to work for Christ—he didn’t give up when he faced pressure.

**on our behalf:** Some Greek manuscripts say, “on our behalf,” and others say, “on your behalf.” English versions differ as to which manuscript they follow:

1. The BSB says “on our behalf.” This means that Paul was saying that Epaphras faithfully served Christ among the Colossians as a representative of Paul

(and Timothy). (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NCV, NET, NJB, REB)

2. Other versions say “on your behalf.” This can mean one of two things:
3. that Epaphras was serving Christ by teaching the Colossians, that is, “for the Colossians.” (KJV, CEV).
4. that Epaphras was faithfully serving Christ by being a representative of the Colossians to Paul (and Timothy). (GW, NLT).

The first option (1) is recommended because it has the best support among the Greek manuscripts. It also fits the context, since Paul was emphasizing Epaphras’ work among the Colossians.

## Colossians 1:8

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God’s people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

#### Paragraph 1:3–8

The theme in this section is that Paul continually thanked God for the Colossian Christians, because they had trusted in Christ Jesus and because they loved their fellow Christians.

#### 1:8

#### and who also informed us of your love in the Spirit.

- And it was he who told us<sup>(excl)</sup> how much the Holy Spirit has enabled you to love God’s people.
- He came here and told us<sup>(excl)</sup> how God’s Spirit is working in you to cause you to love all God’s people.

**your love:** In many languages it will be necessary to state whom the Colossian Christians loved. There are three possibilities:

1. They loved other believers (as in 1:4).
2. More specifically, they loved one another.

#### 3. They loved Paul and Timothy.

If you need to include the object of their love in your language, it is recommended that you follow the first option (1). This verse probably refers back to 1:4 where Paul wrote that the Colossians loved all God’s people. The first option includes the second option, because if they loved all believers they also loved one another.

**in the Spirit:** This refers to the Holy Spirit. If the word Spirit by itself might have an unclear or negative meaning in your language, you could say “God’s Spirit” or use your term for “Holy Spirit.” Paul was saying that the Colossians loved others “by means of” the Holy Spirit, that is, it was the Holy Spirit who enabled/caused them to love others. Here is another way to express this:

the love that the Holy Spirit has given you (GNT)

## Colossians 1:9

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God’s people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

#### Paragraph 1:9–12

Theme: Paul was constantly asking God to help the Colossians to know all that God wanted them to do.

In these verses Paul was not actually praying. Rather, he was telling the Colossians what he usually prayed for them. In Greek these four verses are one long sentence. You will probably need to divide this sentence into several sentences in your translation, as most English versions do. The main part of the long sentence is “we have not stopped praying for you and asking God...” (1:9a–b). The rest of these verses contain a list of what Paul was praying for the Colossians.

Study the different ways the English versions have broken 1:9–12 into different sentences. Consider how you can arrange the sentences and connect them together to make Paul's prayer sound natural in your language. One way to do this would be to repeat, "We pray that..." at the beginning of each subject Paul prayed for the Colossians.

### 1:9a

**For this reason, since the day we heard about you, we have not stopped praying for you**

- ¶ Because we<sup>(excl)</sup> have heard this good report about you, we<sup>(excl)</sup> have been praying continually for you since the day we<sup>(excl)</sup> first heard it.
- ¶ Since the time Epaphras/people told us<sup>(excl)</sup> this news about you, we<sup>(excl)</sup> have been constantly asking God to help you.

**For this reason:** These words connect 1:9–12 with what Paul said in 1:3–8. Because of the news Paul had heard about the Colossians, he prayed for them.

**we have not stopped praying for you:** This is another hyperbole (see 1:6b). It does not mean that Paul prayed for the Colossian believers all day and all night and never stopped. It means that he prayed for them often and regularly. If it is more natural in your language, you could translate not stopped praying in a positive way. For example:

we have always prayed for you (GNT)

See also NCV, NLT.

### 1:9b

**and asking God to fill you with the knowledge of His will**

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> have been asking God to help you to know fully what he wants you to do.
- We<sup>(excl)</sup> have been requesting that God would help you to understand everything that he wants you to do.

**to fill you with the knowledge of:** This is a figure of speech. To be "filled with knowledge of something" means "to know something fully, to understand it completely."

**His will:** God's will is what God wants and desires. So Paul was praying that God would cause the Colossians to know fully what he wanted for them. He was praying that they would understand all that God wanted them to do.

### 1:9c

**in all spiritual wisdom and understanding,**

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> have been asking God to do this by making you very wise about spiritual matters and enabling you to understand them well.

**in all spiritual wisdom and understanding:** The Greek preposition en that the BSB translates in has many possible meanings depending on the context. Because of this, commentators have three opinions of how to connect 1:9b and 1:9c:

1. 1:9c is the means by which a person is filled with the knowledge of God's will (1:9b). So 1:9b–c means: "[We ask God] to cause you to know fully all that he wants you to do by means of him making you very wise and enabling you to understand spiritual things." (NIV, GW, NJB)
2. 1:9c is a restatement of 1:9b. So 1:9b–c means: "[We ask God] to cause you to know fully all that he wants you to do; that is, we ask him to make you very wise and to enable you to understand spiritual things." No English version follows this, but several commentaries support it.
3. 1:9c is something that accompanies 1:9b. So Paul not only prayed that God would fill the Colossians with the knowledge of God's will, but also with all spiritual wisdom and understanding. (GNT, CEV, NCV, NLT)

All these options are possible. The Display follows the first interpretation (1) because it has strong support from both English versions and commentaries. If you wish to follow the second option, you could say:

that is, that God will fill you with all spiritual wisdom and understanding

**all spiritual wisdom and understanding:** The order of the words in Greek here is: "all wisdom and understanding spiritual." It is not clear from this word order how the adjectives all and spiritual are connected to the nouns wisdom and understanding. There are two main possibilities:

1. The adjectives all and spiritual modify both nouns, so it is translated all spiritual wisdom and understanding. (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, GW, NET, NLT)
2. The adjective all only modifies the noun wisdom and the adjective spiritual only modifies the noun understanding. For example:

perfect (all) wisdom and spiritual understanding (NJB) (NJB, see also SSA)

It is recommended you follow the first interpretation (1) like the majority of English versions and commen-

taries do. This means that Paul was not simply praying that the Colossians would be wise, but that they would be wise “spiritually.”

**spiritual:** There are two ways to understand spiritual in this context:

1. It means being wise about and understanding spiritual matters, that is, about God and his ways. (NCV)
2. It means that the wisdom and understanding come from the Holy Spirit. (GNT, CEV)

Either of these interpretations is acceptable. Most English versions are ambiguous. The Display follows the first interpretation (1), which is supported by many commentaries. If you wish to follow the second interpretation you could say:

we<sup>(excl)</sup> ask God to make you very wise and cause you to understand his ways by means of the Holy Spirit helping you

## Colossians 1:10

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God’s people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

### Paragraph 1:9–12

Theme: Paul was constantly asking God to help the Colossians to know all that God wanted them to do.

In these verses Paul was not actually praying. Rather, he was telling the Colossians what he usually prayed for them. In Greek these four verses are one long sentence. You will probably need to divide this sentence into several sentences in your translation, as most English versions do. The main part of the long sentence is “we have not stopped praying for you and

asking God...” (1:9a–b). The rest of these verses contain a list of what Paul was praying for the Colossians.

Study the different ways the English versions have broken 1:9–12 into different sentences. Consider how you can arrange the sentences and connect them together to make Paul’s prayer sound natural in your language. One way to do this would be to repeat, “We pray that...” at the beginning of each subject Paul prayed for the Colossians.

### 1:10b

#### and may please Him in every way:

- As a result you will please him in every way.
- Then he will be very happy about all that you do.

### 1:10a–b

#### so that you may walk in a manner worthy of the Lord and may please Him in every way:

In this part of the verse, Paul told the Colossians the purpose for which he was praying that they would be filled with the knowledge of God’s will (1:9b): that is, Paul prayed that they would fully know what God wanted them to do (1:9b), so that they would behave as God’s people should (1:10a) and please God.

### 1:10a

#### so that you may walk in a manner worthy of the Lord

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> ask God to do this for you in order that you will behave as the Lord’s people should behave.
- For if you know what God wants you to do, and you are wise and understand his ways, then you will act in a way that honors the Lord Jesus.

**walk in a manner worthy of the Lord:** This means “to behave in the way the Lord’s people should behave,” or “to act in a way that honors the Lord.”

**the Lord:** Paul was probably referring to the Lord Jesus here, not the Lord God. Try to leave your translation ambiguous, as the English versions do.

### 1:10c

#### bearing fruit in every good work,

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> also pray that you will constantly do all kinds of good/helpful deeds,
- We<sup>(excl)</sup> have been praying this in order that you will help one another in every way,

**bearing fruit in every good work:** The figure of speech in 1:10c and 1:10d (bearing fruit and “growing”) is the same one that Paul used in 1:6. Here, however, the meaning is clear because Paul specified the way the Colossians would “bear fruit,” that is, in every good work. The term good work is the fruit (result)

of “living a life worthy of the Lord” (1:10a). Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Your lives will produce all kinds of good deeds  
(GNT)

### 1:10d

#### growing in the knowledge of God,

- and that you will continually know God better and better.
- and you will continue to understand more and more about God.

**growing in the knowledge of God:** This does not mean knowing more and more facts about God. Rather, Paul wanted the Colossians to continue to know God better and to understand more and more about what he wanted them to do. This is similar to what Paul said in 1:9b.

## Colossians 1:11

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God’s people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

### Paragraph 1:9–12

Theme: Paul was constantly asking God to help the Colossians to know all that God wanted them to do.

In these verses Paul was not actually praying. Rather, he was telling the Colossians what he usually prayed for them. In Greek these four verses are one long sentence. You will probably need to divide this sentence into several sentences in your translation, as most English versions do. The main part of the long sentence is “we have not stopped praying for you and

asking God...” (1:9a–b). The rest of these verses contain a list of what Paul was praying for the Colossians.

Study the different ways the English versions have broken 1:9–12 into different sentences. Consider how you can arrange the sentences and connect them together to make Paul’s prayer sound natural in your language. One way to do this would be to repeat, “We pray that...” at the beginning of each subject Paul prayed for the Colossians.

### 1:11

This verse is still part of the long sentence in Greek which began at 1:9. Many English versions begin a new sentence here (RSV, GNT, CEV, GW, NCV, NLT, REB). One way to do this is to use a phrase like “We ask God...” to show that this verse is still part of Paul’s prayer.

### 1:11a

#### being strengthened with all power according to His glorious might

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> also pray that God will continually make you strong using his great power which has no limits
- And we<sup>(excl)</sup> pray that God will strengthen you in your spirits by empowering you to the full extent of his great power,

**being strengthened with all power:** Paul was praying that God would strengthen the Colossian Christians. The words being strengthened are in the present tense in Greek, so you could translate them:

We pray that God will always/continually strengthen you...

**according to His glorious might:** The phrase according to implies how much God is able to strengthen people. Paul was saying: “Since God’s power is limitless, there is no limit to how much he can strengthen you.”

**His glorious might:** The Greek text literally says “the might of his glory.” The word glorious clearly shows that the power comes from the all-powerful/almighty God. One way to translate His glorious might is “his power which is so wonderful” (see 1:11–12 in the UBS Handbook).

### 1:11b

#### so that you may have full endurance and patience, and joyfully

- so that you may patiently and joyfully endure your sufferings
- so that as God strengthens you, you will continue to trust firmly in Christ in the midst of trials, and you will be patient and rejoice,

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> pray this so that even when you suffer, God will help you to continue to trust him, to be patient with people who cause you trouble, and to be joyful.

**so that you may have full endurance and patience:**

A literal translation of the Greek is “into all endurance and patience.” Most English versions translate this as the goal or purpose of 1:11a, that is, “We pray that God will strengthen you..., so that you will have great endurance and patience” (see BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, NCV, NLT, REB, SSA).

**endurance and patience:** The two Greek words that the BSB translates endurance and patience are similar in meaning. They both refer to the way a Christian should behave when he faces a difficult situation, especially when he suffers because people persecute him for being a Christian.

**endurance:** This means being steadfast/faithful. It means not giving up, even in times of suffering and persecution.

**patience:** This means being patient with those who are persecuting you, that is, enduring their persecution patiently and not being angry at them.

It is possible to consider the two nouns “endurance” and patience together as the GNT has done:

So that you may be able to endure everything with patience. (GNT)

**and joyfully:** A literal translation of the Greek is “with joy.” This phrase “with joy” can be connected to the words before it or the word after it:

1. Some translations connect the words “with joy” to “endurance and patience” in 1:11b. For example:

to patiently endure everything with joy (GW) (GW, RSV, CEV, KJV, SSA)

1. Other versions connect the words “with joy” to “giving thanks” in 1:12a. For example:

and joyfully giving thanks to the Father (BSB) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NCV, NET, NLT, NRSV, REB).

There are several other places in the NT where the NT authors connect the idea of “joy” with trials or suffering. For example, see 2 Corinthians 8:1, 1 Thessalonians 1:6, Matthew 5:11–12. But in the NT the word “joy” is not usually connected to thanksgiving. Therefore it is recommended that you follow the first option (1) above.

## Colossians 1:12

### Section 1:3–12: Paul thanked God for the Colossians and prayed for them

In this section, Paul told the Colossian Christians that he often thanked God for them. He was grateful to God that they had trusted in Christ Jesus, and that they loved all God’s people. He told them about his prayers for them—that God would cause them to be wise and help them to know what he wanted them to do.

Epaphras had come from Colossae to visit Paul in prison. He brought news to Paul about the Christian congregations in Colossae and the towns nearby. Paul was happy to hear that the Christians in Colossae were trusting firmly in Jesus. However, he was concerned to hear that there were some people among them who wanted to continue to practice their old religious beliefs, and others who said that Christians must obey the Jewish laws. In this section of his letter, Paul concentrated on the good news he had heard from Epaphras.

### Paragraph 1:9–12

Theme: Paul was constantly asking God to help the Colossians to know all that God wanted them to do.

In these verses Paul was not actually praying. Rather, he was telling the Colossians what he usually prayed for them. In Greek these four verses are one long sentence. You will probably need to divide this sentence into several sentences in your translation, as most English versions do. The main part of the long sentence is “we have not stopped praying for you and asking God...” (1:9a–b). The rest of these verses contain a list of what Paul was praying for the Colossians.

Study the different ways the English versions have broken 1:9–12 into different sentences. Consider how you can arrange the sentences and connect them together to make Paul’s prayer sound natural in your language. One way to do this would be to repeat, “We pray that...” at the beginning of each subject Paul prayed for the Colossians.

### 1:12b

#### who has qualified you to share in the inheritance of the saints in the light.

- who has made you worthy to share in all that he has prepared for his own people in heaven.
- It is he who has made you his people, and because of this you are worthy to share in what he has promised to give to his own people in his kingdom of light.

**1:12a-b**

**Father, who has qualified you:** The Greek verb *hikanoō* that the BSB translates qualified means to make something or someone fit or capable for a task. The important thing here is that Paul said that it was God who had made the Colossians “fit” or “capable,” it was not something they had done for themselves.

**1:12a****giving thanks to the Father,**

- May you continually thank God our<sup>(incl)</sup> Father,

**you:** There is a textual problem in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the pronoun you here. This is followed by nearly every English version. (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)
2. Other Greek manuscripts have the pronoun “us.” This is only followed by some older English versions. (RSV, KJV, NASB)

You should follow the first option (1) since it has the best manuscript support. Also, the majority of English versions follow this option.

**to share in the inheritance:** The Greek word *klēros* that the BSB has translated as inheritance means “portion, what has been allotted/promised to someone.” Here it is a figure of speech to refer to what God has promised to give Christians in heaven.

**saints:** See the note on 1:4b.

**in the light:** The BSB translates the Greek text literally as in the light. Some other English versions translate this phrase as “kingdom of light” (NIV, GNT, CEV, NCV, REB) to contrast this verse with 1:13a which talks about “the dominion/power of darkness.”

There are two ways to interpret the phrase “in the light”:

1. It is a figure of speech and means “heaven” (SSA). God has promised that all Christians will be with him in heaven—that is the inheritance he has promised that they will all share. It is described as light because God is pure, that is, without sin, and, therefore, heaven is pure. It also refers to the great light surrounding God in heaven.
2. It refers to the morally upright way in which Christians should behave in this world (as in 1 John 1:5–7, 2:9–10). That is, light refers to moral purity; it refers to Christians behaving in the way that pleases God. For example:

to share the inheritance that belongs to God’s holy people, who live in the light (NLT)

Both these meanings are possible and many English versions leave it ambiguous. If you cannot leave it ambiguous in your translation, it is recommended that you follow the first option for the following two reasons:

1. Receiving “the lot” or “inheritance” is almost always spoken of in Scripture as something in the future. So it is more logical to see the light here as the light of heaven.
2. Paul was probably comparing the inheritance that had been promised to Christians to the inheritance that had been promised to the Israelites in the OT. Each Israelite family received their portion/share of the land when they entered the land of Canaan, just as God had promised them. In the same way, Christians will receive what God has promised them when they enter heaven.

**Colossians 1:13****Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything**

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

**Paragraph 1:13–14**

Theme: God has delivered Christians from the power of Satan and placed them under the protection of his Son.

1:13–14 are transitional verses. It is difficult to decide whether these verses should be the end of the previous section (1:9–12), or the beginning of the next section (1:15–20). In most English versions 1:13–14 are part of the same section as 1:9–12 (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, CEV, NCV, NJB, NLT). However, the SSA gives good reasons why a new section should begin at 1:13.

1:9–12 was Paul’s prayer for the Colossians. In 1:13–14 Paul was no longer praying, rather he was writing about how God had redeemed those who believed in Jesus. So it seems best to begin a new section at 1:13, not at 1:15. If the national language translation in your country has the section break at 1:15 and you feel you must follow that, you should at least start a new paragraph at 1:13.

**1:13a****He has rescued us from the dominion of darkness**

- ¶ God has rescued us<sup>(incl)</sup> from the evil power of Satan, which is like living in darkness.
- ¶ In the past Satan ruled us<sup>(incl)</sup>. It was as though we lived in darkness. But now God has set us free from Satan.

Some English versions add the word “For” to clarify the connection between verses 12 and 13. In 1:12, Paul said that God had made the Colossians worthy to share all that he had prepared for his people. In 1:13, Paul began to explain how God did this.

**He has rescued us:** A literal translation of the Greek is “who rescued us.” The “who” refers back to God the Father in 1:12.

**the dominion of darkness:** This contrasts with the phrase “in the light” in 1:12. Here darkness is a figure of speech for the evil power of Satan who rules over people who do not believe in Jesus. If darkness is not used as a figure of speech for evil in your language, here is another way to translate this verse part:

he delivered us from the evil power of Satan who is the ruler of evil/darkness

#### 1:13b

**and brought us into the kingdom of His beloved Son,**

- And he has now caused his Son, Jesus, whom he loves, to rule us<sup>(incl)</sup>.

**brought us into the kingdom of His beloved Son:**

The Greek word that the BSB translates brought means “change, remove, move from one place to another.” When a person becomes a Christian, God removes him from the kingdom where Satan rules, to a different kingdom, the kingdom of His beloved Son.

**kingdom of His beloved Son:** This means the kingdom where Jesus rules. See meaning 1 of “kingdom” in the glossary.

**His beloved Son:** The phrase His beloved Son refers to Jesus. It is the short form of the title, “the Son of God.” This title was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title “the Son of God” also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and

giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title “the Son of God” in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

The title “the Son” or “the Son of God” refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general term, such as:

the Child  
A translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son” or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are not acceptable, since they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God,” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

the Child of God

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “the male child,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

## Colossians 1:14

### Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

**Paragraph 1:13–14**

Theme: God has delivered Christians from the power of Satan and placed them under the protection of his Son.

1:13–14 are transitional verses. It is difficult to decide whether these verses should be the end of the previous section (1:9–12), or the beginning of the next section (1:15–20). In most English versions 1:13–14 are part of the same section as 1:9–12 (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, CEV, NCV, NJB, NLT). However, the SSA gives good reasons why a new section should begin at 1:13.

1:9–12 was Paul's prayer for the Colossians. In 1:13–14 Paul was no longer praying, rather he was writing about how God had redeemed those who believed in Jesus. So it seems best to begin a new section at 1:13, not at 1:15. If the national language translation in your country has the section break at 1:15 and you feel you must follow that, you should at least start a new paragraph at 1:13.

**1:14a****in whom we have redemption,**

- It is by means of his Son and what he did that God has freed us<sup>(incl)</sup> from the power of Satan

**in whom:** The words in whom refer to “His beloved Son” in 1:13b, that is, to Jesus. It is by means of the Son that God redeems people.

In the rest of this section, 1:14–23, Paul refers to Jesus by only a pronoun (“he,” “him,” “his”). However, in your language you may need to replace one or more of these pronouns with a name. If so, you should use “his/God's Son,” which is the way Paul referred to Jesus in 1:13. Another way would be “Christ” or “Christ Jesus” (these are other ways Paul refers to Jesus in Colossians).

**redemption:** The noun redemption comes from the verb “to redeem” which means “to buy back something which once belonged to you.” It also means “to free someone from slavery by paying a price.” In the NT, the blood that Jesus shed when he died on the cross was the price that was paid to “redeem” people and free them from being slaves of Satan. See “redeem” in KBT for further information.

**1:14b****the forgiveness of sins.**

- and forgiven our<sup>(incl)</sup> sins.
- and forgiven us for all the sinful things we<sup>(incl)</sup> have done.

**the forgiveness of sins:** In many languages, it is necessary to use a verb to translate forgiveness. God is the subject of the verb.

**General Comment about 1:14**

English versions do not agree about how 1:14a and 1:14b should be connected, that is, they do not agree about how Paul connected “redemption” and “forgiveness” in this verse. There are two possibilities:

1. Some translations connect the two parts of the verse using the word “and.” In this case, Paul was saying that by means of his Son, God redeemed us and forgave our sins. (CEV, NCV, NLT, REB)
2. Other versions consider that by “forgiveness,” Paul meant almost the same thing as “redemption” in 1:14a. So he was saying by means of his Son, God redeemed us, that is, he forgave our sins. (GNT, GW)

Both of these options are possible. The Display follows the first option (1).

**Colossians 1:15****Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything**

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

**Paragraph 1:15–20**

Theme: Jesus Christ has shown exactly what God is like. He is the great ruler over everything that he, with God, created.

In this paragraph Paul was emphasizing how great Jesus is. This was in order to oppose the following things that the false teachers were teaching the Colossian Christians.

1. The Greek people believed that evil spirits created and then controlled the world. A summary of Paul's response to that false teaching is: No, Jesus, who is equal to God, created the world and now controls it.
2. The Greeks also said that God's Messiah would never live in a human body. A summary of Paul's response is: When Jesus, God's Messiah, became a man, he retained all the character and power of God.

**1:15a****The Son is the image of the invisible God,**

- ¶ No one can see God, but when his Son became a man, he revealed God to people.
- ¶ We<sup>(incl)</sup> cannot see God, but when his Son, Christ Jesus, became a man, he caused us to understand what God is like, because he is just like him.

**The Son:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as The Son is literally the pronoun “he,” as in the NIV. It refers back to “His beloved Son” in 1:13b. See the note in 1:14a about Paul’s use of pronouns in this section. Refer to Jesus in a way that is natural in your language.

**the image of the invisible God:** When Jesus, who is God, became a man, he retained all the characteristics of God, yet people could see him. Therefore, when people saw Jesus they saw exactly what God is like, that is, they saw the character of God. This is why Paul called Jesus the image of God. Be sure that your translation does not cause your readers to think that Jesus merely showed people what God looked like.

#### 1:15b

##### **the firstborn over all creation.**

- Just as a firstborn son has the greatest authority in the family, so Christ has the greatest authority over everything that God has created.
- He has supreme authority over all that God has created.

**the firstborn over all creation:** This does not refer to when Jesus was born in Bethlehem, nor does it mean that Jesus was the first person that God created. No one created Jesus. He has always existed with God and is one with God.

Scholars interpret this phrase in one of three ways:

1. Some biblical scholars believe that the word firstborn in this verse means, “the one who has the authority that the firstborn son has.” Therefore, the firstborn over all creation means, “the one who has supreme authority over all creation.” The word firstborn is used this way in Psalm 89:27:

And I will also appoint him my firstborn, the most exalted of the kings of the earth.

1. Other scholars believe that the firstborn over all creation means, “the one who existed before anything was created.”
2. The other main interpretation is that it means both, that is, “the one who existed from the beginning of time and who has supreme authority over all creation.”

Throughout this section Paul was emphasizing that Christ rules over everything, so the first interpretation is the most likely. The GNT clarifies this by saying:

He is the first-born Son, superior to all created things. (GNT)

Here are some other ways you could translate this part of the verse:

He is more important than everything God created.

He is higher in rank/authority than everything God created.

## Colossians 1:16

### **Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything**

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

#### **Paragraph 1:15–20**

Theme: Jesus Christ has shown exactly what God is like. He is the great ruler over everything that he, with God, created.

In this paragraph Paul was emphasizing how great Jesus is. This was in order to oppose the following things that the false teachers were teaching the Colossian Christians.

1. The Greek people believed that evil spirits created and then controlled the world. A summary of Paul’s response to that false teaching is: No, Jesus, who is equal to God, created the world and now controls it.
2. The Greeks also said that God’s Messiah would never live in a human body. A summary of Paul’s response is: When Jesus, God’s Messiah, became a man, he retained all the character and power of God.

#### **1:16a**

##### **For in Him all things were created,**

- Because by means of him God created everything.
- Because it was he who worked with God to create everything:

**For:** In this clause Paul explains the reason why Christ has supreme authority over all that has been created. It is because he is the creator of all things.

**in Him all things were created:** Here Paul says that all things were created in him. Later in 1:16e, Paul said that all things were created through him. Both imply that God created all things by means of Christ. However, the Bible never explains exactly how this happened. The important thing is that Christ was present when God created the world and played an active role in that event. You could translate it like this:

God created all things by means of Christ.

Another possible way to express this is:

God caused him Christ to create all things.

**in Him:** In the Greek text, Paul placed the phrase in Him at the beginning of the clause to emphasize it. You should emphasize this phrase in your translation, too.

**were created:** This is often a difficult word to translate. It means, “to cause something to begin to exist.” It means more than “to make something from existing materials.” If the verb your language uses for “to make” can include both meanings of “to create” listed above, then you can use it here.

#### 1:16b

##### things in heaven and on earth,

- That is, he created everything here on earth, and also everything in heaven.
- This includes things here on earth and also things in heaven.

**things in heaven and on earth:** In 1:16a Paul said that God created “all things” by means of Christ. The expression here, things in heaven and on earth, is another way to say “all things.”

#### 1:16c

##### visible and invisible,

- He created everything that we can see, and also everything that we cannot see.
- It includes things that can be seen and also things that cannot be seen.

**visible and invisible:** This refers to the things people can see and those they cannot see. There are two ways to understand how this part of the verse connects to 1:16b:

1. When Paul said visible and invisible, he again meant all things. Everything that God created belongs to the group of things we can see or to the group of things we cannot see.
2. When Paul said visible and invisible, he was restating 1:16b in the opposite order (this is called a chiasmic structure). Therefore, invisible things is equivalent to “things in heaven,” and visible things is equivalent to “things on earth.”

Both these options are possible and have strong support among the commentaries. The Display follows the first option (1). If you wish to follow the second option (2), you could say:

He created the things in heaven that we cannot see, and the things on earth that we can see.

Whichever option you choose, the important thing is to clarify that God, by means of Christ, created everything.

#### 1:16d

##### whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities.

- This means that it was he who created even the angels and other supernatural beings who have great power and authority.
- He created every person/being who has power and who rules, even the powerful angels and other spirit beings.

**thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities:** Most Biblical scholars believe this is a specific list of the “invisible” things Paul mentioned in 1:16c, but no one is certain about the identity of each of these groups. Paul was not teaching here about the different types of leaders among the angels and spirits. He simply wanted to emphasize that all of them, even the most powerful and important ones, were created by means of Christ.

#### 1:16e

##### All things were created through Him and for Him.

- By means of Christ, everything was created. And everything exists for his benefit.
- Yes, God caused Christ to create everything, without exception, so that all things would honor Christ.

**All things:** Here in 1:16e, Paul put the words All things at the beginning of this clause to emphasize them. Try to emphasize these words in a natural way in your translation.

**through Him:** Although the Greek word that the BSB translates through in this phrase is different from the word “in” in 1:16a, the meaning is the same.

**for Him:** This means that Christ is the goal of all creation. In other words, God created all things “for his benefit.” You could also translate this, “to honor him” or “to serve him.”

## Colossians 1:17

### Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

#### Paragraph 1:15–20

Theme: Jesus Christ has shown exactly what God is like. He is the great ruler over everything that he, with God, created.

In this paragraph Paul was emphasizing how great Jesus is. This was in order to oppose the following things that the false teachers were teaching the Colossian Christians.

1. The Greek people believed that evil spirits created and then controlled the world. A summary of Paul’s response to that false teaching is: No, Jesus, who is equal to God, created the world and now controls it.
2. The Greeks also said that God’s Messiah would never live in a human body. A summary of Paul’s response is: When Jesus, God’s Messiah, became a man, he retained all the character and power of God.

#### 1:17a

##### He is before all things,

- He existed before anything else existed,
- Before anything was created, he already existed,

**He is before all things:** This means that Christ existed before anything was created.

**all things:** Notice that Paul used the phrase all things twice in this verse. He had also used this same phrase twice in 1:16. He wanted to emphasize that Christ is important and central. He is supreme over all things. He created all things, is the goal of all things, existed before all things, and holds all things together.

#### 1:17b

##### and in Him all things hold together.

- and all things continue to exist in an orderly manner because of him.
- and he is the one who makes everything work together in unity.

**in Him all things hold together:** This is a difficult clause to translate. It means that after everything was created, Jesus is the one who causes everything to continue to exist and to work together the way God planned. Hebrews 1:3 says something similar:

sustaining all things by his powerful word

## Colossians 1:18

### Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

#### Paragraph 1:15–20

Theme: Jesus Christ has shown exactly what God is like. He is the great ruler over everything that he, with God, created.

In this paragraph Paul was emphasizing how great Jesus is. This was in order to oppose the following things that the false teachers were teaching the Colossian Christians.

1. The Greek people believed that evil spirits created and then controlled the world. A summary of Paul’s response to that false teaching is: No, Jesus, who is equal to God, created the world and now controls it.
2. The Greeks also said that God’s Messiah would never live in a human body. A summary of Paul’s response is: When Jesus, God’s Messiah, became a man, he retained all the character and power of God.

#### 1:18a

##### And He is the head of the body, the church;

- Also it is he, Christ, who rules over his people and guides them, just as the head rules over and guides the physical body.

**the head of the body:** This is a figure of speech. Paul was saying that Christ controls and directs his

people the same way that a person's head controls and directs his body.

In many cultures, people do not consider that a person's head controls his body. However, since the NT often uses this figure of speech, you should try to keep it in your translation. If this is impossible, you could use one of the following ways to translate this part of the verse:

the one who controls his people

the chief over his people

the one who rules over Christians

**the body:** In this verse Paul was emphasizing that Christ is the head (chief, ruler) of the church. He was not emphasizing the other part of the figure of speech, that is, that the church is like Christ's body.

**the church:** The Greek word *ekklēsia* is translated church in almost all English versions. However, the Greek word means "congregation, assembly, community." It never means a church building. Make sure you translate this term in a way that clearly refers to a gathering of Christian people, not to a building. For further information see "church" in the glossary and in KBT.

### 1:18b

#### He is the beginning

- He can do this since he is the source of new life for his people,
- He is the one who gives life to the body, his people,

**He is the beginning:** There are several ways to understand this. The two main ways are:

1. Paul was still writing about Christ's relation to his body, the church. English versions show this connection in different ways. For example:

He is its origin (REB)

he is the source of the body's life (GNT)

The NET Bible translates 1:18a-b as:

He is the head of the body, the church, as well as the beginning. (NET) (REB, GNT, NET)

- 1:18b could even be the basis for Paul's statement in 1:18a, that is, Christ is the head of the church since

he is its source. See the SSA for a fuller discussion of this possibility.

1. Paul had begun a new idea here and was referring to the beginning or source of everything, not simply the church. (NCV, NJB)

Many English versions leave this ambiguous, although most scholars agree that Paul was still writing about Christ's relation to the church, so it is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

**the beginning:** The Greek word *archē* that the BSB translates as beginning has several meanings: "beginning, source, origin, foundation." There are many different opinions about which meaning Paul intended here. The three main opinions are:

1. It means that Christ is the source of the church's life. For example:

he is the source of the body's life (GNT)

- See also SSA.

1. It means that Christ is the founder, the one who began the church. For example:

he is its [the church's] origin (REB)

1. The phrase is connected to 1:18c, so beginning refers to the same thing as "firstborn from among the dead." Several English versions imply this by the way they use punctuation to divide the verse. (CEV, GW)

Since it seems that Paul was still writing about the church here (see previous note), this third option is less likely. Either of the other two is possible. The Display follows the first one (1).

### 1:18c

#### and firstborn from among the dead,

- because it was he whom God first raised from death never to die again,

**and firstborn from among the dead:** The BSB connects 1:18c to 1:18b using the word *and*, although there is no conjunction in the Greek text. Scholars suggest two ways to connect the phrase firstborn from among the dead in 1:18c to 1:18b:

1. The phrase firstborn from among the dead explains the reason why Christ is the source (beginning) of the church's life. No English version explicitly follows this, but some reliable commentaries support

this view. The UBS Handbook suggests this, as well as the SSA.

2. The phrase firstborn from among the dead is another title for Christ in the same way that “the beginning” is in 1:18b, and is related in some way. Many English versions seem to understand the phrase this way and they translate it as does the BSB, using and or a comma to separate 1:18b and 1:18c.

Either of these two options is possible and both have strong support in the commentaries. The Display follows the first option.

**firstborn from among the dead:** Christ was not the first person ever to die and be resurrected. The Bible tells us about several people in the OT and the NT who died and later were brought back to life again (see, for example, the story about Lazarus in John chapter 11). However, all these people died again. Christ was the first person who rose from death with the sort of body Christians will have in heaven—a body that will never die again.

**firstborn:** This is the same word that Paul used in 1:15b. However, here the meaning is different. Here Paul was not referring to Christ’s authority, but simply to the fact that Christ was the first to rise from the dead to live forever.

#### 1:18d

**so that in all things He may have preeminence.**

- and God planned it this way in order that Christ alone should be the supreme ruler over all that exists.
- so that Christ would be the most important person/thing in the universe.

**so that in all things He may have preeminence:** This sentence explains the purpose for 1:18b–c. God raised Christ from death and caused him to be the source of the church’s life, so that Christ would be the supreme ruler over everything.

**in all things:** The Greek words that the BSB translates in all things can mean:

1. “all things.” This is how most English versions have translated it.
2. “every way.” Only the NJB has this in the text, though the SSA also supports this translation.

Both of these are acceptable. Your choice of which term to use in your language may depend on how you translate “preeminence.” The important thing is that your translation should communicate that Christ is most important.

**preeminence:** This Greek word that the BSB translates preeminence is related to the word “first.” It means that Christ has the first place, he is first in rank, honor, and influence. Here is another way to translate this verse part:

in order that he alone might have the first place in all things (GNT)

## Colossians 1:19

### Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

#### Paragraph 1:15–20

Theme: Jesus Christ has shown exactly what God is like. He is the great ruler over everything that he, with God, created.

In this paragraph Paul was emphasizing how great Jesus is. This was in order to oppose the following things that the false teachers were teaching the Colossian Christians.

1. The Greek people believed that evil spirits created and then controlled the world. A summary of Paul’s response to that false teaching is: No, Jesus, who is equal to God, created the world and now controls it.
2. The Greeks also said that God’s Messiah would never live in a human body. A summary of Paul’s response is: When Jesus, God’s Messiah, became a man, he retained all the character and power of God.

#### 1:19

**For God was pleased to have all His fullness dwell in Him,**

- For God himself decided that his Son would fully have all God’s character/nature.
- Because God also planned that even when Christ became a man, he/Christ would be fully equal to God in every way.

**For:** Notice that the BSB begins 1:19 with the word For. 1:19 explains and provides a reason for the previous verses.

**God was pleased to have all His fullness dwell in Him:** A literal English translation of the Greek is: “in

him was-pleased all the fullness to-dwell.” The phrase in Him refers to Jesus. In Greek there is no subject of the verb that the BSB translates was pleased. There are two main possibilities:

1. The subject of the verb is God. This is how most English versions translate the verse. (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NLT).
2. The subject of the verb is fullness. This is how the RSV translates the verse.

Most scholars agree that God is the subject of the verb was pleased and so it is recommended that you follow the first option (1). Another way to translate the words God was pleased is:

God decided...

**all His fullness:** The Greek is literally “all the fullness.” It is not clear from this verse alone what fullness Paul meant. However, this is similar to what Paul says in 2:9: “in Christ all the fullness of the Deity dwells in bodily form.” This helps us to understand that Paul was probably referring to God’s fullness in this verse. When Jesus came into the world, even though he became a man, he was still God, and he still retained all the power and characteristics of God. We know from what Paul says in this letter to the Colossians that there were people in Colossae teaching false doctrine. These teachings were probably similar to what was later called gnosticism. Gnosticism taught that between God and people there were many lesser gods and powerful beings, and that Christ was just one of these beings. That is why in this letter Paul told the Colossians how supreme and how important Christ is. Here in 1:19 Paul says that “all the fullness” of God was in Christ. Christ is not just one of many powerful beings between God and man, Christ is not just a little like God. All of God and God’s nature was fully in Christ.

**in Him:** This, of course, refers to Christ. In the Greek text Paul placed these words at the beginning of the clause to emphasize them. You should emphasize them in your translation in a way that is natural in your language.

## Colossians 1:20

### Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed

them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

### Paragraph 1:15–20

Theme: Jesus Christ has shown exactly what God is like. He is the great ruler over everything that he, with God, created.

In this paragraph Paul was emphasizing how great Jesus is. This was in order to oppose the following things that the false teachers were teaching the Colossian Christians.

1. The Greek people believed that evil spirits created and then controlled the world. A summary of Paul’s response to that false teaching is: No, Jesus, who is equal to God, created the world and now controls it.
2. The Greeks also said that God’s Messiah would never live in a human body. A summary of Paul’s response is: When Jesus, God’s Messiah, became a man, he retained all the character and power of God.

### 1:20a

#### and through Him to reconcile to Himself all things,

- And by means of Christ God also decided that he would restore harmony between himself and all things.
- And Christ is the one that God used to make a way to bring everything he had created back into a good relationship with himself.

**through Him to reconcile to Himself all things:** 1:20a is parallel to the second part of 1:19. In other words, God was pleased to do two things: (1) to have all his fullness dwell in Christ (1:19), and (2) to reconcile to Himself all things (1:20a).

**through Him:** The pronoun Him refers to Christ here, as it does in 1:19, and Paul placed the words at the beginning of the verse to emphasize them. In some Greek manuscripts the words “through him” occur twice. In the UBS Greek text, the second occurrence of “through him” is in brackets. This means it is doubtful that these words were in the original letter that Paul wrote. The UBS Greek text of 1:20 literally reads: and through him to reconcile all things to him, having made peace through the blood of his cross, [through him] whether things on the earth or the things in the heavens. The KJV includes this second “through him” in its translation. The important thing to remember in your translation is that “through him,” whether it occurs once or twice, is emphatic. Make sure Christ is the topic of these verses in your translation.

**reconcile:** The word reconcile means “to change people from being enemies to being friends” or “to make peace between people who were once friends but have become enemies of one another.” When God created the world, he intended that everything and everybody should live in harmony and peace with him. But when Adam and Eve sinned, that peace and harmony was destroyed. When Christ died on the cross, he made it possible for people to have peace with God again.

**all things:** The words all things mean “everything that has been created.” Remember that in 1:16–17 Paul used these same words, all things, four times to refer to everything that God created. So Paul was saying that God not only reconciled all people to himself, but he also reconciled everything he had created. We know from teachings in other parts of the Bible that not everyone will be saved. There will be people, as well as Satan and his angels, in hell. But when we read in Colossians 1:19–20 that “God was pleased...to reconcile to himself all things,” it sounds as if Paul was saying that God would make all things right with himself, and so all people would be saved. Be careful of trying to “explain” what Paul said in your translation. In 1:20 Paul made a strong universal statement. It is best if you translate his statement simply and clearly. Do not try to “make it fit” what the Bible teaches in other passages.

#### 1:20b

#### **whether things on earth or things in heaven,**

- This includes things that are on earth and things that are in heaven.

**whether things on earth or things in heaven:** This is almost the same as what Paul wrote in 1:16b and the meaning is the same in both verses—it means “everything.”

#### 1:20c

#### **by making peace through the blood of His cross.**

- God made a way for all things to be at peace with himself by having his Son shed his blood and die on a cross.
- He did that by means of the blood that his Son shed when he died on the cross. Now everything can be at peace with God.

**by making peace:** The phrase making peace means almost the same as “reconcile” in 1:20a. It means “to cause people to be in harmony.” It does not mean that God caused all things to be at peace with one another, rather it means that he made peace between them and himself.

**through the blood of His cross:** This explains more clearly what Paul meant by “through Him” in 1:20a. The word blood refers to the way Christ died. God required that blood be shed in order for him to forgive sins (Hebrews 9:22). So Christ’s blood is an important symbol in the Bible, and therefore you should keep it in your translation. One way you could clarify it would be to say:

by sending Christ to shed his blood and die on a cross

#### **General Comment about 1:20**

In some languages it is clearer to reorder the parts of 1:20 before translating the verse. Some English versions have done this. For example:

And God was pleased for him to make peace by sacrificing his blood on the cross, so that all beings in heaven and on earth would be brought back to God. (CEV)

See also GNT. Another way to reorder 1:20 is:

God decided to send his Son, who shed his blood and died on a cross. God did this in order to restore harmony between himself and all things. In this way, he made peace between himself and all that exists in heaven and all that exists on the earth.

### **Colossians 1:21**

#### **Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything**

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

#### **Paragraph 1:21–23**

Theme: Although the Colossians had previously been God’s enemies, he had now made them his own people.

1:21–23 is one sentence in Greek. You will probably need to divide it into several sentences in your translation. The main verb of this sentence is “he has reconciled you” (1:22). In the previous paragraph Paul said that God’s plan was to reconcile all things to him-

self (1:20). In this paragraph Paul applied this directly to the Colossians.

### 1:21a

#### Once you were alienated from God

- ¶ As for you believers in Colossae, in the past before you trusted in Christ you were separated from God,

**Once:** The Greek word that the BSB translates Once means “formerly, in the past.” Paul was writing about what the Colossian Christians were like before they believed in Christ.

**you:** The word you is emphasized in the Greek text. In English this can be expressed, “But as for you...,” or, “And you yourselves...” Paul used this emphasis to change the focus of the letter at this point. In 1:15–20 he had written about the greatness of Christ, here he began to write about the Colossian Christians’ relationship to God.

**alienated from God:** The Greek text does not contain the words from God (see RSV and NET). However, almost all commentators agree that the text here implies the words from God. Therefore the BSB and many other English versions include these words. Paul was saying that the Colossians were separated from God. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

far away from God (GNT)

Paul did not mean that the Colossians were physically far away from God. He meant that they did not have a relationship with him because their sinful deeds separated them from him. Other ways to translate this might be:

you were like strangers to God

you had turned your backs on God

### 1:21b

#### and were hostile in your minds,

- and you were hostile to God in all your thoughts,
- and the way you thought was against God,

**hostile in your minds:** This phrase continues to describe what the Colossians were like before they became Christians: they were hostile toward God. Possible ways to say this are:

you were hostile toward God

you were against God

**in your minds:** This explains the specific way the Colossians had been God’s enemies—they were hostile to God in the way they thought and felt. Here is another way to translate this:

Your thoughts made you his enemies (CEV)

### 1:21c

#### engaging in evil deeds.

- because you acted in an evil manner.
- because you continually did evil things.

**engaging in evil deeds:** It wasn’t just the way they thought that caused the Colossians to be God’s enemies—it was also the evil way they acted.

#### General Comment for 1:21b–c

Some English versions combine 1:21b–c and these two ideas. For example:

and were his enemies because of the evil things you did and thought (GNT)

## Colossians 1:22

### Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

#### Paragraph 1:21–23

Theme: Although the Colossians had previously been God’s enemies, he had now made them his own people.

1:21–23 is one sentence in Greek. You will probably need to divide it into several sentences in your translation. The main verb of this sentence is “he has reconciled you” (1:22). In the previous paragraph Paul said that God’s plan was to reconcile all things to himself (1:20). In this paragraph Paul applied this directly to the Colossians.

### 1:22a

#### But now He has reconciled you

- But now God has restored harmony between himself and you,
- But even though you were like that in the past, now God has caused you to be at peace with himself.

**But now:** In this verse Paul contrasted the way the Colossians were before they believed in Christ with the way they were now, that is, after they had become believers.

**He has reconciled you:** See the note on 1:20a. You should translate the word reconciled here the same way as you did in 1:20.

**He:** There are a number of pronouns in the Greek text of this verse and it is not clear to whom they refer. Scholars do not agree about who is the subject of the verb “reconciled.” It could be either God or Christ. Most commentators and English versions prefer God as the subject, and this is consistent with all that the NT teaches. So it is recommended that you clarify that God is the subject in your translation.

### 1:22b

#### by Christ’s physical body through death

- by having his Son become human and die on the cross.
- The way God did this was by means of Christ becoming a man and dying.

**by Christ’s physical body through death:** This is similar to what Paul said in 1:20c. God reconciled the Colossians to himself by means of Christ’s...death.

**Christ’s physical body:** The Greek literally says, “the body of his flesh” (see RSV). Paul was emphasizing that Christ had a physical body, a human body. Why did Paul talk about “Christ’s physical body” in Colossians 1:22, and 2:9? Some scholars believe that the false teachers in Colossae taught that people needed the help of spiritual beings, such as angels, in order to be made acceptable to God. So, in order to fight against this false teaching, Paul wrote that God had reconciled us to himself, not with the help of angels or other spiritual creatures, but by Christ and Christ alone. All of God was in Christ bodily (2:9). His physical body literally died on a cross and his blood poured out (1:20c, 1:22b).

### 1:22c

#### to present you holy, unblemished, and blameless in His presence—

- God did this so that when he brings you to be where he is in the future, you will be pure and without any sin or guilt.
- God reconciled you by having Christ die so that when you stand before God at the time when he judges all people he will consider you to be completely pure, without sin, and no one will have any reason to accuse you of doing anything wrong.

**to present you holy, unblemished, and blameless in His presence:** This states the purpose of 1:22a. God had reconciled the Colossians to himself in order to present them holy, unblemished, and blameless. The subject of this part of the verse is the same as the subject of 1:22a, that is, God. See the note on 1:22a. So Paul was saying, “God has reconciled you...in order that he God can present you...”

**to present you...in His presence:** This means, “to cause you to be in his presence,” or “to bring you to be where he is.” Scholars do not agree about when this happens:

1. Many scholars say that these words refer to the future, that is, to the day when God will judge everyone.
2. Some scholars believe that Paul was writing about something that is already true. By means of Christ’s death, God has already brought those who believe in him into his presence and caused them to be holy and pure. (CEV, NLT)

Both these interpretations are true, and are taught elsewhere in the Bible. Many English versions are ambiguous because the Greek text could mean either. The Display follows the first interpretation (1), since most commentaries prefer it.

**holy, unblemished, and blameless:** In 1:22c–d Paul said that God’s purpose was to make us “to present you holy, unblemished, and blameless in His presence.” Paul was not talking about our actual behavior. No Christian behaves perfectly and never sins. But God has forgiven us for our sins and has justified us. So, now when God judges us, he considers us no longer guilty of sin. He now considers us righteous (2 Corinthians 5:21; Romans 8:1–4) and “holy...unblemished, and blameless.” And in the future, when God raises us from the dead and gives us new bodies, he will make us truly holy in our actions also.: Paul uses three words or phrases that mean almost the same thing.

**holy:** The Greek word *hagios* that the BSB translates *holy* normally means “dedicated to God.” In this context, the meaning is “pure.” (See “holy” in KBT and meaning 2 in the glossary).

**unblemished:** The Greek word *amōmos* that the BSB translates *unblemished* is a term that is used to describe an animal that has no cuts, bruises, or other physical problems—an animal that is acceptable as a sacrifice (1 Peter 1:19; Exodus 12:5). Here it means “morally pure, having no sins.”

**blameless:** The Greek word *anegklētos* which the BSB translates blameless means that no one can accuse believers before God and say they are guilty of sinning.

If your language does not have three different terms for these concepts, there are several ways you can combine them. The main reason Paul used three separate words with similar meanings was to strengthen his statement. The SSA suggests that the meaning is simply, “in order that you should be completely holy.” Another way to translate these three terms is:

completely pure and without blame in any way

## Colossians 1:23

### Section 1:13–23: Jesus Christ is greater than everything

In this section, Paul stated these things: Jesus is equal to God in every way. He has always been with God and he (with God) created the world. God has freed Christians from the power of Satan and has placed them under the rule of his Son, Christ Jesus. God has accepted those who believe in Jesus as his own people. This was possible because Jesus died on the cross instead of them.

#### Paragraph 1:21–23

Theme: Although the Colossians had previously been God’s enemies, he had now made them his own people.

1:21–23 is one sentence in Greek. You will probably need to divide it into several sentences in your translation. The main verb of this sentence is “he has reconciled you” (1:22). In the previous paragraph Paul said that God’s plan was to reconcile all things to himself (1:20). In this paragraph Paul applied this directly to the Colossians.

#### 1:23a

##### if indeed you continue in your faith,

- This is true of you if you continue to believe in the gospel,
- But to make certain this will happen, you must continue to trust in Christ,

**if indeed you continue in your faith:** Paul’s words in 1:23 are part of the same sentence that he began in 1:21. This verse states the condition for 1:22. 1:22 will only be true if the Colossian Christians continue in their faith. Some Christians believe in a doctrine called eternal security. This means that if a person has truly believed in Jesus, nothing they can do can cause them to lose that salvation. Other Christians do not believe this. They believe that a person can truly believe in

Jesus and be saved, but later this person can lose his or her salvation, because he turns away from Christ. Colossians 1:23 is a verse that people often quote when talking about this teaching. You should translate this verse as simply as possible with no explanation. Do not try to make your translation fit what you believe about eternal security.

**continue in your faith:** In Greek the words that the BSB translates continue in your faith are literally “continue in the faith.” It means “continue to believe” or “keep believing.” The object of their faith is probably the gospel. So if you need to supply the object of the verb “believe” in your language, you could say:

But you must continue to believe in the gospel

...believe in Jesus

#### 1:23b

##### established and firm,

- that is, your faith must remain strong, like a house that has been built on a firm foundation,

**established and firm:** This is one way the Colossians were to “continue in their faith.” These two words, established and firm, mean almost the same thing.

**established:** The Greek word *themelioō* that the BSB translates established means “to place on a firm foundation.” This is a figure of speech here. It means that just as a solid foundation causes a house to be stable and strong, so the Colossians must have faith that is firm and strong.

#### 1:23c

##### not moved from the hope of the gospel you heard,

- and you must not let anyone stop you from hoping for what God promised to you in the gospel.

##### not moved from the hope of the gospel you heard:

In Greek this verse part translated literally says: “and not moving/shifting from the hope of the gospel.” The hope of the gospel means “the hope God promised in the gospel.” Some of the things he promised to those who believe are:

1. to raise them after they die
2. to make them holy and perfect
3. to bring them to live with him in heaven forever

See the note on 1:5a for the meaning of the word hope. In many languages it is clearer to translate hope as a verb. In this verse you could say, for example:

you confidently wait for God to do what he promised in the gospel

**not moved:** There are two ways to understand these words:

1. It has a passive sense: that is, “do not let anyone/ anything move you so that you stop hoping...” For example:

and must not allow yourselves to be shaken from the hope you gained when you heard the gospel (GNT) (GNT, NCV, GW, REB)

1. It has an active sense: The Greek verb can actually be understood as middle voice, rather than active. “do not stop hoping...” For example:

You must not give up the hope you received when you heard the good news (CEV) (CEV, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1) because one reason Paul wrote this letter to the Colossian believers was to warn the Colossians not to be deceived by false teachers.

**gospel:** See the word gospel in the glossary.

#### 1:23d

**which has been proclaimed to every creature under heaven,**

- This is the message that has been announced to everyone everywhere.
- This gospel has already been proclaimed to people all over the world.

**has been proclaimed:** This refers to the “gospel” (1:23c). If in your language it is necessary to say who had proclaimed the gospel, you could say “[the gospel] that people/God’s workers have proclaimed...”

**proclaimed:** This means, “announced, made known.”

**to every creature under heaven:** This probably means the same as “all over the world” in 1:6b. See the note there. Paul was saying that the gospel had been proclaimed “to people all over the world.” For other views, you need to consult commentaries.

#### 1:23e

**and of which I, Paul, have become a servant.**

- And I, Paul, have become one who works to preach this message to people.
- I, Paul, am one of God’s workers who proclaims this gospel.

**of which:** This refers back to “gospel” in 1:23c.

**I, Paul:** This is the first time in this letter that Paul used the pronoun I instead of “we.” One reason he did this was to tell his readers that he was about to begin a different topic (in 1:24–2:5).

**a servant:** In some languages it is difficult to say that someone is a servant of the gospel. A servant is a person who serves another person or works for him. Paul meant that he was a person who worked to proclaim the gospel. In the next paragraph (1:24–29) Paul explained more about his work as a servant of the gospel.

## Colossians 1:24

**Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews**

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

### Paragraph 1:24–29

Theme: Paul willingly suffered so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would know the message about Christ.

#### 1:24a

**Now I rejoice in my sufferings for you,**

- ¶ At present I am happy because I know that what I am suffering here as a prisoner benefits you.
- ¶ I am suffering because of the work I have done to help you Gentiles. But I do this willingly now.

**Now I rejoice in my sufferings for you:** Paul was writing about what he had suffered. Here is another way to translate this clause:

And now I am happy about my sufferings for you (GNT)

**I rejoice:** Paul was not saying that he enjoyed suffering. Rather he was saying that he was willing to suffer for the Christians in Colossae and other places.

**for you:** The words for you mean “in order to help you,” or “to benefit you.” In this section, 1:24–2:5, Paul spoke mainly about his work to preach the gospel to the Gentiles (those who were not Jews), and so the pronoun you means, “you Gentile Christians.”

The reason Paul had been suffering was that when he preached the gospel, especially to the Gentiles, his enemies had often persecuted him and put him in prison.

**1:24b****and I fill up in my flesh what is lacking in regard to Christ's afflictions**

- And I willingly suffer all that Christ requires me to suffer on his behalf
- As Christians, we must continue to endure suffering. Just as Christ suffered, so I willingly suffer physically all that is necessary

**I fill up in my flesh what is lacking in regard to Christ's afflictions:**

This is a difficult expression to understand and scholars disagree about what it means. It is not possible in these notes to explain all the different possibilities. Because of this, these notes present one major view among the many. For other views, you need to consult commentaries.

**I fill up:** The Greek verb *antanaplērō* that the BSB translates I fill up means, "I complete (something) by adding what is lacking." Here it means, "I am completing what Christ has appointed for me to suffer," or "I am completing my responsibility to suffer [on behalf of Christ]." Paul did this willingly (see the note on 1:24a).

**in my flesh:** This means that Paul was writing about physical suffering (see GNT).

**what is lacking:** This clause implies what Christ taught, that is, that all Christians will suffer persecution. So here Paul meant that he was suffering what still needed to be suffered.

**in regard to Christ's afflictions:** The Greek word *thlipsis* that the BSB translates afflictions is not used in the NT to refer to what Christ suffered when he died on the cross. It refers to the persecution, difficulties, and other physical and emotional hardships that Christians suffer. For example, it is used in Matthew 24:9, John 16:33, and Revelation 7:14.

Biblical scholars have different opinions about what the phrase Christ's afflictions means in this context. The three most common opinions are as follows:

1. "I am suffering on behalf of Christ."
2. "I am suffering the sufferings of Christ"—that is, "through my suffering, as a member of the body of Christ, it is as if Christ himself were suffering."
3. "I am suffering in the same way Christ suffered."

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1). Since Paul was writing about his own sufferings, it seems more likely that he was saying that he was suffering on behalf of Christ, that is, for the sake of Christ. (See Acts 9:16.)

Paul was not saying that what Christ suffered on the cross lacked something. This would imply that Jesus' death was not sufficient to save those who believe in him. Your translation should be worded carefully to avoid suggesting this.

**1:24c****for the sake of His body, which is the church.**

- in order to help his people, who are like his body.

**His body, which is the church:** See the notes on body and church in 1:18a.

**Colossians 1:25****Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews**

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

**Paragraph 1:24–29**

Theme: Paul willingly suffered so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would know the message about Christ.

**1:25a****I became its servant**

- I have become one who serves these people
- I have become one of God's workers who works to help all believers

**I became its servant:** The pronoun *its* refers back to "church" in 1:24. In 1:23 Paul had said that he had become a servant of the gospel. Here he said that he had become a servant of the church. Paul had become someone who worked to help the community of those who believed in Jesus.

**1:25b****by the commission God gave me**

- by means of God entrusting me with this job for your benefit.
- because God appointed me to do this in order to help you.

**1:25c****to fully proclaim to you the word of God,**

- My job is to explain fully to you this message from God.
- He sent me to teach you his complete message about Christ Jesus.

**1:25b–c**

**by the commission God gave me to fully proclaim to you:** In the Greek text, the phrase that the BSB translates to you is in the middle of the verse. There-

fore, scholars do not agree about how it is connected to the rest of the verse. There are two main ways to understand this phrase:

1. It is connected to what precedes it, that is, God gave Paul a commission for the Colossians, that is, for their benefit, in order to help them. (GNT, RSV, KJV, NCV, NJB, REB)
2. It is connected to what follows, that is, God gave Paul a commission to present the word of God to the Colossians. (BSB, NIV, CEV, GW, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1) since most commentaries support it and it is the clearest way to understand the Greek structure.

**the commission God gave:** To give a commission to someone means to appoint him to do a job, to entrust him with a duty, and make him responsible to do it. The job/commission God entrusted to Paul was to serve the church in Colossae.

**to fully proclaim to you the word of God:** One of the ways that God wanted Paul to serve the church was to fully proclaim...the word of God. Paul's job was to "fully proclaim God's message," or "to tell people about God's message."

**the word of God:** This refers to the message from God, the gospel. In this context it does not mean only the written word of God, the Scriptures.

## Colossians 1:26

### Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

#### Paragraph 1:24–29

Theme: Paul willingly suffered so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would know the message about Christ.

#### 1:26a

#### the mystery that was hidden for ages and generations

- That is, he sent me to teach you about his plan, which in the past, before Christ came, God did not allow people to understand,
- God kept this message concealed from all the people who lived in the past,

**mystery:** In the NT the Greek word that the BSB translates mystery means a truth that people cannot understand by themselves but that they can only

understand if God reveals it to them. In Colossians it specifically refers to God's plan for the world that he did not reveal to people until after Christ had died. Paul did not explain the mystery to the Colossians until the end of 1:27.

**that was hidden for ages and generations:** Paul said that God's plan was hidden. This means that God kept it a secret. He did not allow people to understand it fully.

**for ages and generations:** This refers to all the people who lived in all the years before Christ came. Here is another way to translate this verse part:

the secret he hid through all past ages from all human beings (GNT)

#### 1:26b

#### but is now revealed to His saints.

- but which he has now revealed to his people.
- but God has now made known this plan to all his people.

**but is now revealed to His saints:** Although in the past God did not allow people to understand his plan, now that Christ has come, God has revealed his plan, that is, he has made it known/revealed it.

**His saints:** The term saints means all God's people, all believers in Christ. See the note on 1:4b.

## Colossians 1:27

### Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

#### Paragraph 1:24–29

Theme: Paul willingly suffered so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would know the message about Christ.

#### 1:27a

#### To them God has chosen to make known among the Gentiles the glorious riches of this mystery,

- God decided to make known to his people how truly wonderful his plan is for the Gentiles.
- To all his people God has chosen to reveal his secret plan. He wants them all to know that his plan is extremely important to help those who are not Jews.

**To them:** This refers to "the saints" in 1:26b.

**God has chosen to make known among the Gentiles the glorious riches of this mystery:** There are two ways to connect the phrase among the Gentiles to the rest of the verse:

1. The phrase among the Gentiles should be connected to the glorious riches. So this verse means that God wanted the saints to understand that the glorious riches of this mystery were for the benefit of the Gentiles—the Gentiles are included in the riches of his glory. (RSV)
2. The phrase among the Gentiles should be connected to the verb make known in 1:27a. So the BSB interprets this verse to mean that God wanted the gospel to be made known among the Gentiles. (BSB)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

**Gentiles:** This refers to all people who were not Jews.

**the glorious riches of this mystery:** See meaning 1 of “glory” in the glossary.

#### 1:27b

**which is Christ in you,**

- God’s plan is this: that Christ is in you Gentiles,
- This plan is that Christ dwells in you who are not Jews also,

**Christ in you:** In 1:26 Paul began writing about the “mystery” (God’s secret plan). In this phrase he explains what the “mystery” is. It is that Christ dwells in Gentiles who believe in him. When Paul says in you, he means “in you Gentiles.” It is the Spirit of Christ, that is, the Holy Spirit, who lives in those who belong to Christ (see Romans 8:9–10, John 14:16–18). If you use cross references or footnotes, you may want to refer to the above passages, and also to Ephesians 3:17, Galatians 2:20, 2 Corinthians 6:16.

The Greek text translated literally says Christ in you—there is no verb. However, in your translation you will probably need to use a verb. For example:

Christ is in you

Christ lives/dwells in you

Paul was writing about something that was already true when he wrote the letter—Christ was now in the hearts of the believers.

#### 1:27c

**the hope of glory.**

- and so you can confidently expect to share God’s glory in heaven.

- and, as a result, you can be confident that you will receive the glory God has promised.

**the hope of glory:** The phrase hope of glory means “the glory you hope for” or “the glory you expect to receive.” Most scholars believe that this refers to the future glory Christians can expect to receive in heaven. Some English versions express this as “your hope of sharing God’s glory” (CEV, see also NLT, GNT).

**glory:** See meaning 2 of “glory” in the glossary.

#### General Comment about 1:27b–c

In Greek it is not clear how to connect this part of the verse, “the hope of glory,” to 1:27c, “Christ in you.” However, most scholars believe that Paul was saying that “the hope of glory” is the result of Christ being in someone: that is, “Christ is in you, and as a result you confidently expect to have glory.”

#### General Comment about 1:26–27

Paul had written about the “mystery” in 1:26 and 1:27a–b, but he did not say specifically what the mystery was until 1:27c. In some languages it may be necessary to rearrange 1:26–27 to help people understand this. A possible way to do this would be:

God decided to tell his people how wonderful his plan was for you who are not Jews. His plan was this: that Christ should live in you, so you can confidently expect to share God’s glory. In the past, God did not reveal this plan to people. But now he has told his people about it.

## Colossians 1:28

### Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

#### Paragraph 1:24–29

Theme: Paul willingly suffered so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would know the message about Christ.

#### 1:28a

**We proclaim Him,**

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> tell everyone this message about Christ.

**We:** Paul was referring to himself and other people who preached the message about Christ.

**proclaim Him:** The pronoun Him refers back to Christ in 1:27. In some languages it is not possible to say that

a person “proclaims a person.” What Paul meant was that he proclaimed the message about Christ.

### 1:28b

**admonishing and teaching everyone with all wisdom,**

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> warn everyone to obey/follow Christ and we<sup>(excl)</sup> teach everyone as wisely as we<sup>(excl)</sup> can.

**admonishing...everyone:** This means “warning everyone, instructing them not to do something, because it is wrong.”

**teaching everyone:** When Paul “admonished” people, he was warning them about what they should not do. When he taught them, he was telling them what they should do as Christians.

**everyone:** In the Greek text Paul emphasized the word everyone. He used it three times: “we warn everyone and we teach everyone... so that we may present everyone complete in Christ.” Paul was probably emphasizing that he did not distinguish between one Christian and another. Every Christian needs to be warned and taught so that they all will become perfect in Christ.

**with all wisdom:** The Greek says, “in all wisdom.” This type of grammatical construction in Greek usually refers to the manner in which something is done, so most English versions and commentators believe that Paul was saying here that he taught very wisely. You could also translate this:

teaching as wisely as we<sup>(excl)</sup> can

teaching using all the wisdom God has given us<sup>(excl)</sup>

### 1:28c

**so that we may present everyone perfect in Christ.**

- We<sup>(excl)</sup> do this in order that all people who are united to Christ may be spiritually mature/complete when we<sup>(excl)</sup> present them to God.
- Our<sup>(excl)</sup> desire is that by our teaching we<sup>(excl)</sup> may ensure that everyone will be a mature believer in Christ when they stand before God.

**so that we may present everyone perfect in Christ:** Paul wanted this to happen as a result of his teaching—that everyone he told about Christ would believe, grow as a Christian, and so become perfect in Christ.

**present:** This is the same verb that Paul used in 1:22c. See the note there.

**perfect:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as perfect can also mean “complete, mature, grown-up,” and many English translations use that meaning (RSV, GNT, CEV, GW, NET, NCV, REB). Here Paul meant that he wanted everyone to whom he preached to become a mature (strong) believer in Christ.

## Colossians 1:29

**Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews**

**Theme:** Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

### Paragraph 1:24–29

**Theme:** Paul willingly suffered so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would know the message about Christ.

### 1:29a

**To this end I also labor,**

- That is why I work so hard.

**To this end:** This refers back to 1:28c. The purpose for which Paul worked so hard was to “present everyone perfect in Christ.”

**I also labor:** This means, “I work hard.”

### 1:29b

**striving with all His energy working powerfully within me.**

- That is, I exert every effort to do this task by working with all the strength with which Christ empowers me.
- Christ is working in me powerfully, and I am using all the power he gives me to do this job of proclaiming the gospel.

**striving:** This means, “striving intensely, making every effort, doing everything possible.” It can refer to the struggle in an athletic contest or in a battle. However, here it does not refer to a physical effort. Paul knew that he was in a spiritual battle against Satan. Although he was in prison, he was fully committed to using all his energy to help the believers.

**with all His energy:** Paul worked hard and exerted great effort to do his job of preaching the gospel. However, he knew he did not do it by his own power. He said that it was Christ’s energy, the energy that Christ gave him, that enabled him to work as hard as he did.

**working powerfully within me:** Paul said that Christ’s energy was working powerfully in him, en-

abling him to do his job. In some languages it is not possible to talk about “Christ’s energy which so powerfully works in me.” One possible way to translate this would be:

the energy which Christ gives to me as he works in me

The UBS Handbook suggests a translation like this:

the mighty strength which Christ gives me and which shows up as I work

### General Comment about 1:28–29

In some languages it might be necessary to reorder 1:28–29. One way to do this is:

Christ’s powerful help in me enables me constantly to work hard to warn people to continue to follow Christ and to teach them more about him. I work so hard to do this because my strong desire is that every one who is united to Christ will be perfect when they stand before God.

## Colossians 2:1

### Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

#### Paragraph 2:1–5

Theme: Paul was deeply committed to helping the Colossians to understand God’s message about Christ. He knew it was important for them to understand it fully so that no one would deceive them.

#### 2:1a

#### For I want you to know how much I am struggling for you

- ¶ I want you to know that I am deeply committed to helping you in Colossae,
- ¶ I want you to know that I am doing all I can to help you Christians in Colossae,

**For:** The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces more information about how hard Paul works (1:29). Some English versions do not translate this conjunction.

**how much I am struggling:** The Greek word *agōna* that the BSB translates struggling has the same root as the word that Paul used in 1:29b. It refers to a

physical struggle, for example, an athletic contest or a battle, but also emphasizes the emotions that are involved: “I am struggling/agonizing.” In 1:28–29 Paul had said that he was struggling so that everyone might be perfect in Christ. Here in 2:1 he said that he was struggling specifically for the Christians in Colossae and for others whom he had never met and therefore had never taught.

Because Paul was in prison when he wrote this letter, he could not literally work for the Colossians by preaching or helping them in other ways, so he probably was referring to struggling by praying intensively and letter writing. You could translate this verse part as:

I want you to know how concerned I am for you.

#### 2:1b

#### and for those at Laodicea,

- and also the Christians in the town of Laodicea,
- and I am also doing all I can to help the believers in Laodicea,

**Laodicea:** Laodicea was a town northwest of Colossae, further down the Lycos river. Paul probably mentioned Laodicea because it was close to Colossae, and because he knew that the believers in Laodicea would later read this letter (see 4:16b).

#### 2:1c

#### and for all who have not met me face to face,

- and all the other Christians who have not met me personally.
- as well as all the other believers whom I have not met.

#### and for all who have not met me face to face:

Paul had never preached the gospel in either Colossae or Laodicea, but he was still concerned for believers there and in other places where he had not personally worked. In your translation, you may need to clarify that the believers in Colossae and Laodicea are included in the larger group of all who have not met me face to face. One way to do this is to translate 2:1c as:

...and for all other believers who have not met me.

Another way to do this is to reverse the order of the clauses in 2:1. For example:

I want to tell you how hard I have worked for all the believers who have never met me personally,

including you there in Colossae and also the believers in Laodicea.

## Colossians 2:2

### Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

#### Paragraph 2:1–5

Theme: Paul was deeply committed to helping the Colossians to understand God's message about Christ. He knew it was important for them to understand it fully so that no one would deceive them.

#### 2:2a

##### that they may be encouraged in heart,

- I am doing this in order to encourage you all spiritually,

**they:** This refers to all the people Paul mentioned in 2:1. This includes the Christians at Colossae, to whom Paul was directly writing, so it may be clearer for your readers if you use “you<sup>(plur)</sup>” or “all of you” here and in the rest of 2:2.

**encouraged in heart:** The Greek verb *parakaleō* that the BSB translates encouraged can also mean “strengthened” or “comforted.” Since Paul was writing to the Colossians about their need to believe strongly in the true message about Christ, he probably meant “strengthened” or “encouraged,” not “comforted.”

**in heart:** Paul used the Greek word for heart to refer to the center of a person's feelings and emotions. He meant that he wanted the Colossians to be encouraged personally, within themselves. Many English versions do not translate this part of the verse literally (see GNT, GW, NCV, NLT). There are several ways you could translate this:

- Translate literally and use your word for heart. You should only do this if the heart is considered the center of emotions in your culture.
- Use an idiom that has the same meaning in your culture.
- Translate the phrase directly, for example, “I want to encourage you spiritually” or “I want to strengthen you in your faith.”

You should use the option which is most natural in your language.

#### 2:2b

##### knit together in love,

- and so that your love for one another will unite you.
- so you will love each other more and more, and in this way you will be one united group,

**knit together in love:** Paul was concerned that the false doctrines being taught in Colossae would divide the Christians. He wanted them to be united by means of the love they had for one another as they believed the true teaching about Christ. You could translate this:

I want you all to love one another and, in that way, to be united.

#### 2:2c

##### and filled with the full riches of complete understanding,

- I want you all to have the wonderful blessings that result when you truly understand God's message and are completely sure that it is true.
- so that you will all have the great joy and assurance that people have who understand completely God's message,

**full riches:** Paul wanted the Colossians to have “all riches” that come from understanding and being certain about God's message. The word riches is used as a figure of speech here. It does not mean money or other possessions, but it means the wonderful blessings and benefits that result from understanding and being certain about God's message. This includes benefits such as joy and peace.

**complete understanding:** The Greek expression that the BSB translates complete understanding is literally “the full-assurance of understanding.” Scholars understand the word *plērophoria* (BSB complete) in two ways:

1. It means, “full assurance.” The whole expression then means that Paul wanted the Colossians to have the “complete assurance, certainty” which would come from truly understanding the message about Christ. For example:

the full wealth of assurance which true understanding brings (GNT) (GNT, KJV, NET, NLT, REB)

1. It means “fullness.” The whole expression then means “complete/full understanding.” This is how the BSB understands it. (BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, NCV, SSA)

Both of these options are possible meanings for plērophoria. The Display follows the first option (1), since most commentaries support it.

### 2:2d

**so that they may know the mystery of God, namely Christ,**

- I want you to have this assurance so that you will know God's plan that he had not revealed to people in the past. That is, I want you to know Christ himself.
- and so that you will know the secret message from God, which is Christ himself.

**the mystery of God, namely Christ:** For the meaning of mystery, see the note on 1:27a. Paul was saying that Christ is the center of God's mystery. To know God's mystery is to know about Christ, or to know Christ himself. In some languages it will be necessary to clarify this by placing the word Christ into a separate clause. For example:

I want you all to know the mystery of God, that is,  
I want you to know about Christ.

## Colossians 2:3

**Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews**

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

### Paragraph 2:1–5

Theme: Paul was deeply committed to helping the Colossians to understand God's message about Christ. He knew it was important for them to understand it fully so that no one would deceive them.

### 2:3

**in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge.**

- Only Christ is able to cause you to be wise and understand God's message, which is valuable like a treasure.
- Only Christ is able to help you to understand thoroughly this important/valuable message that God has now revealed.

**in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge:** This is a figure of speech. Here, wisdom and knowledge are like treasures that are hidden in Christ. There are two ways to understand this:

1. Paul was referring to a Christian's wisdom and knowledge. So this verse means that, just as treasure is valuable, so being wise and knowing God and God's message is very valuable. Christ is the only one who can cause us to be wise and know God and his message. (SSA)
2. Paul was referring to God's wisdom and knowledge. In this case the verse means that Christ is the only one who can cause people to know about God's wisdom and knowledge, which are very valuable. (GNT, REB; UBS Handbook).

The Display follows the first interpretation (1).

**hidden:** When Paul said that wisdom and knowledge were hidden in Christ, he did not mean that people could not get this wisdom and knowledge at all. Rather, he meant that it is in Christ and Christ alone that people can find these things. Only Christ can make people truly wise, only he reveals God's plan to mankind.

## Colossians 2:4

**Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews**

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

### Paragraph 2:1–5

Theme: Paul was deeply committed to helping the Colossians to understand God's message about Christ. He knew it was important for them to understand it fully so that no one would deceive them.

### 2:4a

**I say this**

- I am telling you this

**I say this:** The word this refers back to what Paul had been saying earlier in 1:24–2:3, especially how very important Christ is (2:3). In some languages it may be better to translate this:

I have written this to you

I have told you these things in my letter...

### 2:4b

**so that no one will deceive you by smooth rhetoric.**

- so that no one will deceive you by teaching you a false message, talking persuasively in a way that causes you to think he is right.

**so that no one will deceive you by smooth rhetoric:**

Paul had heard that there were people in Colossae who were teaching a false message. (See the Introduction to these Notes.) These teachers wanted to deceive the Colossian Christians, that is, to lead them astray, to cause them to believe their wrong teachings.

**smooth rhetoric:** This means they tried to make their teaching sound true and reasonable, so that other people would believe what they said.

**General Comment about 2:4**

One way to translate 2:4 is:

I am saying these things to you so that no one will persuade you to believe their false teachings, even if what they teach sounds believable.

**Colossians 2:5****Section 1:24–2:5: Paul told about the way he worked hard to tell the gospel to the non-Jews**

Theme: Paul willingly suffered and worked hard so that the Colossians, most of whom were not Jews, would understand the true message about Christ so thoroughly that no one would be able to deceive them.

**Paragraph 2:1–5**

Theme: Paul was deeply committed to helping the Colossians to understand God's message about Christ. He knew it was important for them to understand it fully so that no one would deceive them.

**2:5a****For although I am absent from you in body,**

- For even though I am not with you physically,
- Although I am far away from you,

**2:5b****I am present with you in spirit,**

- it is as if I am with you, because I am always thinking about you.
- I think of you continually.

**2:5a–b**

**although I am absent from you in body, I am present with you in spirit:** Be careful that you do not translate this in a way that would cause your readers to think that Paul's spirit had left his body and traveled to Colossae. When Paul said he was absent from you in body, he simply meant that he was physically far away from them, in a different city, hundreds of kilometers away. When he said he was present with you in spirit, he meant that he constantly thought about them and was concerned for them. In some languages it may be better to translate this as a simile. For example:

It is as if I am with you.

The Display shows some non-figurative ways to translate these phrases.

**2:5c****and I delight to see your orderly condition**

- I am happy because I know that you remain united
- And I am happy to hear that you are continuing to be one united group,

**and I delight to see:** Paul could not literally see the Colossians, for he was in a different city. However, although he was far away from Colossae, he was thinking about the Colossians and it was as if he could see them. Paul knew about the Colossian believers because he had heard news from Epaphras and others. In your language it might be more natural to translate the verb see using another verb. For example:

I am happy to hear...

I am happy to know/learn from what I've heard...

**your orderly condition:** Paul told the Colossian believers that he was pleased about two things. He was happy that they were orderly (2:5c), and that their faith was "firm" (2:5d). Both these words in Greek were used as military terms. The word translated orderly means "to stand together in orderly ranks," like soldiers in a military parade. There are two ways to interpret it:

1. The Colossian believers were united. (SSA, GNT, REB)
2. The Colossian believers were behaving in an orderly manner. For example:

I am glad to know you are living as you should (CEV) (CEV, NCV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), since it fits the context better. Paul was happy to hear that the Colossian believers were united and that the false teachers had not divided them. He was happy that the Colossians had not divided into groups that believed different false teachings.

**2:5d****and firm faith in Christ.**

- and that you are firmly trusting in Christ.
- and you are continuing to believe only in Christ.

**firm faith in Christ:** The Greek word that the BSB translates firm means "to maintain a firm position, to be unmoved." Although there was false teaching in

Colossae, the majority of the Christians had continued to trust firmly in Christ. You can translate firm faith in Christ as:

I am happy to hear that your faith in Christ is strong and not changing,

## Colossians 2:6

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

#### Paragraph 2:6–7

Theme: The Colossians should continue to behave in ways that people who accept Christ Jesus as their ruler should behave.

In these verses Paul began more directly to urge the Colossian believers to continue to follow Christ and to reject the false teachings they were hearing.

#### 2:6a

**Therefore, just as you have received Christ Jesus as Lord,**

- ¶ Therefore, just as you have believed the message that Christ Jesus is your master/ruler,

**Therefore:** The Greek word *oun* that the BSB translates as *Therefore* shows that Paul was basing what he was about to say on what he had already said: “So, based on what I have said, I urge you...”

**just as you have received Christ Jesus as Lord:** This means “since/because you have received Christ Jesus as Lord.”

**have received:** This can mean either “to accept something” or “to accept instruction or teaching about something.” So there are two ways to interpret this part of the verse:

1. The Colossians had believed the teaching that Christ Jesus was the Lord, the supreme ruler of the universe and of all his people.
2. The Colossians had accepted Christ Jesus as their Lord, that is, as their ruler or chief, the one whom they obey.

Both of these interpretations are true, and Paul probably did not distinguish between them in his mind. However in his letters, Paul used this word most frequently to mean, “to accept teaching about something” (see 1 Corinthians 11:23, 15:3; Galatians 1:9, 1:12; 1 Thessalonians 2:13). Therefore, it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

If you want to follow the second interpretation (2), you could translate this part of the verse:

So then, since you have acknowledged that Christ Jesus is your Lord...

So then, since you have said, “Christ Jesus is my Lord,”...

The form of the word received in Greek shows that it refers to an action that had been completed, that is, at some time in the past the Colossians had heard and believed the teaching about Christ.

#### 2:6b

**continue to walk in Him,**

- continue to behave as people who belong to him should behave.
- you must do what he wants you to do at all times, since you are united to him.

**continue to walk in Him:** The Greek translated literally says, “walk in him.” This is a figure of speech that means, “behave every day like someone who is united to Christ.” The verb is in the present tense, meaning, “continue to behave....” Paul was writing about the way the Colossians should act/behave every day.

**in Him:** Paul urged his readers to walk in Him. This meant that the way they behaved should be based on the fact that they were united to Christ.

## Colossians 2:7

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:6–7

Theme: The Colossians should continue to behave in ways that people who accept Christ Jesus as their ruler should behave.

In these verses Paul began more directly to urge the Colossian believers to continue to follow Christ and to reject the false teachings they were hearing.

### 2:7

In 2:6 Paul gave his main command in this paragraph —“continue to walk in him.” In 2:7 Paul used three phrases to explain how the Colossians should “walk in Christ.” He told them to be “rooted and built up in Him” (2:7a), “established in the faith” (2:7b), and “overflowing with thankfulness” (2:7c).

### 2:7a

#### **rooted and built up in Him,**

- Remain firmly established in your faith in Christ like a plant rooted in the ground, and continue to increase your trust in him,
- That is, having firmly believed the true message about Christ, continue to learn more and more about him,
- Continue to believe firmly the message about Christ, and become stronger in your relationship with him,

**rooted...in Him:** This is the first of two figures of speech in this part of the verse. The form of this verb once more shows that this was an action that had been completed. When the Colossians believed the gospel, they became like a plant that has its roots deep in the soil and stays firmly in place. Paul was telling them to continue to believe firmly all the main teachings about Christ, and not to begin to believe different teachings.

**built up in Him:** This is the second figure of speech in this part of the verse. Paul was telling the Colossians that in the same way that a building is larger when it is built higher/taller, so their relationship with Christ should grow larger. Paul did not specify exactly what he meant by this. He may have meant that he wanted the Colossians to continue to know more about Christ, or he may have meant that they should continue to trust more in Christ.

The form of the verb shows that this is a continuous action, that is, that Paul wanted the Colossians to continue to be built up in Christ more each day.

If it is not possible for you to use these figures of speech in your language, you could:

- translate the meaning with no figures of speech,
- use a figure of speech from your language which has the same meaning.

One way you could translate this with no figures of speech is:

You have firmly believed and trusted in him, so continue to do this and continue to grow in your relationship with him.

### 2:7b

#### **established in the faith as you were taught,**

- and continue to be convinced/sure that what people taught you about Christ is the truth,
- and you must continue to believe more and more strongly in what your teachers taught you about Christ,

**established in the faith as you were taught:** There are two ways to understand the faith here:

1. It refers to all the true teachings about Christ. So Paul wanted the Colossians to grow stronger and more convinced about the true Christian message. SSA and many commentaries support this view.
2. It refers to personal faith in Christ. So Paul wanted the Colossians to grow stronger in their own faith. For example:

become ever stronger in your faith (GNT) (CEV, GNT, NET, UBS Handbook).

Most English versions translate this phrase ambiguously. Because the phrase as you were taught follows the words the faith, the first option (1) is probably correct in this context. Paul wanted the Colossians to become more and more convinced that the faith they had been taught was true.

**established:** The Greek word *bebaioō* that the BSB translates established means “to make sure, to confirm.” So 2:7b means, “Continue to be convinced/sure that the things you have been taught are true.”

**as you were taught:** Paul mentioned in 1:7 that Epaphras was one of the people who taught the Colossians about Christ. If it is not possible in your language to use a passive (you were taught), you could say:

like people taught you

like Epaphras and others taught you

### 2:7c

#### and overflowing with thankfulness.

- and be continually very thankful to God.
- and when you talk to God always thank him for all that he has done for you.

**overflowing with thankfulness:** This means being very thankful to God. Paul was not writing about being thankful in a general sense.

## Colossians 2:8

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:8–15

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians to make sure that the false teachers did not deceive them with their deceptive Greek philosophies and ideas about the spirit world.

Paul stated his main point at the beginning of this paragraph: “See to it that no one takes you captive...” (2:8a). You need to make this main point clear in your translation.

### 2:8a

#### See to it that no one takes you captive

- ¶ Be careful! Do not let anyone force you to believe
- ¶ Make sure you do not allow anyone to trap you into believing

**See to it:** This is a warning, it means, “Watch out!” “Be careful!” “Pay attention!” “Make sure that...”

**that no one takes you captive:** This is a figure of speech. When a person is captured, he is forced to do whatever his captors want. In the same way the false

teachers wanted to make the Colossian believers believe them and do whatever they commanded. So Paul means, “Be careful. Do not let anybody trick you and tell you what you must believe.” The SSA says, “Make sure that no one makes you become his disciple.”

### 2:8b

#### through philosophy and empty deception,

- their ideas about God/religion. What they teach is worthless and is not based on the truth.
- what they discuss about God/religion. What they teach may sound wise/true, but it is false and worthless.

**philosophy and empty deception:** Among the non-Christian Greek people, there were many philosophers. A philosopher is a person who spends most of his time thinking and teaching about the gods and supernatural spirits. The Greek people admired and respected these philosophers very much. It seems that some of the Greek Christians in Colossae were thinking up ideas about God in this way, but their ideas were wrong. Paul was afraid that other Christians in Colossae would be led astray by listening to their teaching.

**philosophy:** Here are some other ways to translate this word:

human wisdom (GNT)

teaching/ideas about God/spirits

**empty:** Paul said that the things they taught were empty, that is, “worthless, having no value,” their teachings did not help anyone truly to know God.

**deception:** He also said that what they taught caused deception. This word implies that what they taught sounded true and wise, but it was wrong, and it deceived people.

### 2:8c–e

In 2:8c–e, Paul used three phrases to describe in more detail what these people taught.

### 2:8c

#### which are based on human tradition

- The things they teach are merely ideas that have been passed on from other people,
- It is based only on ideas which people have invented,

**which are based on human tradition:** A literal translation of the Greek is “according to the traditions of people.” Paul wanted to emphasize that these teach-

ings were from people, not from God. These were ideas that people had invented, not truths that God revealed. Here is another way to translate this clause:

only human teachings (CEV)

**tradition:** Traditions are normally ideas and customs that have been passed-down/imparted from older people to younger people. The same Greek word is used in Matthew 15:2–3, 15:6; 1 Corinthians 11:2; 2 Thessalonians 2:15, 3:6. If you have an expression in your language for teachings that the elders tell to younger people, you may be able to use it here.

### 2:8d and the spiritual forces of the world

- and they teach people to follow rules that concern things in this world

**and:** This verse part is parallel to 2:8c and begins with the same Greek word *kata* “according to.” The things the false teachers taught depended on two things: “human tradition” (2:8c) and “the basic principles of this world” (see NIV alternative source line for 2:8d). The BSB uses the word and here to show that the false teaching came from “the basic principles of this world” in a similar way to how it came from “human tradition.”

**the spiritual forces of the world:** The NIV translates this Greek phrase: “basic principles of the world.” The reason there are two different translations is because the Greek word *stoicheia* that the BSB translates spiritual forces and the NIV translates “basic principles” has two meanings:

1. It could mean, “elementary principles and rules about behavior.” (NIV, NJB, SSA)
2. It could refer to “the heavenly bodies,” that is, the sun, moon, and stars. In this context it would refer specifically to the spirits whom the Greeks believed were in control of these bodies. (BSB, GNT, RSV, CEV, NCV, NET, NLT, REB)

Although most English versions prefer the second option (2), the commentaries are fairly equally divided. The first option is recommended here (1) because it makes best sense in the context. Paul was talking about false teaching. He used this same word *stoicheia* in 2:20, where he followed it immediately with a list of rules that people had made. Therefore, in this context Paul probably meant the basic religious rules which people invent.

**of the world:** There are two ways to understand this:

1. It mean that these were rules about the world and the things in the world, that is, rules about external things, such as food, clothes, ceremonies, etc. See SSA.
2. It means that people invented these rules. So world here means “people in the world.”

Both are possible in the context. However when Paul wrote more about this in 2:16, 20–23, he explicitly referred to laws concerning external things, so it is best to follow the same interpretation here.

If you wish to follow the second option, you could say:

And they teach people to obey regulations that people have invented.

### 2:8e rather than on Christ.

- rather than teaching the true message about Christ.
- rather than depending on the true teaching about Christ.

**rather than on Christ:** A literal English translation of the Greek is “and not according to Christ.” This is in contrast to 2:8c–d where Paul had described the two things on which the false teachers depended for their teaching. Here Paul said what they did not depend on.

These words have two possible meanings:

1. The things the false teachers taught were not the true teachings about Christ. SSA expresses this: “it teaches what is contrary to the true teachings about Christ.” (BSB, NIV, REB)
2. What the false teachers taught was not from Christ. That is, it did not agree with what Christ taught and the truth he gave to his followers. (GNT, CEV, NCV, NLT)

Both interpretations are possible and their meaning is very similar. However, the first one is closer to the normal meaning of the Greek word *kata* “according to,” which Paul used to begin each phrase in 2:8c–e, so the first interpretation is recommended (1).

## Colossians 2:9

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

**Theme:** Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:8–15

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians to make sure that the false teachers did not deceive them with their deceptive Greek philosophies and ideas about the spirit world.

Paul stated his main point at the beginning of this paragraph: “See to it that no one takes you captive...” (2:8a). You need to make this main point clear in your translation.

### 2:9

**For in Christ all the fullness of the Deity dwells in bodily form.**

- Do not let these people deceive you, for in his human body Christ has all of God’s nature.
- For even when Christ became a man, he was still completely God.

**For:** Beginning with 2:9, Paul gave the Colossian believers some reasons why they should not believe the false teachers. The Greek word *hoti* that the BSB translates *For* connects 2:9 with 2:8. Paul was saying: “Do not let them deceive you, for ...”

**in Christ all the fullness of the Deity dwells in bodily form:** This verse is similar to 1:19. In 1:19 Paul said that God decided to have “all His fullness” live in Christ. In 2:9 Paul explained more clearly what this meant. He says all the fullness of the Deity dwells bodily in Christ. In the Greek sentence structure, Paul emphasized the words in Christ (literally: “in him”). You may be able to express this: “For it is in Christ and in Christ alone that all the fullness of the Deity lives in bodily form.”

**all the fullness of the Deity:** See the note on 1:19. When Paul said that all the fullness of the Deity is in Christ, this implied that Christ alone has all the power and authority that God has.

**Deity:** The Greek word *theotēs* that the BSB translates *Deity* comes from the Greek word *theos* “God.” It means all that God is: his nature, his power, and his perfection. So when Paul said that “all the fullness of the Deity” lived in Christ, he meant that Christ is fully God. All that God is, Christ is also.

**dwells:** The Greek verb *katoikeō* that the BSB translates *dwells* means, “stays, lives, remains.” Paul used the same verb in 1:19, but there he used a past tense. Here he used the present tense, and so it means that all God’s nature is now permanently in Christ.

**in bodily form:** This refers to the fact that Christ was born and he became a human being with a human body. Even then, Christ had all of God’s nature in him.

## Colossians 2:10

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:8–15

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians to make sure that the false teachers did not deceive them with their deceptive Greek philosophies and ideas about the spirit world.

Paul stated his main point at the beginning of this paragraph: “See to it that no one takes you captive...” (2:8a). You need to make this main point clear in your translation.

### 2:10a

**And you have been made complete in Christ,**

- And you, by being united to Christ, are spiritually complete.
- And you are connected to Christ, so you have all that you need spiritually.

**And you have been made complete in Christ:** The BSB used the word “fullness” in 2:9, where it referred to God’s nature. However, the meaning is not the same in this verse. Here it means “you are complete because you are united to Christ.” If someone trusts in Christ, he has all that he needs in order to be saved, so he does not need to listen to what false teachers say.

### 2:10b

**who is the head over every ruler and authority.**

- He is the one who rules over every being who rules and has authority.

**who is the head over:** This is a figure of speech that means “who rules over, who is chief over.” See the note on 1:18a.

**every ruler and authority:** When Paul used the words ruler and authority together in this way, he probably referred to all spirit beings, such as angels and demons. He used the same words in 1:16d. See the note there. You can translate this in one of two ways:

- In a general sense. For example:

every ruler and authority (BSB) (BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NLT, REB)

- In a way that refers specifically to spirits. (See 2:10 in the USB Handbook.) For example:

every spiritual ruler and authority (GNT) (GNT)

## Colossians 2:11

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:8–15

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians to make sure that the false teachers did not deceive them with their deceptive Greek philosophies and ideas about the spirit world.

Paul stated his main point at the beginning of this paragraph: “See to it that no one takes you captive...” (2:8a). You need to make this main point clear in your translation.

### 2:11–15

In 2:10 Paul said “you have been given fullness in Christ.” This was a general statement. Here in 2:11–15

Paul described in more detail the fullness believers have in Christ through salvation.

### 2:11a

#### In Him you were also circumcised,

- Because you are united to Christ, it is as if you were circumcised,

**In Him you were also circumcised:** In this verse Paul used the Jewish rite of circumcision as a figure of speech for what Christ has done for believers. You should keep this figure of speech in your translation if possible. Paul used this figure of speech for two reasons:

1. When the Jews circumcised a baby boy, they removed a piece of skin, and Paul was comparing this to Christ removing the sinful nature of those who believe in him.
2. Also, circumcision was the rite that marked the Jews as God’s people. When a boy was circumcised, this was the sign that he was part of God’s people, the Jews. Here Paul was saying that the Colossian Christians did not become the people of God because someone physically circumcised them, but because Christ freed them from the old sinful way they used to behave.

### 2:11b

#### in the putting off of your sinful nature,

- and your sinful nature was removed.
- and you were freed from the power of your evil desires.

**in the putting off of your sinful nature:** The Greek word *apekdisis* that the BSB translates as putting off is used for “removing, stripping off” something, such as clothes. In this context Paul used it as a figure of speech. When a person is circumcised, the priest removes a piece of skin from his body. In the same way, when a person is united with Christ, Christ removes his sinful nature.

**sinful nature:** Literally “body of flesh.” Paul was referring to human nature, which is naturally sinful. GNT translates it, “this sinful self” (see 2:11 in GNT). If it is not possible in your language to talk about “removing” sins, you can say:

he freed us from the power that sin has in our hearts

### 2:11c

#### with the circumcision performed by Christ

- It was Christ who removed your sinful nature.

**with the circumcision performed by Christ:** Paul said it was Christ who removed a person's sinful nature. It is "the circumcision done by Christ" (see 2:11 in GNT, NIV).

**2:11d  
and not by human hands.**

- I do not mean that somebody circumcised you physically.
- This did not happen by being circumcised physically.

**and not by human hands:** By saying this, Paul explained that he was not writing about literal circumcision. The phrase not by human hands means "this is not something that people did to you," or "you were not circumcised physically."

**General Comment about 2:11**

It may be clearer in some languages to reorder the parts of 2:11. One way to do this might be:

When you were united to Christ, it is as if you were circumcised. You were not circumcised physically. No, rather it was Christ who circumcised you spiritually; he cut away and removed your sinful nature.

## Colossians 2:12

**Section 2:6–23: Behave as God's people should behave and do not follow false teaching**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

**Paragraph 2:8–15**

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians to make sure that the false teachers did not deceive them with their deceptive Greek philosophies and ideas about the spirit world.

Paul stated his main point at the beginning of this paragraph: "See to it that no one takes you cap-

tive..." (2:8a). You need to make this main point clear in your translation.

**2:12**

In 2:11 Paul used circumcision as a figure of speech to describe what Christ does when a person becomes a Christian: he removes the person's old, sinful nature. In 2:12 Paul used a different figure of speech: baptism. Baptism also describes and symbolizes what happens when a person becomes a Christian, but it includes something extra. In baptism, not only is the old, sinful nature put to death, but also God gives the person a new nature. Paul compared the death of the old sinful nature and the receiving of the new nature to the death and resurrection of Christ.

**2:12a**

**And having been buried with Him in baptism,**

- When you were baptized, it showed that your sinful nature was buried just like Christ was buried,
- When you were baptized, it was as if you had died and been buried with Christ,

**And having been buried with Him in baptism:** Paul compared the death of a person's old sinful nature to Christ's death and burial. Here Paul said that when a Christian is baptized, the act of going into the water is like being buried. In 2:12b he said that the act of coming out of the water is like rising from death. Therefore, baptism shows what happens when a person becomes a Christian—his old nature dies and he receives a new nature.

Since Paul was not writing about being literally buried, in your translation you may want to say something like this:

When you were baptized, it is as if you died and were buried together with Christ,

You may also want to repeat your translation of the phrase "sinful nature" from 2:11 in your translation as follows:

When you were baptized, your sinful nature died and was buried just like Christ,

**with Him:** The phrase with Him means "together with Christ" or "just like Christ." It shows that Christians identify with Christ. Be careful not to translate this phrase in a way that implies that Christians were buried beside/alongside Christ at the same time as he was.

**in baptism:** This means "When you were baptized..." or "At the time of your baptism..."

**2:12b****you were raised with Him**

- and you were raised with a new nature just like Christ was raised to life.
- and then it was as if you had been raised from death with him.

**you were raised with Him:** The BSB implies that the phrase “in baptism” is only connected to the verb “buried.” However, in Greek this phrase actually is connected to the verb raised in 2:12b as well as to the verb “buried” in 2:12a. Therefore, Paul was comparing a person coming out of the water after being baptized to someone rising from the dead. This is the second part of Paul’s figure of speech. Paul was comparing the way God raised Jesus from death with the way he gives a new nature to believers.

**with Him:** As in 2:12b, this phrase with Him shows that people who are baptized identify with Christ. It does not mean that people were raised from the dead at the same time as Christ was.

**2:12c****through your faith in the power of God, who raised Him from the dead.**

- This happened to you because you believed that God who raised Christ to life had the power to do it.
- This happened because you believed that God’s power to raise Christ from the dead would raise you with a new nature also.
- This happened because you believed that God, by his power, raised Christ to life again after he had died.

**through your faith in the power of God, who raised Him from the dead:** This means that believers are given a new nature by believing that God has the power to do it just as he had the power to raise Jesus from the dead.

**Colossians 2:13****Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they

should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

**Paragraph 2:8–15**

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians to make sure that the false teachers did not deceive them with their deceptive Greek philosophies and ideas about the spirit world.

Paul stated his main point at the beginning of this paragraph: “See to it that no one takes you captive...” (2:8a). You need to make this main point clear in your translation.

**2:13–15**

In Greek, 2:13–15 is one long, complicated sentence. Most English versions divide it into several sentences. You will probably need to do this in your translation, too.

**2:13a****When you were dead in your trespasses**

- And as for you Gentiles, before you believed in Christ you were spiritually dead because you were sinful,
- You who are not Jews were separated from God because you had broken God’s laws,

**you:** Paul used an emphatic pronoun you here. In English, this can be expressed “It was you...” If you have special pronouns in your language to show such emphasis, you should use one here.

**dead in your trespasses:** Paul was writing about what the Colossians were like before they believed in Jesus. This is a figure of speech that means, “you were spiritually dead because you were continually behaving in sinful ways.” Because of the sinful things they did, it was not possible for them to have eternal life and be with God forever.

If you want to keep the figure of speech dead in your translation, you may need to clarify that Paul was not writing about physical death. For example, you could say:

it was as if you were dead

you were dead spiritually

If you cannot keep the figure of speech in your translation, you could say:

you were separated from God because you had sinned

**trespasses:** Paul did not use the normal Greek word for trespasses here, but he used the word *paraptōma*, which means “transgressions, actions that break the law.” Most modern English versions use the word “sins.” Unless you have a word that specifically means “transgressions,” you should probably also use your normal term for “sins” in this verse.

### 2:13b

#### and in the uncircumcision of your sinful nature,

- and because you were not free from the power of your sinful nature.
- and because God had not yet removed your sinful nature.

#### and in the uncircumcision of your sinful nature:

Here Paul gave a second reason why the Colossians had been dead spiritually. There are two main interpretations of this part of the verse:

1. Some scholars think that Paul was talking about spiritual circumcision, as in 2:11. For example:

you were uncircumcised spiritually, that is, you were controlled by your evil nature (SSA)

your sinful nature was not yet cut away (NLT) (GW, NCV, NLT, SSA)

1. Some scholars think that Paul meant literal circumcision, that is, that the Colossians were Gentiles and so had not been circumcised according to the law of Moses. For example:

you were Gentiles without the Law (GNT) (GNT, NJB, REB)

Both interpretations have strong commentary support. The Display follows the first interpretation—that Paul used the term uncircumcision as a figure of speech, similar to 2:11. The uncircumcision of your sinful nature means “your sinful nature had not been removed,” or “God had not freed you from the power of your sinful nature.”

However, if you want to follow the second interpretation, you could say:

You were spiritually dead...because you were Gentiles and did not know God.

### 2:13c

#### God made you alive with Christ.

- But God raised you up to live a new life with Christ.

- But even though you were like that, God gave you new spiritual life. It was just as if he caused you to live again, together with Christ.

**God made you alive with Christ:** This is similar to what Paul said in 2:12b: “[you were] raised with him/[Christ].” Paul was saying that although the Colossians had been spiritually dead (2:13a), when they became Christians, God made them spiritually alive.

### 2:13d

#### He forgave us all our trespasses,

- God forgave us<sup>(incl)</sup> for all our sins.
- He forgave us<sup>(incl)</sup> for all the sinful things that we<sup>(incl)</sup> had done.

**He forgave us all our trespasses:** He refers to God. Notice that Paul changed here from saying “you” to us.

**trespasses:** This is the same word Paul used in 2:13a. You should translate it in the same way here.

## Colossians 2:14

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:8–15

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians to make sure that the false teachers did not deceive them with their deceptive Greek philosophies and ideas about the spirit world.

Paul stated his main point at the beginning of this paragraph: “See to it that no one takes you captive...” (2:8a). You need to make this main point clear in your translation.

### 2:14a

#### having canceled the debt ascribed to us in the decrees that stood against us.

- It was as if God had erased the record of our<sup>(incl)</sup> sins that stated the charges against us.

- He did this by erasing the document that condemned us<sup>(incl)</sup> because of all our sins.

**having canceled the debt ascribed to us in the decrees:** Scholars understand this in one of two ways:

1. The word that the BSB translates as the debt is literally “record of debts” in Greek. Here it is used as a figure of speech. Paul was using legal language to explain how God sets people free from the guilt that is the result of sin. In the court, a person’s debts were written either on a papyrus or on a clay tablet. When the debts were paid, the papyrus or clay tablet was wiped clean and there was no more record of debts or charges against the person.
2. The BSB phrase the debt refers to the written Jewish law with all of its many regulations. Paul was saying that the law was against us and opposed to us because God condemned the people who did not obey these regulations. Therefore, when Christ died on the cross, God broke the power that the law has.

There are valid reasons to choose either of these interpretations. The Display follows the first option (1) for the following reasons:

1. The Greek word that the BSB translates the debt was a common term used in Greek courts. It was a written statement of the charges against a person. The Greek word that the BSB translates decrees usually referred to an official proclamation of the charges against the person. Therefore, it appears to refer to the official written statement of the charges against sinners.
2. The words that Paul used about the document being canceled and “taken away” seem too strong to refer to what happened to the law of Moses when Christ died. Jesus himself said that he did not come to destroy the Law but to fulfill it (Matthew 5:17).

**canceled:** The Greek word that the BSB translates canceled means “to erase, wipe out.” When God forgives someone, it is as if he “erases” everything that was written down about that person—all his sins and guilt.

**that stood against us:** In Greek Paul says that “the debt ascribed to us in the decrees” was against us and “stood opposed to us” (NIV). These two phrases are similar and it is difficult to find a difference between them. So most modern English versions combine them into one phrase, like the BSB’s stood against us. (See GNT, GW, RSV, CEV, NCV, NJB, NLT.) Unless you have a clear way to make a difference between the two phrases, you should follow one of these versions. For example:

the charges which were brought against us (GW)

## 2:14b

### He took it away, nailing it to the cross!

- That is, it was as if he destroyed that record by nailing it to the cross when Jesus died.
- He removed that document completely when Christ was nailed to the cross and died.

**nailing it to the cross!:** This is another figure of speech. There were no lists of sins nailed to the cross on which Jesus died. However, when Christ was nailed to the cross he suffered the punishment for the sins of all people. So it was as if everyone’s sins were nailed to the cross in the body of Christ. If your readers are confused by this figure of speech, you could try translating this part of the verse without using the figure of speech; see the second meaning line in the Display for one way to do this.

## Colossians 2:15

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:8–15

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians to make sure that the false teachers did not deceive them with their deceptive Greek philosophies and ideas about the spirit world.

Paul stated his main point at the beginning of this paragraph: “See to it that no one takes you captive...” (2:8a). You need to make this main point clear in your translation.

## 2:15a

### And having disarmed the powers and authorities,

- When at that time God defeated the evil spirits/beings who rule and have authority,

- Not only did God forgive us, but also when he had broken the power of the powerful ruling spirits,

**And having disarmed the powers and authorities:**

The words powers and authorities are the same words that Paul used in 1:16d and 2:10b. See the notes about these verses. Paul was referring to spirit powers and authorities who were against God and who were controlling people. See also Ephesians 6:12.

**disarmed:** The Greek word *apekdumai* that the BSB translates disarmed means “to undress.” In this context it means that God took away the power from these “powers and authorities.”

**2:15b**

**He made a public spectacle of them, triumphing over them by the cross.**

- he showed everyone that he had defeated them by means of Christ dying on the cross.
- he let it be known openly that Christ had defeated those evil spirits when he died on the cross.

**He made a public spectacle of them:** This means that God shamed the powers and authorities publicly, and he made it obvious to everyone that he had defeated them.

**He:** Scholars do not agree about who this pronoun “he” refers to:

1. Most scholars say that it is God. It was God who “made a public spectacle of” the powers and authorities, in the same way that he “made you alive with Christ” (2:13c). This is how most English versions translate this verse. (BSB, NIV, RSV, GW, NCV, NLT, REB, SSA)
2. Some scholars say that Christ is the subject of the verb “triumphing over” (and therefore of the verb “disarmed” in 2:15a). See GNT and CEV.

The first option is recommended (1). It is clear that God is the subject of all the main verbs in 2:13–14. If Paul had changed the subject of the verbs in 2:15 to Christ, he probably would have clarified this by using a noun (Christ) rather than a pronoun He.

**triumphing over them:** The Greek verb *thriambeuō* that the BSB translates as triumphing over means “to lead in a victory parade.” Paul may have been thinking about the way, after a great victory, a Roman general would lead his prisoners of war in a public procession through the streets of the city of Rome. This is how several English versions translate it (see 2:15 in GNT, CEV, NJB, REB). When Christ died on the cross, it showed openly that God had defeated Satan and all the evil powers. It was as if God had captured them and was parading them for everyone to see.

**by the cross:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as the cross is an ambiguous pronoun. It could mean “it” or “him.” It could refer to one of two things:

1. It could refer to the cross. (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, KJV, NCV, NLT, NRSV, REB).
2. It could refer to Christ. (RSV, GW, NJB, SSA).

The commentaries are equally divided about which of these two options they support, so both options are possible. The meaning is almost the same—God triumphed by Christ and his death on the cross.

## Colossians 2:16

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:16–19

Theme: Paul told the Colossians not to believe the teachings of those people who wanted them to obey their rules. They should trust only in Christ.

### 2:16a

#### Therefore let no one judge you

- ¶ Therefore based on what I have said, I urge you: do not allow anyone to criticize you
- ¶ Therefore pay no attention to any people who say you are wrong

**Therefore:** The same Greek word *oun* that Paul used at the beginning of 2:6a is used here. It shows that Paul was beginning again to urge the Colossians to do something based on what he had just said. If you need to clarify this connection to the previous paragraph, you could begin this paragraph: “So then, based on what I have said, I urge you...”

**let no one judge you:** Apparently there were people in Colossae who believed and taught that Christians must obey certain laws and customs. If a Christian did not obey these rules, these people criticized/condemned him and said that he was not behaving as a

Christian should. Another way to say this is “Do not pay attention to people who criticize you...”

**no one:** In some languages it may be better to translate this using a plural: “Do not let any people criticize you...” Paul was referring to any person or group of people that was criticizing the believers in Colossae and trying to make them believe that they needed to do more than just believe in Christ in order to be saved.

#### 2:16b

##### by what you eat or drink,

- because you do not obey their rules that forbid people from eating or drinking certain things,
- because you eat certain foods or drink certain drinks which they say you should not,

**by what you eat or drink:** These false teachers were saying that people should not eat certain foods or drink certain drinks. These rules may have been those that the Jews followed (for example, the Jews were not allowed to eat blood or the meat from pigs and certain other animals), or other general rules similar to the Jewish rules. If you have words in your language for these kind of food taboos, you may be able to use those terms here.

#### 2:16c

##### or with regard to a feast, a New Moon, or a Sabbath.

- or because you do not participate in certain celebrations like their annual religious festivals, or when they celebrate the new moon, or the Sabbath.
- or because you do not celebrate their religious festivals, or celebrate with them when the new moon appears, or keep the Sabbath day like they do.

**or with regard to a feast, a New Moon, or a Sabbath:** The false teachers also taught that, in order to be holy, people must obey rules about what they could do on certain days. These again were probably like the Jewish customs.

**a feast:** The Jews celebrated several yearly festivals, for example, Passover, the Day of Atonement, the Feast of Tabernacles. Paul was probably referring to annual celebrations like these.

**a New Moon:** The Jews also had special ceremonies each month when the New Moon appeared. The new moon is the term for the moon on the night after the moon is completely dark, when a small piece of the moon begins to be bright again.

**a Sabbath:** Saturday was the Jewish Sabbath (day of rest). It was a special day for the Jews; they did not work that day and had special ceremonies. See “Sabbath” in KBT and the glossary for more information.

## Colossians 2:17

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

#### Paragraph 2:16–19

Theme: Paul told the Colossians not to believe the teachings of those people who wanted them to obey their rules. They should trust only in Christ.

#### 2:17a

##### These are a shadow of the things to come,

- Do not listen to them, because all those laws are only like a shadow. They are nothing more than symbols of the good things that God promised us.
- Do not heed those people, because those rules are merely symbols that God gave to his people long ago to tell them about the Messiah that he was going to send.
- God gave the Jews these laws and holy days to show them in advance something about the Savior he planned to send to them.

**a shadow of the things to come:** This is a figure of speech. A person’s shadow shows something about what that person is like. In a similar way, the Jewish laws about food and the celebration of religious festivals helped the Jews to know, before he came, something about the Messiah, the Savior whom God had promised to send them. The Jewish holy days all had a spiritual significance for the Jewish people associated with the coming of the Messiah, God’s chosen Savior. The Passover represented the eternal salvation which the Messiah would make possible. Pentecost represented the time when God’s law would be in the hearts of people, through the coming of the Holy Spirit, and the Feast of Tabernacles represented the gathering in of people from all nations to God.

#### 2:17b

##### but the body that casts it belongs to Christ.

- It is Christ of whom all those laws are symbols.
- Christ fulfills what God promised, and so those things are no longer necessary.

**but the body that casts it belongs to Christ:** This phrase continues the figure of speech from 2:17a. All the rules and customs were like a “shadow,” but Christ is like the body that makes the shadow.

#### General Comment about 2:17

If you need to explain this figure of speech in your translation, you could say something like:

These regulations are like a shadow that is cast by someone who is approaching; that is, they only represent the spiritual blessings that Christ himself has now given to you (adapted from SSA of 2:17).

## Colossians 2:18

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

#### Paragraph 2:16–19

Theme: Paul told the Colossians not to believe the teachings of those people who wanted them to obey their rules. They should trust only in Christ.

#### 2:18a

### Do not let anyone who delights in false humility and the worship of angels

- Do not let anyone insist that you humble yourself and worship angels like they do.

**anyone who delights in false humility and the worship of angels:** There are several problems with this part of the verse.

**anyone who delights in:** There are two ways to understand the Greek verb that the BSB translates delights in:

1. It means, “insists on.” Paul was referring to people who insisted that other people must also show this false humility and must worship angels, like they did. That is, “these people insist that you humble yourselves...” (RSV, GNT, NCV, SSA)
2. It means, “enjoys” or delights in, as in the BSB. Paul was referring to people who enjoyed making themselves humble and worshiping angels. (NIV, CEV, GW, NET, NJB, REB)

In 2:16 Paul had already discussed the religious rules these people were telling the Colossians to obey, so it is likely that he was continuing to write about this in 2:18. Therefore it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

**false humility:** The Greek word literally means “humble-minded.” The word can also be used about true humility (see Acts 20:19), but here in 2:18 Paul used it with a negative meaning. These people said that they were humble, but in fact, they were very proud of all they did.

It may also imply that they practiced strict fasting and denying themselves luxuries to make their bodies suffer. In 2:23 the same Greek word is used, and it clearly means this. They thought that they could make themselves acceptable to God by their own efforts.

**the worship of angels:** Apparently in Colossae some people in the church believed they should worship angels and were telling other Christians that they should do so also.

#### 2:18b

### disqualify you

- That will cause you to lose the reward that God has promised to you.
- If you follow their teachings, you will lose the reward God has promised you.

**disqualify you:** This phrase in the BSB is translated from a single Greek word that has two meanings:

1. It means, “to deprive someone of their rights or of the prize they deserve.” So Paul meant, “Do not let anyone cheat/rob you and take away your prize”. (BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, KJV, NCV, NJB, REB)
2. It means, “to pass judgment on.” So Paul meant: “Do not let anyone act as your judge and say that you are not worthy to get the prize,” or more simply, “Do not let anyone condemn you.” (GNT, NET, NLT)

The Display uses the first meaning (1), although the second meaning is also possible. If you want to follow the second meaning in your translation, you could translate 2:18a–b like this:

Do not allow anyone to condemn you because you do not humble yourselves and worship angels like they do.

### 2:18c

#### with speculation about what he has seen.

- A person who teaches like that bases his authority to teach these things on visions which he claims to have seen.
- These people say that they have special knowledge about God because they have seen visions.

**with speculation:** The Greek word *embateuō* that the BSB translates as with speculation does not occur anywhere else in the NT. Its primary meaning is “to step on” or “to frequent.” However, it can also mean:

1. “To take a stand on.” That is, these people claimed that they had authority to teach these things because of the visions they had seen. For example:

anyone who claims to be superior because he has seen special visions (GNT) (GNT, RSV, SSA)

1. “To investigate,” and therefore to continue to give many details about what they had seen. (NIV, CEV, GW, NET, NRSV)

Both these meanings are possible. The Display uses the first option (1), which fits the context well.

**about what he has seen:** Paul was referring to the visions that these false teachers said they had seen.

### 2:18d

#### Such a person is puffed up without basis by his unspiritual mind.

- He is very proud of all the ideas he has invented. But he has no reason to be proud.
- His ideas come from his own mind, and they cause him to be proud. But actually he does not have any reason to be proud.

**Such a person:** As he did in 2:16a and 2:18a, Paul was not writing about only one person, but about any person or group of people who taught these false teachings. You can use either a singular or a plural here, whichever is natural in your language.

**is puffed up:** This means “to be proud” but in a negative way, that is, it means “to think of oneself as better than other people.”

**without basis:** The Greek word that the BSB translates without basis means “at random, for no purpose/reason.” It means these people were proud even though there was no reason for them to be proud.

**his unspiritual mind:** Paul said that this kind of person became proud because of his unspiritual mind (literally: “the mind of his flesh”). This can be interpreted in two ways:

1. The phrase his unspiritual mind means “his human way of thinking”. In other words, these people were proud because of ideas they thought up themselves. (BSB, GNT, NCV, NRSV, REB)
2. “Flesh” means “sinful nature.” So this phrase means that these people were proud “because of their sinful thoughts”. (CEV, GW, NET, NLT, SSA)

Both these interpretations are acceptable. The Display follows the first one (1). Paul’s point was that these people were proud because of their own thoughts, thoughts that came from their own worldly minds, not from God.

## Colossians 2:19

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:16–19

Theme: Paul told the Colossians not to believe the teachings of those people who wanted them to obey their rules. They should trust only in Christ.

### 2:19a

#### He has lost connection to the head,

- He has stopped believing and teaching the true message about Christ, the head of the body.

**He has lost connection to the head:** The Greek literally says “not holding on to the head.” Obviously Paul did not mean holding on physically to “the head” (Christ). There are two ways to understand this figure of speech:

1. Paul meant that such people did not “hold firmly to the true teachings about Christ.” This means that

they did not faithfully believe and teach what is true about Christ.

2. Paul meant that such people no longer trusted in Christ to save them. This could be translated: “he is no longer loyal to Christ,” or “he ceases to depend on Christ” (UBS Handbook).

The first interpretation is recommended (1) because it fits best with the warning Paul was giving the Colossian believers in this letter—that they should not follow the false teachings these people taught.

**head:** This refers to Christ. The figure of speech here is the same as in 1:18a; that is, Christ is like the head of a body, and his people, Christians, are like the body. In your translation, you should translate this figure of speech here like you did in 1:18.

### 2:19b

**from whom the whole body, supported and knit together by its joints and ligaments, grows**

- Just as a head directs a body, so Christ directs all his people so they remain united and held together as ligaments and sinews hold a body together,
- It is Christ who causes his people to grow spiritually just like the head causes the body to grow physically. He joins it together by ligaments and sinews,

**from whom the whole body...grows:** The words from whom mean “from Christ.” Paul said that Christ controls the spiritual growth of the church in the same way that the head of a person controls the physical growth of his body. One way to say this is “It is only by being connected/united to Christ that the whole body grows.”

**the whole body:** This means the whole body of Christ, which means the church, all believers.

**grows:** In this context grows means “to grow spiritually,” “to continue to know God more and more,” or “to continue to understand more about God.” It does not mean, “to grow numerically,” that is, to have more and more people become Christians.

**supported and knit together by its joints and ligaments:** The Greek words that the BSB translates joints and ligaments refer to the tough, stringy parts inside the body that connect all the other parts together. Paul was saying that just as joints and ligaments support and join together the parts of the body, so the church is held together and supported by Christ’s control.

### 2:19c

**as God causes it to grow.**

- and it grows the way God has planned.

**as God causes it to grow:** The Greek literally says, “grows a growth of God.” This can mean:

1. The growth is the way God has planned/desired. This could be expressed, “as God wants them to grow,” or “the way God has planned”. (GNT, GW, NCV, REB, SSA)
2. The growth is from God. This could be expressed, “as God causes the church to grow spiritually. (BSB, NIV, CEV, NET, NLT)

The Display follows the first interpretation (1).

## Colossians 2:20

**Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:20–23

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians that they should not obey once more all those regulations that were based only on human ideas. They had abandoned that old way of living.

### 2:20a

**If you have died with Christ to the spiritual forces of the world,**

- ¶ It is as if you died with Christ and so the rules of this world no longer control you.
- ¶ Since your sinful nature died with Christ, you no longer have to obey this world’s rules.

**If you have died with Christ:** This is similar to 2:12a. Paul did not mean that the Colossian believers literally died when Christ died. It was their old sinful nature that died with Christ.

In Romans 6:1–11 Paul wrote about this in more detail. If you use footnotes or cross-references, you may want to include references here to Romans 6:1–11 and Galatians 5:19–20.

**If:** The Greek begins with a word that the BSB translates literally as If. However, Paul was not questioning or wondering if the Colossians believers had died with Christ or not. He knew that it was true. “Since” is another way to translate this word in English. You should use a word in your language that expresses that something is certain/true.

**have died with Christ to:** Paul said that the Colossian believers had died with Christ to these rules. This means that they had been freed from these laws, and now the laws no longer had any control over them.

**to the spiritual forces of the world:** This phrase spiritual forces of the world is the same as in 2:8d. It has the same meaning here as in 2:8d—“the elementary principles and rules of life.” See the note on 2:8d for the alternative interpretation.

## 2:20b

**why, as though you still belonged to the world, do you submit to its regulations:**

- Therefore why do you still obey these rules as if the world still controlled you?
- Therefore do not continue obeying these rules like those who have not been freed from the world’s control.

**why...do you submit to its regulations:** This is Paul’s main point in this paragraph (2:20–23). He was telling the Colossian believers that they did not need to submit to the rules that the false teachers were teaching them. Paul used a rhetorical question here to emphasize that the Colossians did not need to submit to these rules. If you do not use rhetorical questions in this way in your language, it may be better to translate this rhetorical question as a command, such as:

Do not obey...

“You do not need to obey...”

**as though you still belonged to the world:** This means to behave “as if the world were still controlling the way you behave” (rather than in the way someone who belongs to God should behave). Here is another way to translate this:

It’s as though you were still under the world’s influence (GW)

## Colossians 2:21

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:20–23

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians that they should not obey once more all those regulations that were based only on human ideas. They had abandoned that old way of living.

## 2:21

In this verse Paul summarized the Jewish rules in a very general way. He may have only been referring to the Jewish food laws, but it is more likely that he also meant other rules that said that touching certain things caused a person to be ceremonially unclean. You do not need to specify details of the laws in your translation.

## 2:21a

**“Do not handle,**

- These rules include rules like: “Do not handle this kind of thing!
- Those who teach these things say, “You must not hold that thing in your hand!”

**Do not handle:** This means not to hold something in one’s hands, not to use it.

## 2:21b

**do not taste,**

- Do not eat/taste this kind of food!

**do not taste:** This means not to eat even a little of something.

## 2:21c

**do not touch!”?**

- Do not even touch this kind of thing!”

**do not touch!:** This is similar to 2:21a, but it is stronger. It means not even to touch something. For

example, the law of Moses commanded Jews not to touch the dead bodies of people or animals.

### General Comment about 2:21

If it is necessary in your language to say what sort of things should not be handled, tasted, or touched, you should use very general words, like “these things”. For example:

Do not handle these things. Do not eat these foods. Do not touch these things.

### General Comment about 2:21

In this verse, Paul was quoting the words of the false teachers. You must clarify this in your translation so that your readers do not think that Paul was commanding the Colossian believers not to touch or taste certain things. The BSB shows this by using quote marks, but it may be better in your language to begin the verse with an introductory phrase like:

There are people who teach you rules like this: “Do not handle...”

You do not have to follow rules that say, “Do not handle...”

## Colossians 2:22

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

### Paragraph 2:20–23

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians that they should not obey once more all those regulations that were based only on human ideas. They had abandoned that old way of living.

### 2:22–23

In 2:22–23, Paul gave the basis for why the Colossian believers did not need to obey the regulations he wrote about in 2:20–21.

### 2:22a

**These will all perish with use,**

- It is intended that all these things will cease to exist after they have been used.
- These rules refer to things that cannot last. After we use them, they are discarded.

**These will all perish with use:** The word *These* refers to the things these rules talk about, such as food. It does not refer to the rules themselves. Paul was saying that to obey rules about these sorts of things would not help the Colossians to grow spiritually because such rules only talk about things that are used for a short time, and then wear out or are discarded.

### 2:22b

**because they are based on human commands and teachings.**

- You do not need to obey rules about such things, because they are only laws and commands that people have invented.

**because they are based on human commands and teachings:** The Greek translated literally says “according to the commands and teachings of people.” This refers to the regulations in 2:20. Paul was saying that the Colossians did not need to obey these rules because they were not God’s law, but only rules invented by people.

## Colossians 2:23

### Section 2:6–23: Behave as God’s people should behave and do not follow false teaching

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to behave correctly because they belong to Christ. They should not follow those who teach a false message. He also reminded them that God had accepted them completely because they belong to Christ.

In 1:13–2:5 Paul had reminded the Colossians what is true about Christ and had told them that God had always planned to make them his people. Beginning in 2:6, Paul urged them to continue to believe in Christ. He assured them that this was the same message that Epaphras and others had taught them. Therefore, they should continue to trust in Christ more and more and act in ways that honor God. They should not believe any other message.

**Paragraph 2:20–23**

Theme: Paul warned the Colossians that they should not obey once more all those regulations that were based only on human ideas. They had abandoned that old way of living.

**2:23a**

**Such restrictions indeed have an appearance of wisdom,**

- These rules do indeed appear to be wise,
- These rules seem to show a wise way to behave,

**have an appearance of wisdom:** Or “...have a reputation for wisdom.” Paul was saying that these rules seemed to be wise—but they were not. They appeared to be rules that taught people the correct way to behave, but (2:23e) they did not succeed.

**2:23b**

**with their self-prescribed worship,**

- for they teach people to be willing to do things that require great effort in order to show that they are devoted to God,

**self-prescribed worship:** The first “wise” rule that Paul specified concerned self-prescribed worship. The meaning of the Greek word is difficult to understand, so English versions translate it in many different ways. The basic meaning seems to be that the people attempt to please God by willingly forcing themselves to follow difficult religious rules.

**2:23c**

**their false humility,**

- to humble themselves,

**their false humility:** See the note on verse 2:18a.

**2:23d**

**and their harsh treatment of the body;**

- and to treat their bodies harshly.
- and to make themselves suffer because they think this will please God.

**their harsh treatment of the body:** These rules also told people to treat their bodies harshly. This included fasting or only eating poor food, forcing themselves to stay awake for a long time, sitting outside in the cold for a long time, or beating themselves. People did things like these because they thought that by doing them they could please God.

**2:23e**

**but they are of no value against the indulgence of the flesh.**

- But in fact these rules do not help people to control their evil desires.

- But even when people obey these rules, they still cannot stop behaving sinfully.

**but they are of no value against the indulgence of the flesh:** This means: “But these rules are useless. They cannot help people to control their evil desires.” This part of the verse contrasts with 2:23a. Paul was saying, “these rules seem to be wise but they are actually useless.”

**General Comment for 2:23**

In some languages you can clarify the contrast in this verse by rearranging it. One way to do this would be:

These rules tell you to willingly submit to strict religious rites, humble yourselves, and make your bodies suffer in order to please God. This may seem like a wise way to behave, but actually these rules do not help people to control their evil desires.

**Colossians 3:1****Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

**Paragraph 3:1–4**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should behave as those who belong to Christ should behave.

**3:1a**

**Therefore, since you have been raised with Christ,**

- ¶ Because God has given you new life just as if you had been raised with Christ,
- ¶ It is as if God raised you from death when he raised Christ from death,

**Therefore, since you have been raised with Christ:** This sentence is similar to 2:12b. See the note on that verse.

As in 2:12, you may need to clarify that Paul was using a figure of speech here. He did not mean that the Colossians had been physically raised from the dead. He was saying that they had been given new, spiritual life when they trusted in Christ.

**Therefore:** The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Therefore indicates that what follows is what Paul wants his readers to do as a result of what he has stated in the previous chapters.

**since:** See the note on 2:20a. Once again Paul used a Greek word that literally means “if.” However, he was not saying that the Colossians may or may not have been “raised with Christ”; rather, he was stating what he believed to be true.

### 3:1b

#### **strive for the things above,**

- be constantly wanting what is associated with heaven.
- so I urge you to always desire to behave as people who belong to heaven should behave.

**strive for the things above:** This is Paul’s main command in this paragraph (3:1–4). He repeated almost the same words in 3:2a.

**strive for:** This phrase in English comes from one Greek word that means “seek, try to find.” In this context it means, “to strive for, aim at.” It describes truly desiring something. In Greek this verb is in the present tense, so it means “be constantly wanting.”

**the things above:** This means “things associated with heaven.” However, the things Paul referred to were not objects associated with heaven, but spiritual values associated with heaven that should be demonstrated in the behavior of Christians (such as those listed in 3:12–14).

### 3:1c

#### **where Christ is seated at the right hand of God.**

- There in heaven Christ is now sitting on the right side of God, which is the place of honor and authority.
- That is where Christ is sitting in the most honored place next to God.

**the right hand of God:** To sit at the right hand of a ruler is a figure of speech that means to be given the place of greatest honor and power.

These words refer to Psalm 110:1, a verse that is quoted many times in the NT. You need to translate it here like you translated it elsewhere (see Matthew 22:44, Mark 12:36, Luke 20:42, Acts 2:34, Hebrews 1:13). If you keep the figure of speech in your translation, you may need to explain its meaning either in a footnote or by including some implicit information in your translation. For example:

where Christ sits at God’s right hand in the place of honor and power (NLT)

## Colossians 3:2

### **Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

### **Paragraph 3:1–4**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should behave as those who belong to Christ should behave.

### 3:2a

#### **Set your minds on things above,**

- In other words, always think about the things/values associated with heaven,
- Therefore be constantly wanting to behave in the way people who belong to heaven should behave,

**Set your minds on things above:** This means almost the same thing as 3:1b. The slight difference is that “strive for” in 3:1b refers to strongly desiring things above, whereas Set your minds on in 3:2a refers to constantly thinking about things above, making them the center of your attention. However, if it is difficult to make such a distinction in your translation, you can use a synonym or even repeat the same words, if that is natural.

### 3:2b

#### **not on earthly things.**

- and do not continue to think about doing the evil things that are connected with the ways you once behaved/lived.
- and have nothing to do with the evil deeds which people who do not know God do.

**not on earthly things:** This contrasts with “things above” in 3:2a. Paul was telling the Colossians that they should not constantly think about earthly things. This refers to “things associated with this world.” There are two ways to interpret this:

1. It could refer to the evil way people on earth behave (see SSA).
2. It could refer more generally to ordinary activities of daily living.

Both of these interpretations are possible. Most English versions imply the second interpretation. The first interpretation above (1) seems to show this contrast most clearly, and so the Display follows it.

If you want to follow the second interpretation (2), you could say:

Always think about the things that concern your new life from God in heaven. Do not constantly think about the things of this world.

Whichever way you translate this phrase, you should make sure that it clearly contrasts with 3:2a.

### Colossians 3:3

#### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

#### Paragraph 3:1–4

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should behave as those who belong to Christ should behave.

#### 3:3a

##### For you died,

- You should do this since it is as if you died when Christ died,
- For your old way of life is finished, just as though you had died,

**For:** The conjunction For connects 3:3 with 3:2. It provides the basis for what Paul said in 3:2. He said that since our old sinful nature has died, we should not continually think about earthly things, but rather concentrate on the things of heaven.

**you died:** See the notes on 2:12a and 2:20a. Again, Paul did not mean that the Colossians had actually died, but that their sinful nature had died.

#### 3:3b

##### and your life is now hidden with Christ in God.

- and you now live united with Christ in God's presence. People do not yet see/understand this new life of yours.
- and now you have new/spiritual life, just like Christ who is with God does, a new life which no one can yet see.

**your life is now hidden:** The word hidden here contrasts with "appear" in 3:4b. When Paul said that a believer's new life was hidden, he meant that it was hidden from the world and its evil influences—just as a dead body that has been buried is hidden and cannot be seen. People who do not know God cannot see or understand the believer's new life.

**with Christ:** As in 2:12a–b, the phrase with Christ shows identification with Christ. It means "together with Christ."

**in God:** Scholars do not agree about how to understand this phrase or how it fits with the rest of this verse. It may mean "in God's presence" (the SSA discusses this). Most English versions leave it ambiguous.

### Colossians 3:4

#### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

#### Paragraph 3:1–4

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should behave as those who belong to Christ should behave.

#### 3:4

Paul contrasts 3:4 with 3:3. He was saying that now (while we are living on earth), the new life that we have because we are united with Christ is hidden (people cannot see it). But in the future, "when Christ... appears," then our new life will no longer be hidden, everyone will be able to see it.

#### 3:4a

##### When Christ, who is your life, appears,

- But when Christ, who is the source of your new life, appears publicly to all the people of the world,
- When Christ, who causes you to live, comes back to earth,

**Christ, who is your life:** In many languages, a literal translation of this phrase will not provide the correct meaning to readers. This phrase contains the following ideas:

1. Christ is the source of your new, spiritual life.
2. Christ is the one who causes you to have this new life.
3. The reason you live is to serve Christ.
4. Christ alone causes your life to have real meaning.

The first two are probably the best ways to translate the central meaning. If you need to include this implicit information, you could translate:

When Christ who gives you real/new life...

When Christ who is the source of your spiritual life

**your life:** There is a textual problem with this phrase:

1. Some Greek texts say “your life.” (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, NET, NLT, NRSV, NJB)
2. Other Greek manuscripts say “our life.” (RSV, GW, KJV, REB)

The first option has the best support (1) and it is recommended that you translate this “your life.”

**appears:** The Greek word that the BSB translates appears can also be translated “be revealed.” Paul was referring to the future when Jesus will return to earth and show/reveal his power and glory.

### 3:4b

**then you also will appear with Him in glory.**

- then you will appear with him and share his glory.
- at that time you will appear with him as his glorious, perfect people.

**you also will appear with Him:** In the future, when Christ returns to earth and is revealed to everyone, all believers will be with him and everyone will see them—their life that is united to Christ will no longer be hidden.

**in glory:** This is a difficult phrase to understand. There are two main interpretations:

1. It refers to the state of Christ and his followers when they appear, that is, they will all have “glorious” bodies, perfect and free from sin.
2. It refers to the manner in which Christ and his followers will appear. When Christ returns, he will come with all God’s visible glory—the brightness and light of heaven. The believers who are with him will share this glory.

In Colossae the false teachers were teaching that the only way for Christians to be perfect was to obey all the rules they were taught. It seems that Paul was saying that when believers appear with Christ, everyone will see that they are perfect and free from sin. The perfection is because they have died with Christ and were raised with him (3:1,3), not because of any rules they have obeyed. Therefore, it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

It probably will not be possible to include the complete meaning of this phrase in your translation. One way to include both interpretations is to say, “share his glory” (GNT, NCV, NLT). Also, see “glory” in KBT and meaning 3 in the glossary for more information.

## Colossians 3:5

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil

deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

### Paragraph 3:5–11

Theme: Paul commanded the Colossians not to do what was evil.

### 3:5a

**Put to death, therefore, the components of your earthly nature:**

- ¶ Therefore, stop doing the evil things that are connected with your sinful nature.
- ¶ Therefore your old nature is dead, so no longer let yourselves be controlled by the evil things that you are tempted to do because of your old, sinful nature.

**Put to death:** This is a figure of speech that means: “have nothing to do with,” “do not associate with,” “refuse to do,” or “eliminate completely.” Paul was saying that the Colossians should no longer act in these ways, in fact, they should totally reject such behavior. It is as if such ways of behaving are “dead” and therefore these old ways no longer control the believers. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

So put all evil things out of your life (NCV)

**therefore:** This word connects this paragraph to what Paul had said before. Here Paul began to instruct the Colossians about how they should and should not behave, but he based his commands on the previous paragraphs. These paragraphs described the new life the Colossians now had because they had trusted in Christ.

**the components of your earthly nature:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as earthly is literally “on the earth.” It is the same phrase Paul used in 3:2b. It means the evil deeds and desires that come from the old sinful nature. Paul was telling the Colossians that they must put to death anything that belongs to that old sinful nature. In other words, they should no longer behave the way they used to behave before they trusted in Christ.

### 3:5b–c

In 3:5b–c Paul lists five kinds of evil behavior as examples of “the components of your earthly nature.”

### 3:5b

**sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires,**

- Do not be sexually immoral, do not do any sort of sexually unclean/indecent act, and do not desire to do such things. Do not desire to do any other sort of evil.

- Do not behave immorally in any way. Do not be controlled by a desire to behave like this or in any other evil way.

**sexual immorality, impurity, lust:** The first three kinds of evil behavior that Paul listed were sexual sins.

**sexual immorality:** The Greek word *porneia* that the BSB translates sexual immorality is a general term that means any kind of unlawful sexual behavior. This includes people having sex before they are married or having sex with someone other than their own husband or wife.

**impurity:** The second term, impurity, also refers to sexual sin. It is often mentioned together with *porneia*, “sexual immorality,” in the NT. It can be translated, “doing indecent things,” or “doing shameful things.”

**lust:** The last term, lust, means “strong desire, passion.” In this verse, it probably means strong sexual desire.

It is difficult to make differences between these three terms in some languages. If you do not have different terms for each of these ideas in your language, here are some ways you could combine them:

Do not commit adultery or do other deeds that people are ashamed to talk about.

Do not behave in any sort of sexually immoral way.

**evil desires:** The fourth term, evil desires, is a general term. It probably refers not only to evil sexual desires, but also to any kind of evil desire. Here is another way to translate this term:

Do not desire to do what is evil (SSA)

Since Paul has just referred to sexual sins, you may want to translate it like this:

and do not desire to do other kinds of evil

### 3:5c

#### and greed, which is idolatry.

- Do not desire to have many possessions. That is just like worshipping the things you desire.
- Do not be greedy for more and more things. If you are greedy, it is like you are worshipping idols.

**greed:** The fifth term, greed, means desiring to get more and more things, such as money or other possessions.

**which is idolatry:** Paul said here that “greed” is the same as idolatry. Idolatry usually means, “the worship of idols rather than God.”

## Colossians 3:6

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

### Paragraph 3:5–11

Theme: Paul commanded the Colossians not to do what was evil.

### 3:6a

#### Because of these, the wrath of God is coming

- Because people do these evil things, God will certainly punish severely
- Because of these evil things, God will show his great anger by punishing

**Because of these:** The word *these* refers back to the things listed in 3:5. Paul was saying, “Because people do these evil things...”

**the wrath of God is coming:** This means, “The time is coming when God will show his anger.” Paul did not mean that God would become angry. He meant that God will show he is angry by punishing people who act in the ways described in 3:5.

**wrath:** This is a strong word for “anger.” If you have only one word for “anger” in your language, you may want to use an adjective here and say “great/intense anger.”

### 3:6b

#### on the sons of disobedience.

- those who do not obey him. (GNT)
- those who disobey him by doing such things.

**on the sons of disobedience:** There is a textual problem with this part of the verse.

1. Some Greek manuscripts include this Greek phrase in their translations. Below is a list of some English versions that retain this phrase. (BSB, GNT, CEV, GW, KJV, NJB, NRSV)
2. Some Greek manuscripts do not contain these words. Below is a list of some English versions that omit this phrase. (NIV, RSV, NCV, NLT, REB)

There is no majority view among English versions about whether or not to include this phrase. Since there is no majority view, you should probably follow the English version or national language version which is most used in your area. If you use footnotes in your translation, you could mention the alternative in a footnote.

## Colossians 3:7

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

#### Paragraph 3:5–11

Theme: Paul commanded the Colossians not to do what was evil.

#### 3:7

**When you lived among them, you also used to walk in these ways.**

- You yourselves once behaved in those evil ways before you trusted in Christ.
- These were the sort of things you used to do, when you lived without any thought of obeying God.

**When you lived among them:** Paul was writing about the way the Colossians behaved before they became believers.

**you:** This translates an emphatic pronoun in Greek. Here is another way to translate this pronoun:

you yourselves (GNT)

**used to walk in these ways:** This is an idiom which means to “behave in these ways.” See the notes on 1:10a and 2:6b.

**in these ways:** This refers to the list in 3:5b–c.

## Colossians 3:8

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

#### Paragraph 3:5–11

Theme: Paul commanded the Colossians not to do what was evil.

#### 3:8a

**But now you must put aside all such things as these:**

- But now you must not do these things any more:
- But now you are believers, and so you must stop doing these things:

**But now:** Paul was contrasting the way the Colossians should behave now that they had trusted Christ with the way they used to behave (3:7).

**you must put aside all such things as these:** In Greek the verb that the BSB translates put aside can literally mean “take-off/remove” clothes. Here Paul was using it as an idiom. It means almost the same thing as “Put to death” in 3:5a: “Do not do any of these things any more.” This same idiom is used in Romans 13:12; Ephesians 4:22, 4:25; 1 Peter 2:1; and James 1:21.

**all such things as these:** It is possible that all such things refers back to the list of evil things in 3:5. But most scholars and translations say that these words refer forward to the evil things that Paul listed in 3:8b and 3:9.

#### 3:8b

**anger, rage, malice, slander, and filthy language from your lips.**

- Do not be angry in any way. Do not act in hateful ways toward other people. Do not say hateful things about people or let obscene words come out of your mouth.
- Do not get angry or allow your anger to control you. Avoid hurting people by what you do or say, and never use any sort of unclean/vile language.

**anger, rage:** These two words, anger and rage, mean almost the same thing. If you have two synonyms in your language for anger, you can use them here, otherwise you can combine the two words and say, “do not be angry in any way.”

**malice:** To act with malice means to act in wicked, hateful ways, to do things to people just to be unkind. Here is another way to translate this word:

hateful feelings (GNT)

**slander:** This means to say hateful, unkind, insulting things about people. This may mean telling lies about people, but it can also include saying true things about people, but with the intent to hurt them.

**filthy language:** This probably refers to obscene talk or cursing. If you do not have an expression in your language for speaking in this offensive or profane

manner, you may be able to say, “using words that should not be spoken.”

**from your lips:** The Greek is literally “from your mouth.” Notice that the BSB, along with several other English versions, has translated the Greek word for “mouth” with lips. This is because in English it is more natural to refer to words being “on someone’s lips” than “in their mouth.” In other languages, it may be more natural to refer to the throat or the tongue. You should use the term that is most natural in your language.

## Colossians 3:9

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

### Paragraph 3:5–11

Theme: Paul commanded the Colossians not to do what was evil.

#### 3:9a

**Do not lie to one another,**

- Do not lie to one another.

#### 3:9b–10

The phrases in 3:9b–10 are similar to those in Ephesians 4:22–24. You should compare your translations of these two passages to make sure you have translated them in a similar way.

#### 3:9b

**since you have taken off the old self with its practices,**

- Do not do these things, since you have abandoned your old nature and all the ways it caused you to behave.
- You should not behave in these ways, because you have stopped being the person you were and behaving the way you did in the past before you trusted Christ.

**since:** Paul was explaining to the Colossians why they should not act in these evil ways. 3:9b–10 is connected not only to 3:9a but also to 3:8.

**have taken off the old self:** The Greek verb that the BSB translates taken off literally refers to removing clothes. Paul used it as a figure of speech to mean that just as people take off old, dirty clothes, so a Christian has taken off his old nature.

**the old self:** The old self means the way the Colossians behaved in the past, the way they used to be before they became believers, their old sinful nature.

This is similar to what Paul said in 2:11b (“putting off your sinful nature”) and 2:20a (“you have died with Christ”). See the notes on these verses. Paul was saying, “you have stopped being the person you used to be.”

**its practices:** This means “the ways you used to behave.”

## Colossians 3:10

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

### Paragraph 3:5–11

Theme: Paul commanded the Colossians not to do what was evil.

#### 3:10a

**and have put on the new self,**

- And now that you have trusted in Christ, you have become a new/different person.
- You now think and act in a new, completely different way.

The phrases in 3:10a are parallel to 3:9b. They describe what happened to the Colossians when they became Christians. 3:9b described the old nature the Colossians had put off or taken off, and 3:10a described the new nature they had put on instead.

**have put on the new self:** The Greek verb that the BSB translates have put on is parallel to “have taken off” in 3:9b. It normally refers to putting on clothes. Here Paul used it as a figure of speech to mean that the Christian has “put on” (started) a new way of behaving, just as a person “puts on” clothes.

**the new self:** This means the new life and new way of behaving that a person has once he trusts in Christ.

Paul was saying: “you have started being a new person.”

#### 3:10b

**which is being renewed in knowledge in the image of its Creator.**

- God has put this new nature in you, and he is causing it to become more and more like himself, so you will truly know him.

- God made you a new person and he is making you more and more like himself, so you will truly know him.

**which:** This refers back to the “new self” in 3:10a.

**is being renewed in knowledge in the image of its**

**Creator:** God is the one who is doing the “renewing.” The verb that the BSB translates is being renewed is present tense in Greek. This means that God is continually renewing believers, that is, he is constantly changing them and causing them to be more like himself.

**in knowledge:** Most scholars think that Paul was writing about knowing God. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in order that you might get to know God truly (SSA)

in order to bring you to a full knowledge of himself (GNT)

**its Creator:** God, the Creator, was the one who created this new nature/self, and he is the one who gives new life to everyone who trusts in Christ. Here Paul was not referring to God creating the world or physical bodies, but to God creating a new nature for each Christian. (See 2 Corinthians 5:17, Ephesians 2:10.)

## Colossians 3:11

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

#### Paragraph 3:5–11

Theme: Paul commanded the Colossians not to do what was evil.

#### 3:11

This verse is the result of 3:10, that is, as a result of the new life believers have in Christ, differences between people are no longer important—only Christ is. 3:11 is similar to Galatians 3:27–28, 6:15, and Romans 10:12. If you have already translated these passages, you should compare them with this verse.

#### 3:11a

**Here there is no Greek or Jew, circumcised or uncircumcised,**

- Because God has made you a new person, it does not matter if you are a Jew or a non-Jew, or whether you are circumcised or not.
- As a result of this, it is not important whether you are a circumcised Jew or an uncircumcised Greek.

**Here:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as Here does not literally mean “in the place where I am.” It means, “in this new life God has given to you.”

**there is no Greek or Jew:** If the phrase there is no Greek or Jew is translated literally, people may misunderstand it to mean, “Greeks and Jews do not exist,” or “there are no Greek or Jewish believers.” This phrase is an idiom that means that differences between Jews and Greeks are not important, and it does not matter whether a person is a Jew or Greek.

**Greek:** Paul was probably using the word Greek to mean “Gentile,” that is, non-Jewish people. GNT and NLT translate it “Gentiles.”

**circumcised or uncircumcised:** This phrase is parallel to the phrase “Greek or Jew.” Jews were circumcised and this marked them as God’s special people. Greeks/Gentiles were not circumcised.

If your language does not use a lot of parallel phrases, you could combine these two phrases and say:

It does not matter if you are a Jew, circumcised according to the law of Moses, or an uncircumcised Gentile...

#### 3:11b

#### barbarian, Scythian, slave, or free,

- It does not matter if you are a foreigner or from uncivilized people. It does not matter if you are a slave or a free person.
- It is not important whether you are foreign or uncivilized, a slave or someone who is not a slave.

**barbarian:** The Greeks called any person who was not Greek a barbarian. It means “foreigner” and implies someone who was uncultured.

**Scythian:** The Scythians were a fierce, savage people who invaded other peoples’ countries and killed the occupants and caused other sorts of damage. People were afraid of them and considered them one of the worst kinds of “barbarians.” You can translate this using a term in your language that refers to people who are primitive or uncivilized.

**slave:** A slave was a servant who had been bought by someone and therefore belonged to this person. He had no freedom to do what he wanted to do or to go

where he wanted to go. He had no possessions of his own and was completely dependent on his owners for everything.

**free:** This is the opposite of a “slave.” The word free can be translated as “free person,” or “person who is not a slave.”

### **3:11c but Christ is all**

- It is Christ who is supremely important,
- But Christ is the only thing that matters,

**but Christ is all:** This contrasts with 3:11a–b. Paul was saying that all these differences between people did not matter—the only thing that was important was Christ. He is the most important thing in the universe, he is supreme over all things and over all people.

### **3:11d and is in all.**

- and he lives in each one of you.
- and he lives in all his people.

**and is in all:** Most scholars believe that this means that Christ “lives in all believers.” The CEV, NCV, and NLT make this explicit in their translation.

## **Colossians 3:12**

### **Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

### **Paragraph 3:12–14**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that since God loved them so much, they must love one another.

### **3:12a**

**Therefore, as the elect of God, holy and beloved,**

- ¶ Therefore since God has chosen you to be his people and you have been set apart for him and he loves you, I urge you to behave in the following ways:
- ¶ So since God has chosen you to be his people and you are dedicated to him and he loves you,

**Therefore:** This connects back to 3:10. Paul was saying that since the Colossians had put on a new nature, they now should behave as God’s people should behave.

**as:** This means, “since you are...”

**the elect of God:** Paul listed three things about the Colossian believers. First he reminded them that they

were the elect of God, that is, that God had chosen them to belong to him and be part of his people.

**holy:** Second, he reminded them that they were holy. In this context, it means “set apart, dedicated specially to God.” See the term “holy” in KBT and meaning 1 in the glossary.

**beloved:** Third, Paul reminded them that they were beloved. In this context, it means, “God loves you.”

### **3:12b**

**clothe yourselves with hearts of compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, and patience.**

- be compassionate, kind, humble, gentle, and patient.
- help people who are suffering, be kind to one another, be humble, do not insist that others do what you want but be considerate of one another, be patient.

**clothe yourselves:** This is the same verb that Paul used in 3:10a (where the BSB translated it as “put on”). See the notes there. If you cannot use such a figure of speech in your language, you can translate the meaning directly: “Behave in these ways:...”

Paul then listed five ways the Colossians should behave. In some languages it will be necessary to translate each of these five nouns as a short sentence.

**hearts of compassion:** This means feelings of sympathy towards someone who needs help, showing concern for someone who needs help.

**kindness:** This is similar to “compassion.” It means acting in helpful, loving ways toward people.

**humility:** This is the same Greek word that Paul used in 2:18a and 2:23c. There the BSB translated it “false humility.” However, here it has a positive meaning. It means not being proud and arrogant. A person shows humility when he does not act as if he is better than other people.

**gentleness:** This means being willing to yield to others. A person shows gentleness when he is considerate of the rights and feelings of other people and does not insist on having his own way.

**patience:** This means calmly enduring unfair or unkind treatment by others—not becoming angry quickly when other people do something unpleasant. In the next sentence (3:13a), Paul used different words that mean almost the same thing as “being patient.”

## Colossians 3:13

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

#### Paragraph 3:12–14

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that since God loved them so much, they must love one another.

#### 3:13a

##### Bear with one another

- Accept other believers who are different from you, even if they annoy you.
- Do not get upset with one another.

**Bear with one another:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as Bear with means almost the same as the Greek word translated as “patience” in 3:12b. The difference is that the word used in this verse means tolerating the things other people do regularly that are annoying, rather than being patient when someone does something wrong.

Among the Colossian believers, there was a mixture of nationalities. These different groups would have had trouble tolerating the different views of others—in particular the Jews would have found it difficult to Bear with the Gentiles, and the Greeks would have had difficulty “bearing with” the barbarians.

#### 3:13b

##### and forgive any complaint you may have against someone else.

- If someone has wronged you, forgive him.
- If someone has offended you in any way, you must forgive him.

**complaint:** A “complaint” is an accusation or criticism that one person has against another person because of something this other person has done.

#### 3:13c

##### Forgive as the Lord forgave you.

- In the same way as the Lord forgave you, so you also must forgive other people.

**Forgive as the Lord forgave you:** The word as means Paul was comparing two things. There are two possible interpretations:

1. Paul was comparing the manner the Lord had forgiven the Colossians with the manner they should forgive others. He had forgiven them freely and

completely. So they should forgive others freely and completely.

2. Paul was comparing the fact that the Lord had forgiven the Colossians with the fact that they should forgive others.

Both these interpretations are possible. Most English versions are ambiguous, but the majority of commentators favor the first option (1), so the Display follows that.

**Lord:** It is not clear whether the word Lord here refers to the Lord God, or the Lord Jesus. If your translation cannot be ambiguous, you should probably translate it “Lord Jesus.”

## Colossians 3:14

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

#### Paragraph 3:12–14

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that since God loved them so much, they must love one another.

#### 3:14a

##### And over all these virtues put on love,

- As well as all this, the most important thing you should do is to love one another.

**And over all these virtues put on love:** There is no verb in this part of the verse in the Greek, so many English versions repeat the verb put on from 3:12b or use a verb with a similar meaning. Paul was continuing his figure of speech of putting on clothes. Paul was saying that love was like another piece of clothing that a believer was to put on over his other clothes to “bind them all together.” If you cannot use this figure of speech in your translation, you could say:

And above everything else, be truly loving.... (JBP)

As well as all this, the most important thing is that you should love one another...

**these virtues:** A virtue refers to a correct way of behaving and in this case refers back to the kinds of behavior in 3:12b–13c.

#### 3:14b

##### which is the bond of perfect unity.

- For by loving one another, you will become perfectly united.
- For when you love one another, you will be in complete harmony with one another.

**which is the bond of perfect unity:** There are two opinions about what love binds together:

1. It is the bond between Christians. For example:

Love is what holds you all together in perfect unity (NCV) (BSB, NCV, NLT, SSA)

1. The bond of perfect unity is the virtues that Paul had just mentioned. Most English versions imply this by saying something like this:

binds everything together (RSV) (RSV, GNT, CEV, GW, REB)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1). In 3:11 Paul stressed the fact that God accepts all Christians even though they come from different social classes or nations. Therefore, it seems that here in 3:14b also he was emphasizing that people with these differences can only be perfectly united if they truly love one another.

**is the bond of:** This may also be expressed: “you will become one group,” or “you will live in harmony with each other.”

## Colossians 3:15

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

### Paragraph 3:15–16

Theme: Paul urged the Colossians to continue to live peacefully with one another and to thank God constantly. He urged them to be totally committed to the message of Christ.

### 3:15a

#### Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts,

- ¶ Christ has caused you to be at peace with one another, so let this peace control all you do.
- ¶ Let the peace that Christ has given to you direct all your decisions.

**peace of Christ:** This refers to the peace that Christ gives to a believer. Christ has caused Christians to be

at peace with God and with one another. In this verse, Paul was writing about being at peace with other people, specifically with other Christians (see 3:14b, 3:15b). So one way to translate this is:

Christ has caused you to be at peace with one another.

**peace:** In this context, peace means “the ability to be in harmony with one another.”

**rule:** The Greek word *brabeuō* that the BSB translates rule means “to direct, control.”

**in your hearts:** This can mean either:

1. among you, as a group, or
2. within each of you, as individuals.

Since Paul’s next phrase reminded the Colossian believers that God expected them to live peacefully with one another, the first interpretation is preferred (1).

### 3:15b

#### for to this you were called as members of one body.

- Do this since all of you are parts of the same body and God chose you so that you could live peacefully with one another.
- You should do this since God has chosen each one of you to live and work together peacefully as one body.

**for to this you were called:** To be called means “God chose you to be his people so that you will be at peace with one another.” Paul was giving the basis for telling the Colossians why they should always try to live peacefully with other Christians, that is, they should do this, for one of God’s purposes in choosing them was so that they would live peacefully with one another.

**as members of one body:** Paul used this phrase before—see the note on 1:18a. You can translate it as a figure of speech: You are like members of one body,” or give the meaning, “You are all members of the same group.”

### General Comment about 3:15

It may be better in some languages to reorder this verse. The CEV has done this:

Each one of you is part of the body of Christ, and you were chosen to live together peacefully. So let the peace that comes from Christ control your thoughts. (CEV)

**3:15c****And be thankful.**

- And be constantly thanking God.

**Colossians 3:16****Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

**Paragraph 3:15–16**

Theme: Paul urged the Colossians to continue to live peacefully with one another and to thank God constantly. He urged them to be totally committed to the message of Christ.

**3:16a****Let the word of Christ richly dwell within you**

- Think about the message of Christ all the time, so that it controls all that you do and think.
- Allow the message about Christ to influence your thoughts and actions more and more thoroughly.

**the word of Christ:** This can mean either:

1. the word from Christ, that is, the words, or the message, which Christ taught. (GNT, GW, NCV, NLT)
2. the word about Christ, that is, the message about Christ. (CEV, SSA)

Actually there is little difference in meaning between the two. You can follow either interpretation in your translation.

**richly:** The Greek word *plousiōs* that the BSB translates richly is a form of a word that means “wealthy.” However, in this context, it means “lavishly, abundantly, completely, thoroughly.”

**dwell within you:** Paul used the word dwell figuratively. Just as a person lives in a house, so the Colossians were to allow the word of Christ to live in them. It means that they should think about the word of Christ often and let it influence the things they do and say. Find a natural way to say this in your language. For example:

Carry the message about Christ with you daily.

**3:16b–c**

In 3:16a, Paul commanded the Colossian believers to let the word of Christ dwell in them richly. In 3:16b–c he follows this command with three verbs: “teaching...

counseling...singing.” These are specific ways in which the Colossians were to let the message dwell in them.

**3:16b****as you teach and admonish one another with all wisdom,**

- Specifically, teach each other the message about Christ, and warn/urge each other to obey it. Do this as wisely as you can.
- Do this by teaching one another wisely the message about Christ and counseling one another wisely.

**teach and admonish one another with all wisdom:**

1:28b was very similar to this part of the verse. See the note there.

**admonish:** The Greek word that the BSB translates admonish means, “warn, admonish, instruct, advise.” Paul was still writing about “the word of Christ” from 3:16a. He was instructing the Colossians to warn each other to obey that message.

**with all wisdom:** Here the meaning is clear: “Teach and advise each other as wisely as you can.” Some translations connect the words “with all wisdom” to 3:16a. For example, NLT says “Let the words of Christ, in all their richness, live in your hearts and make you wise.” (See also KJV.) But most scholars think that the words “with all wisdom” should be connected to “teaching and admonishing” in 3:16b, as the BSB and most other translations have done.

**3:16c****and as you sing psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs with gratitude in your hearts to God.**

- Sing psalms, hymns of praise to God, and other sacred songs. And as you sing sincerely, be grateful to God for all that he has done for you.
- Also, thank God by sincerely singing psalms, hymns of praise, and other songs about God and Christ.

**and as you sing:** This instruction from Paul is parallel to 3:16b. This was another specific example of how the Colossians were to let the word of Christ dwell in them richly.

**psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs:** Paul was describing three types of songs. It may not be easy to make a clear distinction between them.

**psalms:** Most scholars agree that psalms refer to parts of the book of Psalms in the OT.

**hymns:** This Greek word, according to ancient Christian writings, refers to songs of praise to God and to Christ.

**spiritual songs:** This is where there is most disagreement. Some people say that these were songs emphasizing some point of Christian doctrine, others say they were unwritten songs that a person sang as the Holy Spirit inspired him.

It is probably best if you avoid being too specific in making a difference between these terms. If you do not have three different terms, you could combine two or more of these terms in your translation. For example:

Sing all sorts of songs to praise God.

**with gratitude in your hearts to God:** The word gratitude means being grateful/thankful. In this verse, Paul was instructing the Colossians to “sing” with gratitude, that is, to be singing songs that express their thankfulness to God.

**in your hearts:** This phrase can be connected to the rest of the verse in two ways:

1. It is connected to “sing.” So Paul was instructing the Colossians to “sing” in their hearts. This probably does not mean to sing silently, but rather to sing sincerely, to express in their songs how they really felt. (GW, REB, SSA)
2. It is connected to “gratitude.” This is how many English versions translate this part of the verse. (BSB, NIV, RSV, RSV, CEV, NCV, NET, NJB, NLT)

The word order in the Greek text supports the first interpretation. Many commentaries support this also. So although many English versions follow the second interpretation, it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

## Colossians 3:17

### Section 3:1–17: Behave in ways that please God

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that they should decide to please only God. That is, they should not do evil deeds, they should love one another, they should live peacefully with one another, and they should continually learn more and more about God.

#### Paragraph 3:17

Theme: Paul reminded the Colossians that they belonged to the Lord Jesus. Therefore, they should do everything that people who belong to him should do.

This verse is a summary of all that Paul had commanded/urged the Colossians to do since 2:6.

#### 3:17a

**And whatever you do, in word or deed,**

- ¶ Whatever you say and whatever you do,

#### 3:17b

**do it all in the name of the Lord Jesus,**

- do everything as a representative of the Lord Jesus,
- do everything in a way that shows that you represent the Lord Jesus,

**in the name of the Lord Jesus:** To do something in the name of someone else is to do it as that person's representative, or as one who acts under his authority. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

And whatever you do or say, let it be as a representative of the Lord Jesus (NLT)

#### General Comment about 3:17a–b

You could reorder 3:17a–b as follows:

Since we are all representatives of the Lord Jesus, we should speak as he wants us to speak, and we should do things in the way he wants us to do them.

#### 3:17c

**giving thanks to God the Father through Him.**

- continually thanking God the Father by means of the Lord Jesus.
- and always thanking our<sup>(incl)</sup> Father God by means of the Lord Jesus acting as a mediator.

**God the Father:** In some languages, it is more natural to say “God our<sup>(incl)</sup> Father,” than God the Father.

**through Him:** That is, “through Jesus.” This means that Christians should thank God the Father “by means of the Lord Jesus.” Jesus is our mediator—he is the “go-between.” Christ takes our thanks and presents them to God the Father.

It could also mean that it is by means of Jesus and what he did that Christians can approach God to pray and give thanks. One way to express this is to say:

Always say thank you to our Father God. You can approach him to say thank you because Jesus has made it possible for you.

## Colossians 3:18

### Section 3:18–4:1: Paul instructed husbands and wives, children and parents, slaves and masters

In this section, Paul continued to instruct the Colossians about the way that they should behave in order to please Christ. In this section, however, he was writ-

ing about how they should behave at home rather than within the Christian community. He gave instructions to six types of people: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. His message was the same for all:

1. That people should submit to those who had authority over them,
2. That those who had authority should be considerate toward those under them.

Paul gave instructions to wives in 3:18, to husbands in 3:19, to children in 3:20, to parents in 3:21, to slaves in 3:22, and to masters in 4:1. Make sure you begin each of these verses in the same way.

### Paragraph 3:18–19

Theme: Paul gave instructions to husbands and wives: that wives should be subject to their husbands, and husbands should love their wives.

#### 3:18a

#### **Wives, submit to your husbands,**

- ¶ Wives, continually submit to the authority of your husband,
- ¶ You wives, each of you should continually submit to your husband.

**Wives:** Here Paul was writing specifically to the married women. You may need to use the pronoun “you”(plural) in translating this, for example: “You believers who are married women.” In other languages it may be better to translate this “Each of you who is a married woman.” Use whichever way is most natural in your language.

**submit to your husbands:** The word submit means that a wife must acknowledge that her husband is the leader in their family, she must put herself under his control. In some languages it may need to be translated as “obey.” This command is in the present tense in Greek. This means that a wife should continually submit to her husband.

#### 3:18b

#### **as is fitting in the Lord.**

- because that is what is proper for followers of the Lord to do.
- That is what you should do since you are united to the Lord Jesus.

**as is fitting in the Lord:** Paul was saying that wives should submit to their husbands because that is the way that women who belong to the Lord should behave. It is behavior that is fitting, appropriate, and correct.

**Lord:** This refers to the Lord Jesus.

## Colossians 3:19

### Section 3:18–4:1: Paul instructed husbands and wives, children and parents, slaves and masters

In this section, Paul continued to instruct the Colossians about the way that they should behave in order to please Christ. In this section, however, he was writing about how they should behave at home rather than within the Christian community. He gave instructions to six types of people: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. His message was the same for all:

1. That people should submit to those who had authority over them,
2. That those who had authority should be considerate toward those under them.

Paul gave instructions to wives in 3:18, to husbands in 3:19, to children in 3:20, to parents in 3:21, to slaves in 3:22, and to masters in 4:1. Make sure you begin each of these verses in the same way.

### Paragraph 3:18–19

Theme: Paul gave instructions to husbands and wives: that wives should be subject to their husbands, and husbands should love their wives.

#### 3:19a

#### **Husbands, love your wives**

- Husbands, love your wife,
- You husbands, each of you must love your wife,

**Husbands:** Here Paul is writing specifically to the married men. You may need to use the pronoun “you”(plural) in translating this, for example: “You believers who are married men.” In other languages it may be better to translate this “Each of you who is a married man.” Use whichever way is most natural in your language.

#### 3:19b

#### **and do not be harsh with them.**

- and do not treat her harshly.
- and treat her kindly.

**and do not be harsh with them:** One specific way that husbands can love their wives is by not treating them harshly. To treat someone harshly is the opposite of the qualities that Paul listed in 3:12 (compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, and patience). It is best to translate this as a negative command: “do not...” But if it is difficult to translate it this way, you can translate it as a positive command. For example:

and be gentle with them (NCV)

## Colossians 3:20

### Section 3:18–4:1: Paul instructed husbands and wives, children and parents, slaves and masters

In this section, Paul continued to instruct the Colossians about the way that they should behave in order to please Christ. In this section, however, he was writing about how they should behave at home rather than within the Christian community. He gave instructions to six types of people: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. His message was the same for all:

1. That people should submit to those who had authority over them,
2. That those who had authority should be considerate toward those under them.

Paul gave instructions to wives in 3:18, to husbands in 3:19, to children in 3:20, to parents in 3:21, to slaves in 3:22, and to masters in 4:1. Make sure you begin each of these verses in the same way.

### Paragraph 3:20–21

Theme: Paul gave instructions to parents and children: that children should obey their parents, and parents should not overcorrect their children.

#### 3:20a

#### Children, obey your parents in everything,

- ¶ Children, obey your parents in all you do,
- ¶ You children, each of you should do everything your parents tell you to do,

#### 3:20b

#### for this is pleasing to the Lord.

- since the Lord is pleased when you do this.
- because that is what the Lord wants you to do.

**for this is pleasing to the Lord:** The Greek translated literally says, “for this is pleasing in the Lord.” There are two ways to interpret this:

1. “for this pleases the Lord” (BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, KJV, NCV, NLT).
2. “for this is pleasing to God in the Lord”. This means, “for this is what God wants you to do as followers of the Lord.” Here is another way to translate this:

for this is pleasing to God and is the Christian way (REB) (GNT, REB, SSA)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation with most of the English versions (1).

**Lord:** This refers to the Lord Jesus, just as in 3:18b.

## Colossians 3:21

### Section 3:18–4:1: Paul instructed husbands and wives, children and parents, slaves and masters

In this section, Paul continued to instruct the Colossians about the way that they should behave in order to please Christ. In this section, however, he was writing about how they should behave at home rather than within the Christian community. He gave instructions to six types of people: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. His message was the same for all:

1. That people should submit to those who had authority over them,
2. That those who had authority should be considerate toward those under them.

Paul gave instructions to wives in 3:18, to husbands in 3:19, to children in 3:20, to parents in 3:21, to slaves in 3:22, and to masters in 4:1. Make sure you begin each of these verses in the same way.

### Paragraph 3:20–21

Theme: Paul gave instructions to parents and children: that children should obey their parents, and parents should not overcorrect their children.

#### 3:21a

#### Fathers, do not provoke your children,

- Fathers, do not anger your children by always scolding them,
- You fathers, do not correct your children for every little thing they do wrong and so make them bitter against you.

**Fathers:** The Greek word Paul used here usually refers specifically to fathers. Rarely it can be used to include both parents (see Hebrews 11:23). The GNT translates it “parents” (see also NJB and SSA), but most English versions say “fathers.” Since Paul used the more usual word for “parents” in 3:20, it is more likely that he was addressing fathers alone here as the ones who have final authority in the home.

**do not provoke your children:** The Greek verb that the BSB translates provoke means “to rouse to anger, provoke, irritate.” In the context, this means “do not irritate your children by constantly correcting/scolding them for everything they do.”

#### 3:21b

#### so they will not become discouraged.

- for if you do they will become discouraged.
- If you do they will become angry/sad and stop trying to do what is right.

**discouraged:** The word that the BSB translates discouraged means to become sad (or angry, or frustrated), and therefore to stop trying to do what pleases God. Here is another way to translate this word:

they might give up (CEV)

## Colossians 3:22

### Section 3:18–4:1: Paul instructed husbands and wives, children and parents, slaves and masters

In this section, Paul continued to instruct the Colossians about the way that they should behave in order to please Christ. In this section, however, he was writing about how they should behave at home rather than within the Christian community. He gave instructions to six types of people: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. His message was the same for all:

1. That people should submit to those who had authority over them,
2. That those who had authority should be considerate toward those under them.

Paul gave instructions to wives in 3:18, to husbands in 3:19, to children in 3:20, to parents in 3:21, to slaves in 3:22, and to masters in 4:1. Make sure you begin each of these verses in the same way.

#### Paragraph 3:22–4:1

Theme: Paul gave instructions to slaves and their masters: that slaves should obey their masters and do their work to honor Christ, and that masters should be just and fair in the way they treat their slaves.

This passage is similar to Ephesians 6:5–9. You should compare your translations of these two passages.

#### 3:22a

##### **Slaves, obey your earthly masters in everything,**

- ¶ Slaves, obey your masters here on earth in everything you do.
- ¶ You slaves, do all that your human masters tell you to do.

**Slaves:** See the note on 3:11b. Slaves had no freedom to do what they wanted to do or to go where they wanted to go. They had no possessions of their own and were completely dependent on their owners for everything.

**obey...in everything:** Paul told slaves to obey their masters in everything. This was the same command he gave to children in 3:20a.

**your earthly masters:** That is, your human masters. In Greek the same word *kurios* is used for both “Lord” and “master.” So when Paul told slaves to obey their earthly masters, it also reminded them that they had a heavenly master/Lord also (see 3:24b). Notice that in 4:1b Paul used the phrase “Master in heaven” to refer to Christ.

#### 3:22b–c

In 3:22b–c Paul told slaves how and why (in what manner and for what reason) they were to obey their masters. In 3:22b he told them ways they should not behave, and in 3:22c he told them ways they should behave.

#### 3:22b

##### **not only to please them while they are watching,**

- Obey them all the time. Do not just obey them when they are watching you and so they will praise you.
- Do not only work well when you know that they are watching you and so that they will think well of you.

##### **not only to please them while they are watching:**

This means that a slave should obey his master not only when the master was watching him, but all the time.

Paul was not saying that it was wrong for a slave to work to please his master, but he meant that pleasing their master should not be the only reason for hard work. He clarifies this in the rest of this verse.

#### 3:22c

##### **but with sincerity of heart and fear of the Lord.**

- But work sincerely all the time because you honor the Lord.
- But, since you respect the Lord Jesus, serve your master sincerely.

**but with sincerity of heart:** Slaves should obey and do their work sincerely and honestly, that is, with no hidden motives, not just so their masters will praise them.

**fear of the Lord:** The BSB translates this Greek word literally as fear. However, you should avoid a translation that means, “because you are afraid of the Lord.” In this context, this Greek word means the respect/awe that a person feels because of how great the Lord is. Because of this, in many languages it is best to translate phrases about “fearing the Lord” as “honoring the Lord,” or “respecting the Lord.”

**Lord:** Again this refers to the Lord Jesus.

## Colossians 3:23

### Section 3:18–4:1: Paul instructed husbands and wives, children and parents, slaves and masters

In this section, Paul continued to instruct the Colossians about the way that they should behave in order to please Christ. In this section, however, he was writing about how they should behave at home rather than within the Christian community. He gave instructions to six types of people: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. His message was the same for all:

1. That people should submit to those who had authority over them,
2. That those who had authority should be considerate toward those under them.

Paul gave instructions to wives in 3:18, to husbands in 3:19, to children in 3:20, to parents in 3:21, to slaves in 3:22, and to masters in 4:1. Make sure you begin each of these verses in the same way.

### Paragraph 3:22–4:1

Theme: Paul gave instructions to slaves and their masters: that slaves should obey their masters and do their work to honor Christ, and that masters should be just and fair in the way they treat their slaves.

This passage is similar to Ephesians 6:5–9. You should compare your translations of these two passages.

### 3:23

In 3:23, Paul continued to instruct slaves about the attitude they should show in their work.

### 3:23a

**Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being,**

- Whatever work you do, do it enthusiastically,

**work at it with your whole being:** This means, “to work eagerly, enthusiastically, willingly.”

### 3:23b

**for the Lord and not for men,**

- like those who are working for the Lord should work, not as if you were working only for people.
- as people who work to please the Lord Jesus, and not as people who are working to please other people.

**for the Lord and not for men:** The Greek word that the BSB translates for means “as if for,” that is, Paul was telling the slaves that they should do their work as if they were doing it for the Lord, not for people.

## Colossians 3:24

### Section 3:18–4:1: Paul instructed husbands and wives, children and parents, slaves and masters

In this section, Paul continued to instruct the Colossians about the way that they should behave in order to please Christ. In this section, however, he was writing about how they should behave at home rather than within the Christian community. He gave instructions to six types of people: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. His message was the same for all:

1. That people should submit to those who had authority over them,
2. That those who had authority should be considerate toward those under them.

Paul gave instructions to wives in 3:18, to husbands in 3:19, to children in 3:20, to parents in 3:21, to slaves in 3:22, and to masters in 4:1. Make sure you begin each of these verses in the same way.

### Paragraph 3:22–4:1

Theme: Paul gave instructions to slaves and their masters: that slaves should obey their masters and do their work to honor Christ, and that masters should be just and fair in the way they treat their slaves.

This passage is similar to Ephesians 6:5–9. You should compare your translations of these two passages.

### 3:24a

**because you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as your reward.**

- Do this since you know that the Lord will reward you and you will receive the blessings that he has promised to give to his people.
- Do your work well, because you know that the Lord Jesus will repay you for your work, that is, he will give you the good things he has prepared for his people.

**receive an inheritance from the Lord:** See the note on inheritance in 1:12b. To receive an inheritance means to receive the benefits that the Lord has promised to give his people.

**as your reward:** Paul was telling the slaves who are obedient that God would repay/reward them, that is, he would give them the good things/blessings they deserved because of the work they had done.

In this verse, reward and “inheritance” refer to the same thing. Here is one way to translate this part of the verse:

Remember that the Lord will reward you, that is, he will give you your share in the blessings he has prepared for all his people.

### 3:24b

#### **It is the Lord Christ you are serving.**

- Behave like this because Christ is the Lord you are really serving.
- Remember that Christ is the master whom you are serving.

**It is the Lord Christ you are serving:** Remember that in Greek the word kurios means, “Lord” and “master.” An appropriate way to translate this is to say:

The Master you are serving is Christ.

## **Colossians 3:25**

### **Section 3:18–4:1: Paul instructed husbands and wives, children and parents, slaves and masters**

In this section, Paul continued to instruct the Colossians about the way that they should behave in order to please Christ. In this section, however, he was writing about how they should behave at home rather than within the Christian community. He gave instructions to six types of people: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. His message was the same for all:

1. That people should submit to those who had authority over them,
2. That those who had authority should be considerate toward those under them.

Paul gave instructions to wives in 3:18, to husbands in 3:19, to children in 3:20, to parents in 3:21, to slaves in 3:22, and to masters in 4:1. Make sure you begin each of these verses in the same way.

### **Paragraph 3:22–4:1**

Theme: Paul gave instructions to slaves and their masters: that slaves should obey their masters and do their work to honor Christ, and that masters should be just and fair in the way they treat their slaves.

This passage is similar to Ephesians 6:5–9. You should compare your translations of these two passages.

### 3:25a

#### **Whoever does wrong will be repaid for his wrong,**

- So continue to work to please Christ, because God will punish anyone who keeps doing wrong,
- But if any of you keeps doing wrong, God will punish him in the manner he deserves,

#### **Whoever does wrong will be repaid for his wrong:**

In this verse Paul was warning slaves who might be lazy or try to steal from their masters or do other wrong things. Since Paul was still speaking directly to the slaves, in some languages it may be more natural to use the second person (“you”) here. For example:

But if any of you do wrong deeds, you will be repaid for your wrong.

**be repaid:** This is a passive, but Paul meant that God would repay them. This means that God would punish these people because of the wrong things they had done.

### 3:25b

#### **and there is no favoritism.**

- for God judges all people by the same rules/standard.
- for God judges everyone impartially.

**and there is no favoritism:** Paul said almost the same thing in Romans 2:11. (The same Greek word for favoritism is also used in Luke 20:21 and James 2:9.) Paul meant that God does not favor one person more than another. This means that he does not distinguish unjustly between people by treating some people better than others. He will judge every person fairly/impartially.

## **Colossians 4:1**

### **Section 3:18–4:1: Paul instructed husbands and wives, children and parents, slaves and masters**

In this section, Paul continued to instruct the Colossians about the way that they should behave in order to please Christ. In this section, however, he was writing about how they should behave at home rather than within the Christian community. He gave instructions to six types of people: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. His message was the same for all:

1. That people should submit to those who had authority over them,
2. That those who had authority should be considerate toward those under them.

Paul gave instructions to wives in 3:18, to husbands in 3:19, to children in 3:20, to parents in 3:21, to slaves in 3:22, and to masters in 4:1. Make sure you begin each of these verses in the same way.

### **Paragraph 3:22–4:1**

Theme: Paul gave instructions to slaves and their masters: that slaves should obey their masters and do

their work to honor Christ, and that masters should be just and fair in the way they treat their slaves.

This passage is similar to Ephesians 6:5–9. You should compare your translations of these two passages.

#### 4:1a

**Masters, supply your slaves with what is right and fair,**

- Masters, provide for your slaves justly and fairly,
- You masters, take care of your slaves and treat each one fairly,

**supply your slaves with what is right and fair:** Paul was writing not only about giving slaves things like food and clothing, but also about how masters should treat slaves. He said that masters should treat their slaves in a right and fair manner. There were no laws to protect slaves at that time—their masters could treat them in any way they chose. Paul was appealing to Christian slave owners to treat their slaves in a way that would please God.

**right:** The Greek word *dikaio*s that the BSB translates right means “just, righteous.”

**fair:** The Greek word *isotēs* that the BSB translates fair is similar in meaning to the word translated “right.” It means “equally.”

#### 4:1b

**since you know that you also have a Master in heaven.**

- because you know that you also serve a master in heaven.

**you also:** In Greek these words are emphatic. One way to express this emphasis in English is: “Even you who are masters, remember you also have a Master in heaven.”

**have a Master in heaven:** In some languages it is more natural to say, “you serve a Master in heaven,” or “you are slaves of a Master in heaven.”

**Master in heaven:** In 3:22 Paul told slaves to obey their “earthly masters.” Here he reminded Christian slave owners that they also have a Master. Of course, Paul meant the Lord Jesus who is in heaven. The context clarifies this, so you will probably not need to make this explicit. If you do need to make it explicit, here is one way you could do so:

Remember that you also serve a master who is in heaven. He is the Lord...

## Colossians 4:2

**Section 4:2–6: Paul asked the Colossians to pray for him, and told them how to speak to unbelievers**

In 3:18–4:1 Paul had given instructions to different groups of believers (wives, husbands, children, parents, slaves, and masters). Here in 4:2 Paul began to speak again to all the Colossian believers. He told them to continue praying, especially for him, and to speak wisely and kindly to those who did not believe in Christ.

### Paragraph 4:2–4

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to continue praying to God, and he asked them to pray for him (Paul) while they were praying.

#### 4:2a

**Devote yourselves to prayer,**

- ¶ Pray persistently,
- ¶ Continue to pray diligently,
- ¶ Never give up praying,

**Devote yourselves to prayer:** The Greek verb *proskartereō* that the BSB has translated Devote yourselves to can also mean, “to persist in doing something.” For example:

Be persistent in prayer (GNT)

The meaning of both translations is similar. Paul was instructing the Colossians to continue to pray faithfully, no matter what happened.

#### 4:2b

**being watchful and thankful,**

- and while you pray, continue to be/stay alert, and always thank God.

**being watchful and thankful:** The Greek literally says “being watchful in it in thanksgiving.” The words “in it” refer back to “prayer” in 4:2a. So Paul meant, “When you pray, be watchful and thankful.”

**being watchful:** It means “staying alert, and not becoming tired of praying.”

**thankful:** It may be necessary in your translation to say “thankful to God.”

## Colossians 4:3

**Section 4:2–6: Paul asked the Colossians to pray for him, and told them how to speak to unbelievers**

In 3:18–4:1 Paul had given instructions to different groups of believers (wives, husbands, children, parents, slaves, and masters). Here in 4:2 Paul began to

speak again to all the Colossian believers. He told them to continue praying, especially for him, and to speak wisely and kindly to those who did not believe in Christ.

#### Paragraph 4:2–4

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to continue praying to God, and he asked them to pray for him (Paul) while they were praying.

#### 4:3a

##### as you pray also for us,

- While you pray, pray also for us<sup>(excl)</sup>,

**as you pray also for us:** In the Greek text of this verse there is a word, *hama*, that means “together, at the same time.” The BSB and several other English versions have omitted this word. Paul was asking the Colossians to pray for him and his friends when they were praying for everything else. Here are some other ways to translate this word in context:

At the same time pray also for us (GNT)

and include us in your prayers (REB)

**us:** This referred to Paul and his friends who were with him.

#### 4:3b

##### that God may open to us a door for the word,

- that God will give us<sup>(excl)</sup> the opportunity to preach
- pray that God will make it possible for us<sup>(excl)</sup> to continue to preach,

**that God may open to us a door for the word:** This is a figure of speech. It means, “that God will give us the opportunity to continue to preach the gospel.” This same figure of speech is also found in 1 Corinthians 16:9 and 2 Corinthians 2:12. Some ways to translate this are:

pray that God will make a way for us to spread his message (CEV)

Pray that God will give us opportunities to preach the message about Christ.

#### 4:3c

##### so that we may proclaim the mystery of Christ,

- so that we<sup>(excl)</sup> can tell people this message about Christ, which they did not understand/know before.

- so we<sup>(excl)</sup> can declare this message about Christ, which God had not fully revealed to people in the past.

**the mystery of Christ:** See the note on 1:26a.

#### 4:3d

##### for which I am in chains.

- It is because I preached this message that I am in prison now.

**for which:** This refers back to “word” in 4:3b.

**I am in chains:** It is possible that Paul was bound or chained while he was in prison. However, I am in chains is probably just a figurative way to say, “I am in prison.”

So you can translate the meaning of 4:3d as

I am in prison now because I preached this message about Christ.

## Colossians 4:4

### Section 4:2–6: Paul asked the Colossians to pray for him, and told them how to speak to unbelievers

In 3:18–4:1 Paul had given instructions to different groups of believers (wives, husbands, children, parents, slaves, and masters). Here in 4:2 Paul began to speak again to all the Colossian believers. He told them to continue praying, especially for him, and to speak wisely and kindly to those who did not believe in Christ.

#### Paragraph 4:2–4

Theme: Paul told the Colossians to continue praying to God, and he asked them to pray for him (Paul) while they were praying.

#### 4:4

##### Pray that I may declare it clearly, as I should.

- So pray for me that I will continue to proclaim this message publicly as I know I should do, without being afraid.
- I want to continue to make this message known to many people, as I ought to do. So ask God to help me to do that.

**Pray that I may declare it clearly:** The Greek word *phaneroō*, that the BSB translates declare it clearly, means “reveal, make known, make plain, tell clearly.” Paul used this same Greek verb in 1:26 and in 3:4. In 1:26, he used it to refer to God’s secret plan that he (God) had hidden and not revealed (made known) to people in the past. In 3:4 he used it to refer to the relationship between Christ and Christians, which is

hidden now, but will be revealed (made known) when Christ returns. In both cases it means, “to tell clearly and publicly.” However, there are two ways to interpret it here:

1. The emphasis is on “proclaiming publicly.” This part of the verse therefore means “Pray that I may proclaim the message publicly,” or “Pray that I will make the message known to people.” (See NET, SSA.)
2. The emphasis is on “proclaiming clearly.” This part of the verse therefore means “Pray that I may proclaim the message clearly.”

Both of these are acceptable. Most translations use the word clearly here as the BSB has done, and so follow the second interpretation. However, since Paul, in 4:3–4, was again writing about revealing God’s secret plan, it is likely that the emphasis is on “publicly.” So the first interpretation is recommended (1).

**as I should:** Paul was asking people to pray that he would proclaim the message to many people because this was his duty (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, GW, NCV, REB, SSA). This means that Paul wanted to make sure he fulfilled his obligation to tell people about Christ.

## Colossians 4:5

### Section 4:2–6: Paul asked the Colossians to pray for him, and told them how to speak to unbelievers

In 3:18–4:1 Paul had given instructions to different groups of believers (wives, husbands, children, parents, slaves, and masters). Here in 4:2 Paul began to speak again to all the Colossian believers. He told them to continue praying, especially for him, and to speak wisely and kindly to those who did not believe in Christ.

#### Paragraph 4:5–6

Theme: Paul encouraged the Colossians always to speak wisely and kindly to those who did not believe in the Lord Jesus.

In 4:2–4 Paul asked the Colossians to pray that he would be able to proclaim the gospel to many people. Here in 4:5–6 he gave them advice about how they could preach the gospel to people they knew who were not believers. Paul never said explicitly in these verses, “tell these people about Jesus,” but that is obviously what he wanted the Colossians to do.

#### 4:5a

##### Act wisely toward outsiders,

- ¶ Behave wisely toward those who do not believe in the Lord Jesus.

- ¶ When you are with people who do not believe in Jesus, be wise about what you do.

**outsiders:** By outsiders, Paul meant non-Christians, people who did not believe in Jesus.

#### 4:5b

##### redeeming the time.

- Use every opportunity/circumstance to do this.

**redeeming the time:** Paul was specifically referring to the way the Colossians should use every opportunity/circumstance to help unbelievers, especially to help them to become believers.

In Ephesians 5:15–16 Paul wrote, “Pay careful attention, then, to how you walk, not as unwise but as wise, redeeming the time, because the days are evil.” The underlined words are the same as here in 4:5b. Compare your translations of these two passages and use similar wording. In both Ephesians 5:15–16 and Colossians 4:5, Paul was advising the Christians to behave as Christians should, and to take every opportunity to help those who were not Christians.

## Colossians 4:6

### Section 4:2–6: Paul asked the Colossians to pray for him, and told them how to speak to unbelievers

In 3:18–4:1 Paul had given instructions to different groups of believers (wives, husbands, children, parents, slaves, and masters). Here in 4:2 Paul began to speak again to all the Colossian believers. He told them to continue praying, especially for him, and to speak wisely and kindly to those who did not believe in Christ.

#### Paragraph 4:5–6

Theme: Paul encouraged the Colossians always to speak wisely and kindly to those who did not believe in the Lord Jesus.

In 4:2–4 Paul asked the Colossians to pray that he would be able to proclaim the gospel to many people. Here in 4:5–6 he gave them advice about how they could preach the gospel to people they knew who were not believers. Paul never said explicitly in these verses, “tell these people about Jesus,” but that is obviously what he wanted the Colossians to do.

#### 4:6a

##### Let your speech always be gracious,

- Always speak to them kindly/politely,

**Let your speech:** In your language you may need to translate the word speech as a sentence. For example:

When you talk to/with unbelievers

**always be gracious:** It is difficult to know exactly what Paul meant when he said that “conversation” should be always be gracious. Most English versions use words like “kind, pleasant.” SSA suggests words like “courteous, wise, thoughtful.” See also meaning 3 of “grace” in the glossary.

**4:6b**  
**seasoned with salt,**

- and say things that are effective/persuasive.
- so they will be interested in what you say.

**seasoned with salt:** This figure of speech is even more difficult to understand than “full of grace” in 4:6a. Paul was probably thinking about the manner in which believers should speak to unbelievers when sharing their faith. Conversation that is seasoned with salt is perhaps lively, witty speech. You probably should not keep this figure in your translation. Here are some ways to translate the meaning without the figure of speech:

interesting (GNT)

effective (NLT)

**4:6c**  
**so that you may know how to answer everyone.**

- If you do this, then you will learn/know how to answer anyone who questions you about what you believe.
- As a result, if anyone asks you about the gospel, you will know how to answer them well/wisely.

**so that you may know how to answer everyone:** This is the result of 4:6a–b. Paul was saying that if the Colossians were wise in the way they behaved towards unbelievers, and if when they spoke to them they were polite and said things to interest them, the result would be that they would know how to answer everyone.

**how to answer everyone:** That is, “you will know how to answer everyone who asks you about the gospel.”

The emphasis here is not on what they would say when answering questions asked by unbelievers, but rather on the manner in which they were to answer, that is, that they would know the best way to answer.

## Colossians 4:7

### Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings

#### Paragraph 4:7–9

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that he was sending Tychicus to them, and he would tell them all that had been happening to Paul and his friends.

#### 4:7a

**Tychicus will tell you all the news about me.**

- ¶ Tychicus will tell you all that has been happening to me.
- ¶ When Tychicus arrives there in Colossae, he will tell you everything that has been happening to me here.

**Tychicus:** Paul mentioned in these verses that Tychicus was traveling to Colossae. This probably implied that he would carry this letter from Paul with him.

Paul did not mention until 4:8 that Tychicus was coming to Colossae because he, Paul, had sent him. It may be necessary in some languages to supply this information at the beginning of 4:7. For example:

I have sent Tychicus to visit you, and he will tell you...

#### 4:7b

**He is a beloved brother,**

- He is a Christian brother whom I love.

**a beloved brother:** The Greek word that the BSB translates beloved literally means “one who is loved.” In your language, you may need to use a verb to translate this phrase. If you use a verb, it may be necessary for you to say who loved Tychicus. There are two possibilities:

1. Paul should be the subject. He was saying, “He is my Christian brother whom I love.”
2. Paul and his friends should be the subject, so Paul was saying, “He is our<sup>(excl)</sup> Christian brother whom we<sup>(excl)</sup> love.”

Both are possible and you should use whichever is most natural in your language.

**brother:** See the note on 1:1c.

#### 4:7c

**a faithful minister, and a fellow servant in the Lord.**

- He faithfully works and serves the Lord along with me.

**a faithful minister, and a fellow servant in the Lord:**

This is similar to the words Paul used to describe Ephraim in 1:7b, and 1:7c. See the notes on those verses.

**Colossians 4:8****Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings****Paragraph 4:7–9**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that he was sending Tychicus to them, and he would tell them all that had been happening to Paul and his friends.

**4:8a****I have sent him to you for this very purpose,**

- I have told him to go to visit you for this purpose,

**I have sent him to you:** In some languages a different verb is used for sending people somewhere than the verb used for sending things. Make sure you use the appropriate verb in your language.

Remember that when Paul wrote this letter, he and Tychicus were far away from Colossae, and it would be several weeks before the believers in Colossae read the letter. Not all languages will use the same tense for this sort of action. The possibilities are:

- Use a past tense: “I have sent him to you” because Paul had already sent him by the time the Colossians were reading the letter. (BSB, RSV, NASB, KJV)
- Use a present tense, as the NIV does. (NIV, GNT, CEV)
- Use a future tense: “I will send him to you” because Paul had not yet sent him at the moment when he was writing the letter.

Use the tense that would be most natural in your language.

**for this very purpose:** This means that Paul told Tychicus to go to Colossae for a special purpose. Paul told what this purpose was in 4:8b–c.

**4:8b****that you may know about us,**

- so that you will know how we<sup>(excl)</sup> are doing,
- so that you would learn from him what is happening to us<sup>(excl)</sup>,

**that you may know about us:** This is similar to 4:7a where Paul said that Tychicus would tell the Colossians “all the news about me.” Tychicus would tell the Colossians the news and so they would know what was happening to Paul and his friends.

**4:8c****and that he may encourage your hearts.**

- and also so that he might encourage/strengthen you in your faith.

**that he may encourage your hearts:** This is the second purpose for which Paul sent Tychicus to Colossae.

**encourage:** The Greek word that the BSB translates encourage has several different meanings. It can be translated “help, encourage, comfort, strengthen.” Paul used the same word in 2:2a (see the note there). Paul wanted Tychicus to help the Colossian believers by encouraging them and strengthening their faith.

**Colossians 4:9****Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings****Paragraph 4:7–9**

Theme: Paul told the Colossians that he was sending Tychicus to them, and he would tell them all that had been happening to Paul and his friends.

**4:9a****With him I am sending Onesimus,**

- I am sending him to you along with Onesimus.
- He will be traveling with Onesimus.

**Onesimus:** This is probably the same Onesimus that Paul wrote about in his letter to Philemon. Onesimus had been a slave of Philemon before he ran away to Rome where he met Paul and became a Christian.

**4:9b****our faithful and beloved brother, who is one of you.**

- Onesimus is a faithful Christian brother whom we<sup>(excl)</sup> love. He is your fellow townsman.
- You know Onesimus because he comes from your town. He is a fellow-believer who has been faithful to Jesus Christ, and we<sup>(excl)</sup> love him.

**our faithful...brother:** See the note on this in 1:2a.

**beloved brother:** See the note on 4:7b.

**who is one of you:** This probably means that Onesimus was also from Colossae, so it can be translated “your fellow townsman, one of your own people.”

**4:9c****They will tell you about everything here.**

- The two of them will tell you everything that is happening to us<sup>(excl)</sup> here.

## Colossians 4:10

### Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings

#### Paragraph 4:10–14

Theme: Paul wrote greetings to the Colossians from the friends who were with him.

#### 4:10a

**My fellow prisoner Aristarchus sends you greetings,**

- ¶ Aristarchus greets you. He is here in prison with me.
- ¶ Aristarchus, a fellow-believer who is here in prison with me, asked me to greet you for him.

**My fellow prisoner Aristarchus:** This man was from Thessalonica. He had traveled to Rome with Paul when Paul was a prisoner (Acts 27:3). While Paul was writing this letter, Aristarchus was in prison with Paul, either voluntarily, so he could help Paul, or because he too had been arrested.

#### 4:10b

**as does Mark the cousin of Barnabas.**

- Barnabas' cousin, Mark, also greets you.
- Mark, who is Barnabas' cousin, also asked me to greet you.

**Mark the cousin of Barnabas:** By using the word cousin, Paul meant that one of Mark's parents was the sibling of one of Barnabas' parents. Every language has its own way to refer to such a relationship. In some languages, there may be several terms for cousin in English/Greek, depending on whether the two men's mothers were sisters or their fathers were brothers. However, we do not know this specific information because Greek (and English) do not distinguish the terms in this way. If you need to know this for your language, you may have to use a more general term instead, like "Barnabas' relative."

#### 4:10c

**You have already received instructions about him: If he comes to you, welcome him.**

- You have already heard about Mark, so you know what to do: if he comes to you, welcome him.
- You have already received a letter about Mark, so if he comes to Colossae, welcome him and care for him.

**You have already received instructions about him:** Paul was reminding the Colossian believers that they have already received instructions about Mark.

**received instructions:** This means that at some time in the past, Paul or someone else had sent a message

introducing Mark and instructing them about what to do if he came to Colossae. If possible, translate this in a general way, such as "You have already received a letter about Mark," or "I know that you have already been told about Mark." Only if it is necessary in your language to say who told the Colossians, should you add this information. Then you could say,

I Paul have already sent a message about him.

**If he comes to you, welcome him:** When Paul wrote this letter, he was definitely planning to send Tychicus to Colossae. However he did not know if Mark would go to Colossae or not.

## Colossians 4:11

### Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings

#### Paragraph 4:10–14

Theme: Paul wrote greetings to the Colossians from the friends who were with him.

#### 4:11a

**Jesus, who is called Justus, also sends greetings.**

- Jesus, who is also called Justus, also greets you.
- Greetings also from Jesus, whom some people call by his other name, Justus.

**Jesus, who is called Justus:** This does not refer to Jesus Christ. Jesus is the Greek form of the Hebrew name Joshua, which was a common name for Jewish men. This is why the GNT uses the name Joshua here. However it is better to use Jesus as the rest of the major English versions do.

**who is called Justus:** It was also common at the time Paul lived for Jews to have a Roman or Greek name as well as a Jewish name. This friend of Paul named Jesus was also called Justus.

#### 4:11b

**These are the only Jews among my fellow workers for the kingdom of God,**

- These three men are the only Jewish believers here. They are working with me to spread the message about God's kingdom.
- These three men are the only Jewish Christians here among those who are working with me to teach people to submit to God and accept him as their king.

**for the kingdom of God:** The term kingdom of God (or kingdom of heaven) is used many times in Matthew, Mark, and Luke. See "kingdom of God" in KBT and

meaning 2 in the glossary. You should translate this term here in a similar way to the way you translated it in those books.

#### 4:11c

**and they have been a comfort to me.**

- They have greatly encouraged me.

## Colossians 4:12

**Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings**

### Paragraph 4:10–14

Theme: Paul wrote greetings to the Colossians from the friends who were with him.

#### 4:12a

**Epaphras, who is one of you and a servant of Christ Jesus, sends you greetings.**

- Epaphras, your fellow townsman, also greets you. He is a servant of Christ Jesus.

**Epaphras:** This is the same Epaphras that Paul mentioned in chapter 1. See the note on Epaphras in 1:7a.

**who is one of you:** This is the same thing that Paul said about Onesimus in 4:9b. See the note there.

**a servant of Christ Jesus:** See the note on 1:7b.

#### 4:12b

**He is always wrestling in prayer for you,**

- He prays often and earnestly for you.

**He is always wrestling in prayer for you:** To be wrestling in prayer is a figure of speech. It means, “He prays earnestly/fervently.” Epaphras prayed so fervently because he cared deeply about his friends in Colossae.

#### 4:12c

**so that you may stand mature and fully assured in the full will of God.**

- He prays that you will continue to be spiritually strong/mature, and that you will be very sure/confident about all that God wants you to do.

**so that you may stand mature and fully assured in the full will of God:** Scholars do not agree about how to connect the phrase in the full will of God to the rest of the verse. There are two main views:

1. It should be connected to fully assured, as in the BSB. See SSA. (BSB, GW, NET, NLT, REB).
2. It should be connected to the verb stand mature. This is what the NIV and GNT have done. (NIV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1) since it is the easiest way to understand the Greek text.

**stand:** This figure of speech means “to do something without changing or stopping.”

**mature:** The Greek word means, “to be full-grown, mature, complete, perfect.” Paul used the same word in 1:28c when he said, “so that we may present everyone perfect in Christ.” See the note on that verse. Here it means, “to be mature spiritually.” That is, Epaphras had been praying that the Colossians would become mature Christians, strong in their faith. If they were spiritually mature, the false teachers would not easily persuade them to believe the false teaching.

**fully assured in the full will of God:** Most scholars interpret this to mean, “very sure, completely confident, fully convinced.” In 2:2 Paul used the noun form of this same word. See the note about “full riches” in 2:2c. As stated above, these words are connected to the phrase in the full will of God. Epaphras had prayed that the Colossians would be “completely sure” about what God wanted them to do and believe.

## Colossians 4:13

**Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings**

### Paragraph 4:10–14

Theme: Paul wrote greetings to the Colossians from the friends who were with him.

#### 4:13a

**For I testify about him that he goes to great pains for you**

- I can assure you that he is working hard to help you
- He is here with me, so I know from personal experience that he has worked very hard on your behalf

**For I testify about him:** The Greek verb *martureō* that the BSB translates I testify about literally means “I witness” or “I testify.” It means that because Paul had personally seen and heard what Epaphras was doing, he could assure the Colossian believers that Epaphras was working hard on behalf of the Colossians and others.

**he goes to great pains for you:** The Greek translated literally says “he has much pain/labor for you.” There are two ways to interpret these words:

1. Paul was referring to the hard work that Epaphras was doing to help the Colossians. (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, GW, NCV, NET, REB)

2. Paul was referring to the strong emotions that Epaphras felt because he was concerned about the Colossians. See SSA. (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), since the Greek word *ponos* most naturally means “work,” not “concern.” This is also the interpretation preferred by the majority of commentators. Paul did not specify the sort of work Epaphras was doing on behalf of the Colossians, but it presumably included praying for them (4:12). You could translate this:

I can assure you that he is working hard to help you,

Do not try to explain what kind of work Epaphras was doing.

#### 4:13b

**and for those at Laodicea and Hierapolis.**

- and also for those Christians who live in the towns of Laodicea and Hierapolis.

**Laodicea and Hierapolis:** These were towns along the same river as Colossae, to the west. It is possible that Epaphras had already preached in these towns also.

## Colossians 4:14

**Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings**

### Paragraph 4:10–14

Theme: Paul wrote greetings to the Colossians from the friends who were with him.

#### 4:14

**Luke, the beloved physician, and Demas send you greetings.**

- Luke, the doctor, whom I/we<sup>(excl)</sup> love, sends you greetings. So does Demas.

**Luke, the beloved physician:** The word beloved is the same word that Paul used about Tychicus in 4:7b and about Onesimus in 4:9b. See the notes on these verses. Luke had often traveled with Paul on his journeys.

## Colossians 4:15

**Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings**

### Paragraph 4:15–17

Theme: Paul gave the Colossians some final instructions.

#### 4:15a

**Greet the brothers in Laodicea,**

- ¶ Greet our<sup>(incl)</sup> Christian brothers and sisters who live in the town of Laodicea on my behalf.
- ¶ Tell our<sup>(incl)</sup> fellow believers from Laodicea that I greet them.

**brothers:** See the note on 1:2a.

#### 4:15b

**as well as Nympha and the church that meets at her house.**

- Also greet Nympha for me, and all the Christians who meet in her house.

#### **Nympha and the church that meets at her house:**

Nympha is a woman's name. If your language uses the same pronoun for “his” and “her,” it may not be clear in your translation that Nympha was a woman. This is acceptable. You do not have to make this information explicit unless there is a natural way to do so. One way to do this is to use a form of the name Nympha that would be used only for women's names.

**the church that meets at her house:** See the note on 1:18a and the word “church” in the glossary. Remember that the Greek word *ekklēsia*, which is usually translated church in English, means “assembly, congregation.” It never refers to a building. When Paul was writing this letter, Christians did not meet in special buildings. They usually met in people's houses.

## Colossians 4:16

**Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings**

### Paragraph 4:15–17

Theme: Paul gave the Colossians some final instructions.

#### 4:16a

**After this letter has been read among you,**

- After you believers in Colossae have heard this letter of mine,
- After someone has read this letter to you,

**After this letter has been read among you:** In the first century many people did not know how to read. So most people in Colossae could not read this letter for themselves. They listened while someone else read the letter to the group.

#### 4:16b

**make sure that it is also read in the church of the Laodiceans,**

- make sure that someone also reads it to the Christians in the town of Laodicea.
- send it on to the community of believers in Laodicea and tell them to read it also.

**make sure that it is also read in the church of the Laodiceans:** The phrase the BSB uses, make sure, is an idiom in English. It means, “make certain that.” This is also the meaning of the Greek phrase. Paul was telling the Colossians that they must make sure that the believers in Laodicea also had an opportunity to read this letter.

#### 4:16c

**and that you in turn read the letter from Laodicea.**

- Also, make sure that you read the letter that I wrote to the Christians at Laodicea.
- I have also sent a letter to the believers in Laodicea. Be sure to ask them for it and read it.

**the letter from Laodicea:** There are two ways to understand this phrase:

1. It means “the letter that I wrote to the believers in Laodicea.” Paul wanted the Colossians to ask the Laodicean believers for the letter that Paul had written to them, so they could read it too. (CEV, NCV, NLT, REB)
2. It means, “the letter the Laodiceans will write to you.” Paul knew that the Laodiceans were planning to write to the Colossians and he was telling them to make sure they read that letter. (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1). The majority of commentators agree that this is the correct interpretation. Paul was referring to a letter he had written to the Christians in Laodicea. Unfortunately, a copy of this letter has never been found.

## Colossians 4:17

**Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings**

### Paragraph 4:15–17

Theme: Paul gave the Colossians some final instructions.

#### 4:17a

**Tell Archippus:**

- Say to Archippus:
- Here is a message for Archippus:

**Tell Archippus:** Archippus was a man who lived in Colossae. In this verse Paul wrote a message especially to him. Paul did not explain what work or ministry Archippus had, but he wanted to encourage Archippus to be faithful in his ministry.

#### 4:17b

**“See to it that you complete the ministry you have received in the Lord.”**

- “Make sure that you<sup>(sing)</sup> finish the job/ministry which the Lord has entrusted to you<sup>(sing)</sup>.”
- “The Lord has given you<sup>(sing)</sup> a task to do. Make sure you<sup>(sing)</sup> do it.”

**See to it:** This means almost the same thing as “make sure that” in 4:16b. See the note there. Here are some ways you can translate it:

Make sure

Be careful

You must

**the ministry you have received in the Lord:** There are two main possibilities about what Paul meant when he said that Archippus had received a ministry in the Lord:

1. It means “the work the Lord gave you.” The Lord was the one who gave him the job. For example:

Be sure to carry out the work the Lord gave you (NLT) (CEV, NCV, NJB, NLT)

1. It means “the work you have received as one who is united to the Lord,” or “to serve the Lord,” or “as a Christian worker.” For example:

Be sure to finish the task you were given in the Lord’s service (GNT) (GNT, GW, REB, SSA)

Either of these interpretations is acceptable. The Display follows the first one (1). If you prefer to follow the second one (2), you could say:

Make sure you complete the task that you were given as the Lord’s servant.

**the ministry:** The Greek word *diakonia* that the BSB translates ministry is the word used for service or ministry within the Christian congregation. Paul did not explain what kind of work the Lord had given to Archippus, but he was definitely writing about something Archippus was to do within the Christian community, not work like farming.

## Colossians 4:18

### Section 4:7–18: Paul wrote final messages and greetings

#### Paragraph 4:18

Theme: Paul wrote this final greeting himself so that the Colossians would know that this letter was from him. He reminded them to pray for him there in prison.

#### 4:18a

##### This greeting is in my own hand—Paul.

- ¶ I, Paul, am writing this part of the letter in my own handwriting to greet you so that you will know that this letter is really from me.
- ¶ I had someone else write down this letter for me, but these last words I myself am writing: Greetings from me, Paul.

**my own hand:** Most commentators agree that Paul dictated most of his letter to someone else, and this person wrote his words down. But Paul wrote these last words himself so that the readers would know that the letter really did come from him.

#### 4:18b

##### Remember my chains.

- Remember that I am in prison and pray for me.

**Remember my chains:** The word chains is a figure of speech meaning that Paul was a prisoner. But Paul was not simply reminding the Colossians that he was a prisoner. He was also reminding them to pray for him while he was a prisoner, as he had asked them to do in 4:3–4.

#### 4:18c

##### Grace be with you.

- May the Lord Jesus be gracious/kind to you.
- I pray that God will continue to bless you.

**Grace be with you:** Paul ended most of his letters with these words or similar words. You should translate these words in a similar way at the end of every letter where they occur. (See 1 Corinthians 16:23, 2 Corinthians 13:14, Galatians 5:18, Ephesians 6:24, Philippians 4:23, 1 Thessalonians 5:28, 2 Thessalonians 3:18, 1 Timothy 6:21, 2 Timothy 4:22, Titus 3:15, Philemon 25.) These words are a wish or a prayer. In some languages it may be necessary to include the words “I ask...” or “I pray...” For example:

I pray that God will be kind to you. (CEV)

I ask God to bless you.

Paul did not say explicitly to whose Grace he was referring. However, in your translation, it may be necessary for you to make this information explicit. Some English versions refer to “God’s grace” (GNT, CEV, GW, NLT). However, at the end of most of his other letters, Paul says “the grace of the Lord Jesus,” or “the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ,” so it is acceptable to use either “God” or “Jesus” in your translation.

See also meaning 1 of “grace” in the glossary.